MATH2121: Linear Algebra

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1 Linear Systems and Matrices

1.1 Notation

- $\mathbb{R}$: real numbers.
- $\mathbb{Q}$: rational numbers $\frac{p}{q}$.
- $\mathbb{Z}$: integers $\{\ldots, -2, -1, 0, 1, 2, \ldots\}$.
- $\mathbb{N}$: nonnegative integers $\{0, 1, 2, \ldots\}$.

1.2 Systems of Linear Equations

Definition. A *linear equation* in variables $x_1, x_2, \ldots, x_n$ is an equation of the form

$$a_1x_1 + a_2x_2 + \cdots + a_nx_n = b$$

where $a_1, \ldots, a_n, b \in \mathbb{R}$. Equivalently, $\sum_{i=1}^{n} a_ix_i = b$.

Example. The following are linear equations in x_1, x_2, x_3:

$$3x_1 = 2x_2, \quad 3x_1 + 4x_2 - \sqrt{2}x_3 = 7, \quad 0 = 0, \quad 0 = 1.$$

The following are **not** linear equations:

$$3x_1^2 + 4x_2 = 7, \quad x_1x_2 = x_3, \quad \sqrt{x_1} = x_2.$$

Definition. A *system of linear equations* (or *linear system*) is a list of linear equations in the same set of variables. A *solution* is a list $(s_1, \ldots, s_n)$ such that substituting $x_i = s_i$ makes all equations true. A solution is *nonzero* if at least one $s_i \neq 0$.

Definition. Two linear systems are *equivalent* if they have the same set of solutions.

Number of solutions

Theorem. A linear system (in any number of variables) has either 0, 1, or infinitely many solutions.

Proof (algebraic). Suppose the linear system has two distinct solutions $\vec{s} = (s_1, \ldots, s_n)$ and $\vec{r} = (r_1, \ldots, r_n)$, so $\vec{s} \neq \vec{r}$. Consider the associated *homogeneous system*, obtained by replacing each b_i with 0. For each equation $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij}x_j = b_i$, since $\vec{s}$ and $\vec{r}$ are both solutions we have $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij}s_j = b_i$ and $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij}r_j = b_i$. Subtracting gives $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij}(s_j - r_j) = 0$, so $\vec{s} - \vec{r} = (s_1 - r_1, \ldots, s_n - r_n)$ is a nonzero solution of the homogeneous system. Let $\vec{t} = \vec{s} - \vec{r} \neq \vec{0}$. For any scalar $c \in \mathbb{R}$, the vector $\vec{r} + c\vec{t}$ satisfies $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij}(r_j + ct_j) = b_i + c \cdot 0 = b_i$, so $\vec{r} + c\vec{t}$ is a solution. As c ranges over $\mathbb{R}$, the vectors $\vec{r}, \vec{r} + \vec{t}, \vec{r} + 2\vec{t}, \vec{r} + 3\vec{t}, \ldots$ are all distinct (since $\vec{t} \neq \vec{0}$), giving infinitely many solutions. Hence a system with at least two solutions has infinitely many. Therefore the only possibilities are 0, 1, or infinitely many solutions. ■

Proof (geometric). Each equation $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij}x_j = b_i$ defines a hyperplane in $\mathbb{R}^n$. The solution set is the intersection of all these hyperplanes. If the intersection is empty, there are 0 solutions. If the intersection is a single point, there is 1 solution. If the intersection contains two distinct points $\vec{s}$ and $\vec{r}$, then the entire line $\{\vec{r} + c(\vec{s} - \vec{r}) : c \in \mathbb{R}\}$ lies in the intersection (each hyperplane, containing two points of the line, contains the whole line), giving infinitely many solutions. ■

Definition. A linear system is *consistent* if it has at least one solution, and *inconsistent* if it has zero solutions.

1.3 Matrices

Definition. A *matrix* is a rectangular array of numbers. A matrix is $m \times n$ (or m-by-n) if it has m rows and n columns. We write A_{ij} for the entry in the ith row and jth column.

Definition. Given a linear system

$$\begin{aligned} a_{11}x_1 + \cdots + a_{1n}x_n &= b_1 \\ &\vdots \\ a_{m1}x_1 + \cdots + a_{mn}x_n &= b_m \end{aligned}$$

the *coefficient matrix* is $\begin{pmatrix} a_{11} & \cdots & a_{1n} \\ \vdots & & \vdots \\ a_{m1} & \cdots & a_{mn} \end{pmatrix}$ and the *augmented matrix* is

$$\begin{pmatrix} a_{11} & \cdots & a_{1n} & b_1 \\ \vdots & & \vdots & \vdots \\ a_{m1} & \cdots & a_{mn} & b_m \end{pmatrix}.$$

The coefficient matrix is $m \times n$; the augmented matrix is $m \times (n+1)$.

1.4 Elementary Row Operations

Definition. The *elementary row operations* on a matrix are:

1. **Replacement:** Replace a row by the sum of itself and a multiple of another row.
2. **Scaling:** Multiply a row by a nonzero number.
3. **Interchange:** Swap two rows.

Definition. Two matrices are *row equivalent* if one can be transformed to the other by a sequence of zero or more row operations.

Each row operation is reversible

- Scaling by $c \leftrightarrow$ scaling by $\frac{1}{c}$.
- Swapping rows i and $j \leftrightarrow$ swapping rows i and j.
- Replacing row i by (row i + $c\cdot$ row j) $\leftrightarrow$ replacing row i by (row i − $c\cdot$ row j).

Row equivalence preserves solutions

Theorem. If the augmented matrices of two linear systems are row equivalent, then the systems are equivalent (i.e., have the same solutions).

Proof. It suffices to show that a single elementary row operation on the augmented matrix produces a new system with the same solution set. There are three cases. Let the

original augmented matrix correspond to the system $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij}x_j = b_i$ for $i = 1, \ldots, m$.

1. **Replacement:** Replace row i by (row i + $c\cdot$ row k) with $k \neq i$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}$. The ith equation becomes $\sum_{j=1}^{n}(a_{ij} + c\,a_{kj})x_j = b_i + c\,b_k$. If $\vec{s}$ solves the original system, then $\sum a_{ij}s_j = b_i$ and $\sum a_{kj}s_j = b_k$, so $\sum(a_{ij} + c\,a_{kj})s_j = b_i + c\,b_k$, meaning $\vec{s}$ solves the new system. Conversely, if $\vec{s}$ solves the new system, then $\sum(a_{ij} + c\,a_{kj})s_j = b_i + c\,b_k$, and using $\sum a_{kj}s_j = b_k$ (the kth equation is unchanged) we recover $\sum a_{ij}s_j = b_i$. So the solution sets are equal.
2. **Scaling:** Multiply row i by $c \neq 0$. The ith equation becomes $\sum_{j=1}^{n}(c\,a_{ij})x_j = c\,b_i$, i.e., $c\sum a_{ij}x_j = cb_i$. Since $c \neq 0$, dividing by c recovers the original equation, so the solution sets are equal.
3. **Interchange:** Swap rows i and k. This merely reorders the equations, which does not change the solution set (a list $(s_1, \ldots, s_n)$ satisfies all equations regardless of their order).

Since each elementary row operation preserves the solution set, any sequence of them (i.e., row equivalence) preserves the solution set. ■

1.5 Echelon Form and RREF

Definition. A row in a matrix is *nonzero* if not every entry is zero. The *leading entry* in a nonzero row is the first nonzero entry (from left to right).

Definition. A matrix with m rows and n columns is in *echelon form* if:

(E1) When a row is nonzero, every row above it is also nonzero.
(E2) The leading entry in a nonzero row is strictly to the right of the leading entry of any earlier row.

These imply:

(E3) If a row is nonzero, then every entry below its leading entry in the same column is zero.

Definition. A matrix in echelon form is *reduced* if:

(R1) Each nonzero row has leading entry 1.
(R2) The leading 1 in each nonzero row is the only nonzero number in its column.

Such a matrix is said to be in *reduced echelon form*.

Uniqueness of RREF

Theorem. Each matrix A is row equivalent to exactly one matrix RREF(A) in reduced echelon form, called the *reduced echelon form* of A.

Proof. Existence follows from the row reduction algorithm, which produces a reduced echelon form. We prove uniqueness. Suppose A is row equivalent to two reduced echelon matrices R and S. Since R and S are both row equivalent to A, they are row equivalent to each other. We show $R = S$ by induction on the number of columns. The key idea: the pivot columns of any echelon form of A are in the same positions (this can be shown by induction on the number of pivot columns, since the leftmost nonzero column must contain a pivot in both R and S, and reducing the submatrix below that pivot column gives the same structure recursively). So R and S have pivots in the same positions. In a

reduced echelon form, each pivot column is a standard basis vector $\vec{e}_i$ (with 1 in the pivot row and 0 elsewhere). Since R and S have the same pivot positions, each pivot column of R equals the corresponding pivot column of S. For a non-pivot column, its entries are determined: the entry in a pivot row equals the coefficient needed to express that column as a linear combination of the pivot columns to its left, which is uniquely determined by the column itself and the pivot columns. Since both R and S are obtained from A by row operations (which preserve linear relations among columns), the non-pivot columns of R and S coincide. Therefore $R = S$. ■

1.6 Solving a Linear System from RREF

Definition. A *pivot position* in a matrix A is the location containing a leading 1 in $\text{RREF}(A)$. A *pivot column* is a column containing a pivot position. An entry in a pivot position is called a *pivot*.

Definition. For a linear system in variables $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ with augmented matrix A, the variable x_i is *basic* if i is a pivot column of A, and *free* otherwise.

Solutions from RREF

Theorem. Consider a linear system whose augmented matrix is A.

- The system has **0 solutions** if the last column of A contains a pivot (i.e., $\text{RREF}(A)$ has a row $(0 \quad \cdots \quad 0 \quad 1)$, giving the false equation $0 = 1$).
- The system has **1 solution** if there are no free variables and the last column is not a pivot.
- The system has **infinitely many solutions** otherwise (i.e., the last column is not a pivot but there is at least one free variable).

Proof. Row-reduce A to $\text{RREF}(A) = R$. By the previous theorem, R represents an equivalent system with the same solution set.

1. If the last column of R is a pivot column, then some row of R is $(0 \quad \cdots \quad 0 \quad 1)$, corresponding to the equation $0 = 1$, which has no solution. So the system is inconsistent: 0 solutions.
2. If the last column is not a pivot and there are no free variables, then every variable $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ is basic (each corresponds to a pivot column). Each basic variable is uniquely determined (e.g., $x_i = b_i$ for some determined value b_i), so there is exactly one solution.
3. If the last column is not a pivot but there is at least one free variable, then the system is consistent (no row $(0 \quad \cdots \quad 0 \quad 1)$) and each free variable can take any real value. For each assignment of the free variables, the basic variables are uniquely determined. Since there is at least one free variable ranging over $\mathbb{R}$, there are infinitely many solutions.

These three cases are exhaustive and mutually exclusive. ■

General solution procedure. After computing $\text{RREF}(A)$:

1. Identify basic and free variables.
2. Write each basic variable in terms of the free variables.
3. Choose arbitrary values for free variables; solve for basic variables.

Corollary. If

$$\text{RREF}(A) = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 & b_1 \\ 0 & 1 & \cdots & 0 & b_2 \\ \vdots & & \ddots & & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & \cdots & 1 & b_m \end{pmatrix},$$

then the unique solution is $(x_1, \ldots, x_m) = (b_1, \ldots, b_m)$.

Proof. The RREF shows each variable is a basic variable (every column $1, \ldots, m$ is a pivot column) and the last column is not a pivot. By the previous theorem, there is exactly one solution. Reading off the RREF, the ith equation is $x_i = b_i$ (the leading 1 in column i gives x_i plus zeros from other entries). So $x_i = b_i$ for all i, giving the unique solution $(x_1, \ldots, x_m) = (b_1, \ldots, b_m)$. ■

1.7 Row Reduction Algorithm

Algorithm (Row reduction to echelon form). Input: an $m \times n$ matrix A.

1. Begin with the leftmost nonzero column. This is a pivot column; the pivot position is the top position.
2. Select a nonzero entry in the current pivot column. If needed, swap its row to the top.
3. Use row operations to create zeros below the pivot position.
4. Cover the row containing the current pivot; apply steps 1–3 to the remaining $(m-1) \times n$ submatrix. Repeat until the entire matrix is in echelon form.
5. Starting from the rightmost pivot, rescale to leading entry 1, then create zeros *above* each pivot. Repeat going right to left.

Output: RREF(A).

Pivot positions are invariant

In any echelon form E of a matrix A, the locations of the leading entries are the same. Thus pivot positions can be found from *any* echelon form—one need not fully reduce to find pivots.

Practice Problem #1.14 (RREF classification of ± 1 matrices)

Problem. Let X be the set of all 3×3 matrices whose entries are $+1$ or -1 (there are $2^9 = 512$ such matrices). What forms can $E = \text{RREF}(A)$ take as A ranges over X? For each such E, exactly how many matrices $A \in X$ have $\text{RREF}(A) = E$?

Solution. There are 11 possible reduced echelon forms. The key trick is *row-first normalization*: multiply every row whose first entry is -1 by -1 (this is an elementary row operation and does not change RREF). The normalized rows all begin with 1 and can only be

$$v_1 = (1 \quad 1 \quad 1)^\top, \; v_2 = (1 \quad 1 \quad -1)^\top, \; v_3 = (1 \quad -1 \quad 1)^\top, \; v_4 = (1 \quad -1 \quad -1)^\top.$$

Each ordered triple of normalized rows comes from exactly $2^3 = 8$ original matrices, because each row can independently have either sign. We count by cases:

- *One distinct normalized row.* All three normalized rows are equal. The RREF is $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & \epsilon & \eta \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ with $\epsilon, \eta \in \{\pm 1\}$. There are 4 such reduced forms, each with $4 \cdot 8 = 32$ original matrices.
- *Two distinct normalized rows.* The non-zero part of RREF belongs to one of $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & \epsilon & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & \epsilon \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$, $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & \epsilon \end{pmatrix}$. This gives 6 more reduced forms, each with 48 original matrices ($\binom{4}{2} = 6$ pairs, minus the 2 constant triples per pair, times 8).
- *Three distinct normalized rows.* Among any three distinct types, two have the same second coordinate and the opposite third. After one row swap and row reduction, all three pivots are nonzero, giving RREF I_3. There are $4 \cdot 3 \cdot 2 \cdot 8 = 192$ such original matrices.

Check: $32 + 6 \cdot 48 + 192 = 512$, consistent.

Clever trick: row-first normalization

When matrix entries have sign symmetry (like ± 1 rows), multiply rows to force a uniform sign in the first non-zero entry. This is an elementary row operation that does *not* change RREF, but dramatically reduces case work. Each normalized matrix corresponds to 2^m originals (independent sign choices per row), so counts are recovered post-hoc.

Practice Problem #1.15 (RREF of $M_{ij} = i + j$)

Problem. Let M be the $n \times n$ matrix with $M_{ij} = i + j$. Find $\mathrm{RREF}(M)$.

Solution. Let $\vec{u} = (1 \quad 1 \quad \cdots \quad 1)^\top$. The original ith row is $\vec{r}_i = (i+1, i+2, \ldots, i+n) = \vec{r}_1 + (i-1)\vec{u}$. Row-reduce:

1. $R_2 \leftarrow R_2 - R_1$, turning R_2 into $\vec{u}$;
2. for $i \geq 3$, $R_i \leftarrow R_i - R_1 - (i-1)R_2$; all these rows become zero.

The first two rows are now $\vec{r}_1 = (2, 3, \ldots, n+1)$ and $\vec{u} = (1, 1, \ldots, 1)$. Then $R_1 \leftarrow R_1 - 2R_2$ gives $(0, 1, \ldots, n-1)$. Exchange R_1 and R_2, eliminate the leading entries in column 1, and the final RREF is

$$\mathrm{RREF}(M) = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 & \cdots & 2-n \\ 0 & 1 & 2 & \cdots & n-1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \vdots & & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \end{pmatrix},$$

with exactly $n-2$ zero rows. Special cases: $n = 1$ gives (1), $n = 2$ gives I_2.

Clever trick: eliminate rows first, then columns

When rows are simple linear combinations of a few fixed vector patterns, first row-reduce all high rows to zero and only then fully reduce the survivors. This avoids chasing pivots column by column.

2 Vectors and Linear Combinations

2.1 Vectors

Definition. A *(column) vector* of size n is an $n \times 1$ matrix: $\vec{v} = \begin{pmatrix} v_1 \\ v_2 \\ \vdots \\ v_n \end{pmatrix}$. We write $\mathbb{R}^n$ for the set of all vectors with exactly n rows. Each v_i is a real number.

Vector operations:

- *Addition* (same size only): $\begin{pmatrix} v_1 \\ \vdots \\ v_n \end{pmatrix} + \begin{pmatrix} u_1 \\ \vdots \\ u_n \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} v_1 + u_1 \\ \vdots \\ v_n + u_n \end{pmatrix}$.
- *Scalar multiplication* ($c \in \mathbb{R}$): $c \begin{pmatrix} v_1 \\ \vdots \\ v_n \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} cv_1 \\ \vdots \\ cv_n \end{pmatrix}$.
- *Subtraction*: $\vec{u} - \vec{v} = \vec{u} + (-1)\vec{v}$.

Definition. The *zero vector* in $\mathbb{R}^n$ is $\vec{0} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$. We always have $\vec{0} + \vec{v} = \vec{v} + \vec{0} = \vec{v}$.

Geometric intuition in $\mathbb{R}^2$

A vector $\begin{pmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \end{pmatrix}$ is drawn as an arrow from the origin to (a_1, a_2). The sum $\vec{a} + \vec{b}$ is the diagonal of the parallelogram with sides $\vec{a}$ and $\vec{b}$.

2.2 Linear Combinations and Span

Definition. If $\vec{v}_1, \vec{v}_2, \ldots, \vec{v}_p \in \mathbb{R}^n$ and $c_1, \ldots, c_p \in \mathbb{R}$ (scalars), then

$$\vec{y} = c_1\vec{v}_1 + c_2\vec{v}_2 + \cdots + c_p\vec{v}_p$$

is a *linear combination* of $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p$ with coefficients $c_1, \ldots, c_p$.

Definition. The *span* of vectors $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p \in \mathbb{R}^n$ is the set of all their linear combinations:

$$\text{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\} = \{c_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + c_p\vec{v}_p : c_1, \ldots, c_p \in \mathbb{R}\} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n.$$

Span $\Leftrightarrow$ consistent system

Proposition. A vector equation $x_1\vec{a}_1 + x_2\vec{a}_2 + \cdots + x_n\vec{a}_n = \vec{b}$ (where $\vec{a}_1, \ldots, \vec{a}_n, \vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$) has the same solutions as the linear system with augmented matrix $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{a}_1 & \vec{a}_2 & \cdots & \vec{a}_n & \vec{b} \end{pmatrix}$.

Proof. Write each vector $\vec{a}_j = \begin{pmatrix} a_{1j} \\ a_{2j} \\ \vdots \\ a_{mj} \end{pmatrix}$ and $\vec{b} = \begin{pmatrix} b_1 \\ b_2 \\ \vdots \\ b_m \end{pmatrix}$. The vector equation $x_1\vec{a}_1 + x_2\vec{a}_2 + \cdots + x_n\vec{a}_n = \vec{b}$ means, in the ith coordinate, $\sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{ij}x_j = b_i$ for $i = 1, \ldots, m$. But these are exactly the m equations of the linear system with coefficient matrix (a_{ij}) and augmented matrix $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{a}_1 & \vec{a}_2 & \cdots & \vec{a}_n & \vec{b} \end{pmatrix}$. Therefore a list $(s_1, \ldots, s_n)$ satisfies the vector equation if and only if it satisfies each of the m scalar equations, i.e., it is a solution of the linear system. The two have identical solution sets. ■

Corollary. $\vec{b} \in \text{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\}$ if and only if the matrix $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{v}_1 & \vec{v}_2 & \cdots & \vec{v}_p & \vec{y} \end{pmatrix}$ is the augmented matrix of a consistent linear system (i.e., the last column is not a pivot column).

Proof. By definition, $\vec{b} \in \text{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\}$ if and only if there exist scalars $x_1, \ldots, x_p$ with $\vec{b} = x_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + x_p\vec{v}_p$, i.e., the vector equation has a solution. By the proposition, this is equivalent to the linear system with augmented matrix $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{v}_1 & \cdots & \vec{v}_p & \vec{b} \end{pmatrix}$ having a solution, i.e., being consistent. By the RREF criterion, a system is consistent if and only if the last column of the augmented matrix is not a pivot column (no row $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & \cdots & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$). ■

Span of a single vector

$\text{span}\{\vec{0}\} = \{\vec{0}\}$ (a single point). For $\vec{v} \neq \vec{0}$, $\text{span}\{\vec{v}\} = \{c\vec{v} : c \in \mathbb{R}\}$ is the line through the origin in the direction of $\vec{v}$. This is infinite unless $\vec{v} = \vec{0}$.

Geometric picture of span.

- In $\mathbb{R}^2$: span is a point, a line through origin, or all of $\mathbb{R}^2$.
- In $\mathbb{R}^3$: span is a point, a line through origin, a plane through origin, or all of $\mathbb{R}^3$.

Practice Problem #2.14 (Span is idempotent)

Problem. Interpret the statement "for any $S \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$, $\operatorname{span}(\operatorname{span} S) = \operatorname{span} S$" and prove it formally.
Solution. Taking linear combinations twice produces nothing new beyond taking them once. Let $W = \operatorname{span} S$.
$W \subseteq \operatorname{span} W$: every $\vec{w} \in W$ is a linear combination of vectors in W, namely $\vec{w} = 1 \cdot \vec{w}$, so this is trivial.

$\operatorname{span} W \subseteq W$: let $\vec{u} \in \operatorname{span} W$. By definition, $\vec{u} = \sum_{j=1}^{m} a_j \vec{w}_j$ with $\vec{w}_j \in W$. Each $\vec{w}_j = \sum_{i=1}^{r_j} b_{ji} \vec{s}_{ji}$ with $\vec{s}_{ji} \in S$. Substitute:

$$\vec{u} = \sum_{j=1}^{m} a_j \sum_{i=1}^{r_j} b_{ji} \vec{s}_{ji} = \sum_{\text{all } (j,i)} (a_j b_{ji}) \vec{s}_{ji},$$

a finite linear combination of vectors from S, hence $\vec{u} \in W$. If $S = \emptyset$, both sides equal $\{\vec{0}\}$.

Key intuition

$\operatorname{span} S$ is by definition a subspace, and subspaces are exactly the sets already closed under linear combinations. So applying span a second time does nothing. This trivial-sounding property underlies many results: the basis theorem, rank-nullity, etc.

3 Matrix Equations and Matrix Operations

3.1 Matrix-Vector Product

Definition. If A is an $m \times n$ matrix with columns $\vec{a}_1, \vec{a}_2, \ldots, \vec{a}_n \in \mathbb{R}^m$ and $\vec{v} = \begin{pmatrix} v_1 \\ \vdots \\ v_n \end{pmatrix} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, then the *matrix-vector product* $A\vec{v}$ is the vector in $\mathbb{R}^m$ given by:

$$A\vec{v} = \begin{pmatrix} \vec{a}_1 & \vec{a}_2 & \cdots & \vec{a}_n \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} v_1 \\ v_2 \\ \vdots \\ v_n \end{pmatrix} = v_1\vec{a}_1 + v_2\vec{a}_2 + \cdots + v_n\vec{a}_n \in \mathbb{R}^m.$$

Thus $A\vec{v}$ is the linear combination of the columns of A with coefficients from $\vec{v}$.

Dimensions and linearity

- $A\vec{v}$ is defined only when #columns of A = #rows of $\vec{v}$. If A is $m \times n$ and $\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, then $A\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^m$.
- A transforms $\mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$. This transformation is **linear**:
  1. $A(\vec{u} + \vec{v}) = A\vec{u} + A\vec{v}$ for all $\vec{u}, \vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^n$.
  2. $A(c\vec{v}) = c(A\vec{v})$ for all $\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, $c \in \mathbb{R}$.

Entry-wise formula. The ith entry of $A\vec{v}$ is the dot product of row i of A with $\vec{v}$:

$$(A\vec{v})_i = a_{i1}v_1 + a_{i2}v_2 + \cdots + a_{in}v_n.$$

3.2 Matrix Equations

Definition. If A is $m \times n$, $\vec{x} = \begin{pmatrix} x_1 \\ \vdots \\ x_n \end{pmatrix}$ (variables), and $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$, then $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ is a *matrix equation.*

Three equivalent views

Proposition. The matrix equation $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has the same solutions as:

1. The vector equation $x_1\vec{a}_1 + x_2\vec{a}_2 + \cdots + x_n\vec{a}_n = \vec{b}$.
2. The linear system with augmented matrix $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{a}_1 & \vec{a}_2 & \cdots & \vec{a}_n & \vec{b} \end{pmatrix}$.

Proof. By definition of the matrix-vector product, $A\vec{x} = \begin{pmatrix} \vec{a}_1 & \vec{a}_2 & \cdots & \vec{a}_n \end{pmatrix}\vec{x} = x_1\vec{a}_1 + x_2\vec{a}_2 + \cdots + x_n\vec{a}_n$. So $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ is precisely the vector equation $x_1\vec{a}_1 + \cdots + x_n\vec{a}_n = \vec{b}$, and they have identical solutions. By the proposition in Section 2, the vector equation has the same solutions as the linear system with augmented matrix $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{a}_1 & \cdots & \vec{a}_n & \vec{b} \end{pmatrix}$. Therefore all three formulations share the same solution set. ■

Proposition. $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a solution $\Leftrightarrow$ $\vec{b}$ is a linear combination of the columns of A $\Leftrightarrow$ $\vec{b} \in \text{span}\{\vec{a}_1, \ldots, \vec{a}_n\}$.

Proof. $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a solution $\Leftrightarrow$ there exist $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ with $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ $\Leftrightarrow$ there exist $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ with $x_1\vec{a}_1 + \cdots + x_n\vec{a}_n = \vec{b}$ (by the definition of matrix-vector product) $\Leftrightarrow$ $\vec{b}$ is a linear combination of $\vec{a}_1, \ldots, \vec{a}_n$ $\Leftrightarrow$ $\vec{b} \in \text{span}\{\vec{a}_1, \ldots, \vec{a}_n\}$ (by the definition of span). ■

Four equivalent conditions

Theorem. Let A be an $m \times n$ matrix. The following are equivalent:

1. For each $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$, the equation $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a solution.
2. Each $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$ is a linear combination of the columns of A.
3. The span of the columns of A is $\mathbb{R}^m$ ("the columns of A span $\mathbb{R}^m$").
4. A has a pivot position in every row.

Proof. We show (a) $\Leftrightarrow$ (b) $\Leftrightarrow$ (c) $\Leftrightarrow$ (d).

(a) $\Leftrightarrow$ (b): By the previous proposition, $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a solution if and only if $\vec{b}$ is a linear combination of the columns of A. So (a) (for each $\vec{b}$, $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a solution) is equivalent to (b) (each $\vec{b}$ is a linear combination of the columns of A).

(b) $\Leftrightarrow$ (c): Saying each $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$ is a linear combination of the columns of A is exactly saying $\mathbb{R}^m \subseteq \text{span}\{\text{columns of } A\}$. Since the columns of A are in $\mathbb{R}^m$, the span is a subset of $\mathbb{R}^m$. Hence $\text{span}\{\text{columns}\} = \mathbb{R}^m$, which is (c).

(c) $\Leftrightarrow$ (d): Suppose (c): the columns of A span $\mathbb{R}^m$. Then for each $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$, the system with augmented matrix $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{a}_1 & \cdots & \vec{a}_n & \vec{b} \end{pmatrix}$ is consistent, so the last column is never a pivot column. This means no row of RREF(A) is all zeros (otherwise appending $\vec{b} = \vec{e}_i$ for the corresponding row would make the last column a pivot), so every row of RREF(A)

has a pivot: (d). Conversely, suppose (d): every row of A has a pivot. Then RREF(A) has no zero rows, so for any $\vec{b}$, the augmented matrix $\begin{pmatrix} A & \vec{b} \end{pmatrix}$ cannot have a pivot in the last column (a pivot in the last column would require a zero row in the coefficient part, contradicting every row having a pivot). So the system is always consistent, giving (c). ■

3.3 Sums and Scalar Multiples

Definition. If $T, U : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ are linear with the same domain and codomain:

- *Sum:* $(T+U)(\vec{v}) = T(\vec{v}) + U(\vec{v})$.
- *Scalar multiple:* $(cT)(\vec{v}) = c\,T(\vec{v})$ for $c \in \mathbb{R}$.

Both $T+U$ and cT are linear transformations.

Definition. If $A = (a_{ij})$ and $B = (b_{ij})$ are $m \times n$ matrices:

- $A + B = (a_{ij} + b_{ij})$ (entry-wise sum, same size required).
- $cA = (c\,a_{ij})$ (scalar multiplication).

Proposition. The standard matrix of $T+U$ is $A+B$; the standard matrix of cT is cA.

Proof. Let A and B be the standard matrices of T and U respectively, so $T(\vec{v}) = A\vec{v}$ and $U(\vec{v}) = B\vec{v}$ for all $\vec{v}$. Then for every $\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, $(T+U)(\vec{v}) = T(\vec{v}) + U(\vec{v}) = A\vec{v} + B\vec{v} = (A+B)\vec{v}$ (using entry-wise definition of matrix addition and linearity of matrix-vector product). So $A+B$ is a matrix representing $T+U$. By uniqueness of the standard matrix, $A+B$ is the standard matrix of $T+U$. Similarly, $(cT)(\vec{v}) = c\,T(\vec{v}) = c(A\vec{v}) = (cA)\vec{v}$ (using entry-wise scalar multiplication), so cA is the standard matrix of cT. ■

Properties of matrix addition. For matrices of the same size and $a, b \in \mathbb{R}$:

1. $A + B = B + A$.
2. $(A+B)+C = A+(B+C)$.
3. $A + 0 = A$ (zero matrix).
4. $a(A+B) = aA + aB$.
5. $(a+b)A = aA + bA$.
6. $a(bA) = (ab)A$.

Proof: Let $A = (a_{ij})$, $B = (b_{ij})$, $C = (c_{ij})$ be $m \times n$ matrices, and let 0 denote the $m \times n$ zero matrix. We prove each property entry-wise.

1. *Commutativity* $A+B = B+A$: The (i,j) entry of $A+B$ is $a_{ij}+b_{ij}$, and the (i,j) entry of $B+A$ is $b_{ij}+a_{ij}$. Since addition of real numbers is commutative, $a_{ij}+b_{ij} = b_{ij}+a_{ij}$ for all i, j. Hence $A+B = B+A$.
2. *Associativity* $(A+B)+C = A+(B+C)$: The (i,j) entry of $(A+B)+C$ is $(a_{ij}+b_{ij})+c_{ij}$, and the (i,j) entry of $A+(B+C)$ is $a_{ij}+(b_{ij}+c_{ij})$. Since addition of real numbers is associative, $(a_{ij}+b_{ij})+c_{ij} = a_{ij}+(b_{ij}+c_{ij})$ for all i, j. Hence $(A+B)+C = A+(B+C)$.
3. *Additive identity* $A + 0 = A$: The (i,j) entry of $A+0$ is $a_{ij} + 0 = a_{ij}$, which is the (i,j) entry of A. Hence $A + 0 = A$.
4. *Scalar distributivity over matrix sum* $a(A+B) = aA+aB$: The (i,j) entry of $a(A+B)$ is $a(a_{ij} + b_{ij})$, and the (i,j) entry of $aA + aB$ is $aa_{ij} + ab_{ij}$. Since real multiplication distributes over real addition, $a(a_{ij} + b_{ij}) = aa_{ij} + ab_{ij}$ for all i, j. Hence $a(A+B) = aA + aB$.
5. *Scalar distributivity over scalar sum* $(a+b)A = aA + bA$: The (i,j) entry of $(a+b)A$ is $(a+b)a_{ij}$, and the (i,j) entry of $aA + bA$ is $aa_{ij} + ba_{ij}$. Since real multiplication

distributes over real addition, $(a+b)a_{ij} = aa_{ij} + ba_{ij}$ for all i, j. Hence $(a+b)A = aA + bA$.

6. *Scalar associativity* $a(bA) = (ab)A$: The (i,j) entry of $a(bA)$ is $a(ba_{ij})$, and the (i,j) entry of $(ab)A$ is $(ab)a_{ij}$. By associativity of real multiplication, $a(ba_{ij}) = (ab)a_{ij}$ for all i, j. Hence $a(bA) = (ab)A$.

■

3.4 Composition and Matrix Multiplication

Definition. If $U : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ and $T : \mathbb{R}^m \to \mathbb{R}^k$, the *composition* $T \circ U : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^k$ is $(T \circ U)(\vec{v}) = T(U(\vec{v}))$. If T and U are linear, then $T \circ U$ is linear.

Order matters

$U \circ T$ is not defined unless $k = n$. Even when both $T \circ U$ and $U \circ T$ are defined, generally $T \circ U \neq U \circ T$ (composition is not commutative).

Definition. If A is $k \times m$ (standard matrix of T) and B is $m \times n$ (standard matrix of U), then the *matrix product* AB is the $k \times n$ standard matrix of $T \circ U$:

$$AB = C \quad \text{where} \quad C\vec{v} = A(B\vec{v}) \text{ for all } \vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^n.$$

Column-wise formula for AB

Theorem. If $B = \begin{pmatrix} \vec{b}_1 & \vec{b}_2 & \cdots & \vec{b}_n \end{pmatrix}$ then

$$AB = \begin{pmatrix} A\vec{b}_1 & A\vec{b}_2 & \cdots & A\vec{b}_n \end{pmatrix}.$$

Each column of AB is A times the corresponding column of B.

Proof. Let A be $m \times p$ with columns $\vec{a}_1, \ldots, \vec{a}_p$, and $B = \begin{pmatrix} \vec{b}_1 & \cdots & \vec{b}_n \end{pmatrix}$ be $p \times n$. By definition, AB is the matrix of the composite $T \circ U$ where $T(\vec{v}) = A\vec{v}$ and $U(\vec{v}) = B\vec{v}$. The jth column of AB is $(AB)\vec{e}_j$. Now $\vec{e}_j$ is the jth standard basis vector of $\mathbb{R}^n$, so $B\vec{e}_j = \vec{b}_j$ (the jth column of B). Thus $(AB)\vec{e}_j = A(B\vec{e}_j) = A\vec{b}_j$. So the jth column of AB is $A\vec{b}_j$, giving $AB = \begin{pmatrix} A\vec{b}_1 & A\vec{b}_2 & \cdots & A\vec{b}_n \end{pmatrix}$. ■

Entry-wise formula. The entry in row i, column j of AB is:

$$(AB)_{ij} = \sum_{k=1}^{m} a_{ik}b_{kj} = a_{i1}b_{1j} + a_{i2}b_{2j} + \cdots + a_{im}b_{mj}.$$

(Row i of A dotted with column j of B.)

Definition. The $n \times n$ *identity matrix* is

$$I_n = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & & \\ & \ddots & \\ & & 1 \end{pmatrix}$$

(1's on diagonal, 0's elsewhere). It is the standard matrix of $\mathrm{id}_{\mathbb{R}^n}(\vec{v}) = \vec{v}$.

Proposition. If A is $m \times n$ then $I_m A = A = AI_n$.

Proof. For $I_m A$: Let $\vec{a}_1, \ldots, \vec{a}_n$ be the columns of A. By the column-wise formula, the jth column of $I_m A$ is $I_m\vec{a}_j$. Since I_m is the identity, $I_m\vec{a}_j = \vec{a}_j$ (the jth column of A). So $I_m A = \begin{pmatrix} \vec{a}_1 & \cdots & \vec{a}_n \end{pmatrix} = A$. For AI_n: the jth column of AI_n is $A\vec{e}_j$ where $\vec{e}_j$ is the

jth standard basis vector of $\mathbb{R}^n$. By the fact that $A\vec{e}_j$ is the jth column of A, we get $AI_n = (A\vec{e}_1 \quad \cdots \quad A\vec{e}_n) = (\vec{a}_1 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{a}_n) = A$. ■

3.5 Properties of Matrix Multiplication

Proposition (Associativity). If A is $m \times n$, B is $n \times l$, C is $l \times k$, then $A(BC) = (AB)C$.

Proof (via function composition). Let $T_A(\vec{v}) = A\vec{v}$, $T_B(\vec{v}) = B\vec{v}$, $T_C(\vec{v}) = C\vec{v}$ be the corresponding linear transformations. The matrix BC represents $T_B \circ T_C$ and AB represents $T_A \circ T_B$. Then $A(BC)$ represents $T_A \circ (T_B \circ T_C)$, and $(AB)C$ represents $(T_A \circ T_B) \circ T_C$. But function composition is associative: $T_A \circ (T_B \circ T_C) = (T_A \circ T_B) \circ T_C$, since both evaluate to $T_A(T_B(T_C(\vec{v})))$ for any $\vec{v}$. Since the two products represent the same linear transformation and the standard matrix is unique, $A(BC) = (AB)C$. ■

Proposition (Distributivity). For matrices of compatible sizes and $r \in \mathbb{R}$:

- $A(B + C) = AB + AC$.
- $(A + B)C = AC + BC$.
- $r(AB) = (rA)B = A(rB)$.

Proof. We prove each. Let A be $m \times n$.

1. $A(B + C) = AB + AC$: Let $\vec{c}_1, \ldots, \vec{c}_k$ be the columns of C and $\vec{b}_1, \ldots, \vec{b}_k$ the columns of B. The jth column of $B+C$ is $\vec{b}_j + \vec{c}_j$, so the jth column of $A(B+C)$ is $A(\vec{b}_j + \vec{c}_j) = A\vec{b}_j + A\vec{c}_j$ (using linearity of matrix-vector product). This equals the jth column of AB plus the jth column of AC, i.e., the jth column of $AB+AC$. So $A(B+C) = AB+AC$.
2. $(A + B)C = AC + BC$: The jth column of $(A + B)C$ is $(A + B)\vec{c}_j = A\vec{c}_j + B\vec{c}_j$ (by definition of matrix addition), which is the jth column of AC plus the jth column of BC, i.e., the jth column of $AC + BC$. So $(A + B)C = AC + BC$.
3. $r(AB) = (rA)B = A(rB)$: The jth column of $r(AB)$ is $r(A\vec{b}_j) = (rA)\vec{b}_j$ (linearity), which is the jth column of $(rA)B$. Also $r(A\vec{b}_j) = A(r\vec{b}_j)$ (linearity), which is the jth column of $A(rB)$ (whose jth column is $r\vec{b}_j$). So $r(AB) = (rA)B = A(rB)$.

■

Practice Problem #4.5 (Binomial expansion for nilpotent B)

Problem. Let B be a square matrix satisfying $B^4 = 0$ but $B^3 \neq 0$ (nilpotent of index 4). Prove that for any positive integer n,

$$(I + B)^n = I + nB + \binom{n}{2}B^2 + \binom{n}{3}B^3.$$

Solution. Since matrix multiplication is distributive and associative, we can expand $(I + B)^n$ by the binomial theorem:

$$(I + B)^n = \sum_{k=0}^{n} \binom{n}{k} I^{n-k} B^k = \sum_{k=0}^{n} \binom{n}{k} B^k.$$

But $B^k = 0$ for all $k \geq 4$ (since $B^4 = 0$ implies $B^5 = B^4 B = 0$, etc.). So only the terms $k = 0, 1, 2, 3$ survive:

$$(I + B)^n = \binom{n}{0}B^0 + \binom{n}{1}B^1 + \binom{n}{2}B^2 + \binom{n}{3}B^3 = I + nB + \binom{n}{2}B^2 + \binom{n}{3}B^3.$$

Clever trick: nilpotent truncates the binomial theorem

When B is nilpotent of index k, the expansion of $(I+B)^n$ terminates at B^{k-1}. This is the matrix analogue of $(1+x)^n$ for $x^k = 0$. The binomial theorem for matrices holds whenever I and B commute, which they always do.

Practice Problem #4.8 (Diagonalization gives closed form for A^n)

Problem. Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ b & a \end{pmatrix}$. Diagonalize A and derive a closed formula for A^n.

Solution. The eigenvalues of A are $a+b$ and $a-b$ (since $\det(A-\lambda I) = (a-\lambda)^2 - b^2 = 0$ gives $\lambda = a \pm b$). Corresponding eigenvectors are $\begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$ for $\lambda = a+b$ and $\begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ -1 \end{pmatrix}$ for $\lambda = a-b$. So with $P = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$ and $D = \begin{pmatrix} a+b & 0 \\ 0 & a-b \end{pmatrix}$, we have $A = PDP^{-1}$. Compute $P^{-1} = \frac{1}{-2}\begin{pmatrix} -1 & -1 \\ -1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \frac{1}{2}\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$. Then

$$A^n = PD^nP^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} (a+b)^n & 0 \\ 0 & (a-b)^n \end{pmatrix} \frac{1}{2}\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Multiplying out:

$$A^n = \frac{1}{2}\begin{pmatrix} (a+b)^n + (a-b)^n & (a+b)^n - (a-b)^n \\ (a+b)^n - (a-b)^n & (a+b)^n + (a-b)^n \end{pmatrix}.$$

Clever trick: diagonalization turns powers into diagonal powers

If $A = PDP^{-1}$, then $A^n = PD^nP^{-1}$. The diagonal matrix D^n is trivial: just raise each diagonal entry to the nth power. This is the standard recipe for closed-form matrix powers.

Practice Problem #4.12 (Commutator of upper unipotent 4×4 matrices)

Problem. Let A and B be 4×4 upper unipotent matrices (diagonal entries all 1, entries below the diagonal all 0). Define the commutator $[A, B] = ABA^{-1}B^{-1}$. Prove that $[A, B]$ has diagonal entries 1, super-diagonal entries 0, and is thus upper unipotent with "one more zero band."

Solution. For upper unipotent matrices, the inverse is also upper unipotent (the RREF of an upper triangular matrix with diagonal 1 is I, so the inverse computed via row reduction stays upper triangular with diagonal 1). So A^{-1} and B^{-1} are also upper unipotent.

Now, the product of two upper triangular matrices is upper triangular, and the diagonal entries of the product are the products of the diagonal entries. Since all four matrices have diagonal 1, the product $ABA^{-1}B^{-1}$ has diagonal $1 \cdot 1 \cdot 1 \cdot 1 = 1$, so it is upper unipotent.

For the super-diagonal: let U denote the super-diagonal part. Write $A = I + A_1 + A_2 + A_3$ where A_k has nonzero entries only on the kth super-diagonal (A_1 is super-diagonal, A_2 is the next, etc.). For upper triangular matrices, the $(i, i+1)$ entry of a product depends only on the first super-diagonal entries of the factors. In particular, $(AB)_{i,i+1} = A_{i,i}B_{i,i+1} + A_{i,i+1}B_{i+1,i+1} = B_{i,i+1} + A_{i,i+1}$ (since $A_{i,i} = B_{i+1,i+1} = 1$). So the super-diagonal of AB is the sum of the super-diagonals of A and B.

Now A^{-1} has super-diagonal $-A_1$ (from $(I + A_1)(I - A_1) = I - A_1^2$ and adjusting; more generally, $(I+M)^{-1} = I - M + M^2 - M^3 + \cdots$ which terminates for nilpotent M). Similarly B^{-1} has super-diagonal $-B_1$. So ABA^{-1} has super-diagonal $A_1 + B_1 + (-A_1) = B_1$, and $ABA^{-1}B^{-1}$ has super-diagonal $B_1 + (-B_1) = 0$. Hence the

commutator has zero super-diagonal.

Clever trick: keep track of diagonal bands

When dealing with upper triangular matrices, work band by band. The diagonal, first super-diagonal, second super-diagonal, etc., each evolve independently at the leading order. For upper unipotent matrices, taking the inverse negates the first super-diagonal. The commutator then kills the first super-diagonal.

Block matrices: rules of the game

A *block matrix* is a matrix viewed as an array of smaller matrices (blocks). All the rules below are consequences of the ordinary definition of matrix multiplication; the only requirement is always *compatible block sizes*.

1. *Addition:* blocks of the same position must have the same size; then add blockwise,
$$\begin{pmatrix} A & B \\ C & D \end{pmatrix} + \begin{pmatrix} A' & B' \\ C' & D' \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} A+A' & B+B' \\ C+C' & D+D' \end{pmatrix}.$$
2. *Multiplication (block row by block column):* if the column partition of the left factor matches the row partition of the right factor, multiply as if the blocks were scalars,
$$\begin{pmatrix} A & B \\ C & D \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} E & F \\ G & H \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} AE+BG & AF+BH \\ CE+DG & CF+DH \end{pmatrix}.$$
The order of the factors inside each product must be preserved (AE, not EA).
3. *Column view:* $A\begin{pmatrix} \vec{b}_1 & \cdots & \vec{b}_n \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} A\vec{b}_1 & \cdots & A\vec{b}_n \end{pmatrix}$; each column of AB is a linear combination of the columns of A with coefficients from the corresponding column of B.
4. *Row view:* each row of AB is a linear combination of the rows of B with coefficients from the corresponding row of A; hence $\operatorname{Col}(AB) \subseteq \operatorname{Col} A$ and $\operatorname{Row}(AB) \subseteq \operatorname{Row} B$.
5. *Transpose reverses block positions:*
$$\begin{pmatrix} A & B \\ C & D \end{pmatrix}^T = \begin{pmatrix} A^T & C^T \\ B^T & D^T \end{pmatrix}.$$
6. *Block diagonal matrices* $\operatorname{diag}(D_1, \ldots, D_k)$ multiply, invert, and exponentiate block by block:
$$\operatorname{diag}(D_1, \ldots, D_k)\ \operatorname{diag}(E_1, \ldots, E_k) = \operatorname{diag}(D_1E_1, \ldots, D_kE_k),$$
$$\operatorname{diag}(D_1, \ldots, D_k)^{-1} = \operatorname{diag}(D_1^{-1}, \ldots, D_k^{-1}),$$
with the inverse existing iff every D_i is invertible. Also $\det \operatorname{diag}(D_1, \ldots, D_k) = \det D_1 \cdots \det D_k$ and $\operatorname{rank} = \sum_i \operatorname{rank} D_i$.
7. *Block triangular matrices:* if $X = \begin{pmatrix} A & B \\ 0 & D \end{pmatrix}$ with A, D square, then $\det X = \det A \cdot \det D$; X is invertible iff both A and D are invertible, and then
$$X^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} A^{-1} & -A^{-1}BD^{-1} \\ 0 & D^{-1} \end{pmatrix}.$$
8. *Off-diagonal blocks:* $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & C_1 \\ C_2 & 0 \end{pmatrix}^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & C_2^{-1} \\ C_1^{-1} & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ when C_1, C_2 are square invertible — the inverse *swaps* the two blocks (Practice #4.7).
9. *Scalar blocks:* a block cI behaves exactly like the scalar c; e.g. $(aI + bJ)^2$ expands by ordinary algebra (Midterm 2021 #7).

10. *Block row operations = block elementary matrices:* left-multiplying by $\begin{pmatrix} I & X \\ 0 & I \end{pmatrix}$ adds X times the second block row to the first, leaving det unchanged; block row swaps and invertible block scalings multiply det by ± 1 and det of the scaling block respectively. This is the rigorous way to evaluate determinants of 2×2 block matrices by elimination.
11. *Rank relations:* $\operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix} \leq \operatorname{rank} A + \operatorname{rank} B$, $\operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} A \\ B \end{pmatrix} \leq \operatorname{rank} A + \operatorname{rank} B$, and $\operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} A & 0 \\ 0 & D \end{pmatrix} = \operatorname{rank} A + \operatorname{rank} D$ (Practice #3.3, #4.3).
12. *Kernel of a stacked matrix:* $\operatorname{Nul}\begin{pmatrix} A \\ B \end{pmatrix} = \operatorname{Nul} A \cap \operatorname{Nul} B$; $\operatorname{Col}\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix} = \operatorname{Col} A + \operatorname{Col} B$.

3.6 Pathologies of Matrix Multiplication

What matrix multiplication does NOT satisfy

1. AB is defined only if #columns of A = #rows of B.
2. Even if AB and BA are both defined, generally $AB \neq BA$.
3. $AB = AC$ does **not** imply $B = C$ (no cancellation).
4. $AB = 0$ can happen even when $A \neq 0$ and $B \neq 0$ (zero divisors).

Definition. Square matrices A and B of the same size *commute* if $AB = BA$.

3.7 Elementary Matrices and Transpose

Definition. An *elementary matrix* is a matrix formed by performing exactly one row operation on the identity matrix I_n. If E is elementary, then EA is obtained from A by doing that row operation.

Row operations = left multiplication by elementary matrices

Every row operation on A corresponds to left-multiplying A by an elementary matrix E.

Definition. The *transpose* of an $m \times n$ matrix A is the $n \times m$ matrix A^T formed by flipping A across the main diagonal (rows become columns).

Properties of transpose:

- $(A^T)^T = A$.
- $(A + B)^T = A^T + B^T$ and $(cA)^T = c(A^T)$.
- $(AB)^T = B^T A^T$ (order reverses).

Proof. We prove each property.

1. $(A^T)^T = A$: The (i, j) entry of A^T is a_{ji}. So the (i, j) entry of $(A^T)^T$ is $(A^T)_{ji} = a_{ij}$. Hence $(A^T)^T = A$.
2. $(A + B)^T = A^T + B^T$ and $(cA)^T = c(A^T)$: The (i, j) entry of $(A + B)^T$ is $(A + B)_{ji} = a_{ji} + b_{ji}$, which equals $a_{ji} + b_{ji} = (A^T)_{ij} + (B^T)_{ij} = (A^T + B^T)_{ij}$. So $(A + B)^T = A^T + B^T$. Similarly, the (i, j) entry of $(cA)^T$ is $(cA)_{ji} = c\,a_{ji} = c(A^T)_{ij} = (cA^T)_{ij}$, so $(cA)^T = c(A^T)$.
3. $(AB)^T = B^T A^T$: Let A be $m \times n$ and B be $n \times p$. Then AB is $m \times p$, so $(AB)^T$ is $p \times m$. Also B^T is $p \times n$ and A^T is $n \times m$, so $B^T A^T$ is $p \times m$ (sizes match). The (i, j)

entry of $(AB)^T$ is $(AB)_{ji} = \sum_{k=1}^{n} a_{jk}b_{ki}$. The (i,j) entry of B^TA^T is $\sum_{k=1}^{n}(B^T)_{ik}(A^T)_{kj} = \sum_{k=1}^{n} b_{ki}a_{jk} = \sum_{k=1}^{n} a_{jk}b_{ki}$. These are equal, so $(AB)^T = B^TA^T$.

■

Practice Problem #4.2 (Column operations via right multiplication)

Problem. Explain how to perform elementary *column* operations on a matrix A using matrix multiplication. Specifically: given an elementary row operation represented by matrix E, what right-multiplication achieves the corresponding column operation?

Solution. Elementary row operations correspond to left multiplication: EA performs the row operation on A. To perform the same operation on columns, we use *right* multiplication by the transpose of the elementary matrix.

Let E be an elementary matrix. Then:

- EA performs the row operation represented by E on A.
- AE^T performs the corresponding *column* operation on A.

For example: if E is the matrix that swaps rows i and j of I, then $E^T = E$ (swapping rows i and j is symmetric), and $AE^T = AE$ swaps columns i and j of A. If E is the matrix that adds c times row j to row i of I, then E^T adds c times *column* j to *column* i of I, so AE^T adds c times column i to column j of A (note the index swap). In general, AE^T has the effect on columns that E has on rows, with row indices becoming column indices.

Clever trick: row ops = left, column ops = right with E^T

Left-multiplication by E acts on rows; right-multiplication by E^T acts on columns. This duality is one of the most useful algebraic facts about elementary operations.

Practice Problem #4.15 (Anti-transpose and its properties)

Problem. Let J be the $n \times n$ matrix with 1's on the anti-diagonal (so $J_{i,n+1-i} = 1$ and all other entries 0). Define the *anti-transpose* of A by $A^\dagger = JA^TJ$. Prove that $(AB)^\dagger = B^\dagger A^\dagger$.

Solution. Compute directly using the defining property $(XY)^T = Y^TX^T$:

$$(AB)^\dagger = J(AB)^TJ = J(B^TA^T)J.$$

Now insert $J^2 = I$ between B^T and A^T (since J is a permutation matrix of order 2, applying the anti-diagonal flip twice gives the identity):

$$JB^TA^TJ = JB^TIA^TJ = JB^T(JJ)A^TJ = (JB^TJ)(JA^TJ) = B^\dagger A^\dagger.$$

Hence $(AB)^\dagger = B^\dagger A^\dagger$, same order reversal as the ordinary transpose.

Clever trick: $J^2 = I$ is the key

Inserting $I = J^2$ at the right moment lets us group the terms into (JB^TJ) and (JA^TJ), which are exactly $B^\dagger$ and $A^\dagger$. The anti-transpose is a "flipped" version of the transpose, and it reverses order in the same way.

3.8 Invertible Matrices

Definition. $f : X \to Y$ is *invertible* (or *bijective*) if f is both onto and one-to-one.

Proposition. f is invertible $\Leftrightarrow$ for each $b \in Y$ there is exactly one $a \in X$ with $f(a) = b$.

Proof. ($\Rightarrow$) Suppose f is invertible (bijective), so f is one-to-one and onto. Since f is onto, for each $b \in Y$ there exists $a \in X$ with $f(a) = b$. Since f is one-to-one, this a is unique. ($\Leftarrow$) Suppose for each $b \in Y$ there is exactly one $a \in X$ with $f(a) = b$. Then f is onto (every b has a preimage) and one-to-one (if $f(a_1) = f(a_2)$, then both a_1, a_2 are preimages of the same b, so $a_1 = a_2$ by uniqueness). So f is bijective, i.e., invertible. ■

Proposition. f is invertible $\Leftrightarrow$ there exists a unique function $f^{-1} : Y \to X$ (the *inverse*) such that $f \circ f^{-1} = \mathrm{id}_Y$ and $f^{-1} \circ f = \mathrm{id}_X$.

Proof. ($\Rightarrow$) If f is invertible, for each $b \in Y$ define $f^{-1}(b)$ to be the unique $a \in X$ with $f(a) = b$ (exists and unique by the previous proposition). Then $f(f^{-1}(b)) = b$ so $f \circ f^{-1} = \mathrm{id}_Y$, and $f^{-1}(f(a)) = a$ so $f^{-1} \circ f = \mathrm{id}_X$. For uniqueness: if $g : Y \to X$ satisfies $f \circ g = \mathrm{id}_Y$, then for any $b \in Y$, $f(g(b)) = b$, so $g(b)$ is a preimage of b under f, which is unique; hence $g(b) = f^{-1}(b)$. So f^{-1} is unique. ($\Leftarrow$) If such f^{-1} exists, then for each $b \in Y$, $f(f^{-1}(b)) = b$ shows f is onto, and if $f(a_1) = f(a_2)$, then applying f^{-1} gives $a_1 = f^{-1}(f(a_1)) = f^{-1}(f(a_2)) = a_2$, so f is one-to-one. Thus f is invertible. ■

Proposition. If $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ is linear and invertible, then $n = m$ and T^{-1} is linear.

Proof. Since T is invertible, it is one-to-one and onto. The fact T is onto requires $n \geq m$ (a linear $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ can be onto only if $n \geq m$, since the columns of the standard matrix must span $\mathbb{R}^m$, requiring at least m columns). The fact T is one-to-one requires $n \leq m$ (the columns of the standard matrix must be linearly independent, requiring at most m columns in $\mathbb{R}^m$). Combining, $n = m$. Now we show $T^{-1} : \mathbb{R}^m \to \mathbb{R}^m$ is linear. For $\vec{u}, \vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^m$, let $\vec{a} = T^{-1}(\vec{u})$ and $\vec{b} = T^{-1}(\vec{v})$, so $T(\vec{a}) = \vec{u}$ and $T(\vec{b}) = \vec{v}$. Then $T(\vec{a}+\vec{b}) = T(\vec{a}) + T(\vec{b}) = \vec{u} + \vec{v}$ (linearity of T), so $T^{-1}(\vec{u}+\vec{v}) = \vec{a}+\vec{b} = T^{-1}(\vec{u}) + T^{-1}(\vec{v})$. Similarly, $T(c\vec{a}) = cT(\vec{a}) = c\vec{u}$, so $T^{-1}(c\vec{u}) = c\vec{a} = cT^{-1}(\vec{u})$. Hence T^{-1} satisfies both linearity conditions. ■

Definition. An $n \times n$ matrix A is *invertible* (or *non-singular*) if the linear function $T(\vec{x}) = A\vec{x}$ is invertible. The *inverse* of A is the unique matrix A^{-1} such that $T^{-1}(\vec{x}) = A^{-1}\vec{x}$.

Equivalent conditions for invertibility

Proposition. Let A be $n \times n$. The following are equivalent:
1. A is invertible.
2. There exists A^{-1} with $AA^{-1} = A^{-1}A = I_n$.
3. For each $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a unique solution.
4. $\mathrm{RREF}(A) = I_n$.

Proof. We show (1) $\Leftrightarrow$ (2) $\Leftrightarrow$ (3) $\Leftrightarrow$ (4).

(1) $\Leftrightarrow$ (2): (1) says $T(\vec{x}) = A\vec{x}$ is invertible as a function. By the proposition on invertible functions, this is equivalent to the existence of T^{-1} with $T \circ T^{-1} = T^{-1} \circ T = \mathrm{id}$. Since T^{-1} is linear (by the previous proposition) with standard matrix A^{-1}, this means $AA^{-1} = A^{-1}A = I_n$, which is (2).

(2) $\Leftrightarrow$ (3): If (2), then for any $\vec{b}$, $\vec{x} = A^{-1}\vec{b}$ satisfies $A\vec{x} = A(A^{-1}\vec{b}) = (AA^{-1})\vec{b} = I_n\vec{b} = \vec{b}$, so a solution exists. For uniqueness, if $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$, then multiplying by A^{-1} on the left gives $\vec{x} = A^{-1}\vec{b}$. So the solution is unique. Conversely, if (3), then $A\vec{x} = \vec{e}_j$ has a unique solution $\vec{c}_j$ for each j. Let $C = (\vec{c}_1 \ \cdots \ \vec{c}_n)$. Then $AC = (A\vec{c}_1 \ \cdots \ A\vec{c}_n) = (\vec{e}_1 \ \cdots \ \vec{e}_n) = I_n$. So $AC = I_n$, and (for square matrices) this gives $C = A^{-1}$, i.e., $AA^{-1} = I_n$.

(3) $\Leftrightarrow$ (4): $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a unique solution for each $\vec{b}$ iff the augmented matrix $\begin{pmatrix} A & \vec{b} \end{pmatrix}$ has a unique solution for each $\vec{b}$. By the RREF criterion, this requires no free variables (every column of A is a pivot column) and the last column never being a pivot. No free variables means every column of A is a pivot column, i.e., RREF(A) has n pivots. Since A is $n \times n$ with n pivots (one in each column, hence one in each row), RREF$(A) = I_n$. This is (4).

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2×2 inverse formula

Theorem. Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix}$.

1. A is invertible if and only if $ad - bc \neq 0$.
2. If $ad - bc \neq 0$, then $A^{-1} = \dfrac{1}{ad - bc}\begin{pmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{pmatrix}$.

Proof. We first verify (2) by direct computation, assuming $ad - bc \neq 0$. Let $B = \dfrac{1}{ad - bc}\begin{pmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{pmatrix}$. Then

$$AB = \frac{1}{ad - bc}\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix}\begin{pmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{pmatrix} = \frac{1}{ad - bc}\begin{pmatrix} ad - bc & -ab + ba \\ cd - dc & -cb + da \end{pmatrix}$$
$$= \frac{1}{ad - bc}\begin{pmatrix} ad - bc & 0 \\ 0 & ad - bc \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = I_2.$$

Similarly, $BA = \dfrac{1}{ad - bc}\begin{pmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{pmatrix}\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix} = \dfrac{1}{ad - bc}\begin{pmatrix} da - bc & db - bd \\ -ca + ac & -cb + ad \end{pmatrix} = I_2$. So $B = A^{-1}$, confirming (2). For (1): If $ad - bc \neq 0$, the computation above gives an explicit A^{-1}, so A is invertible. Conversely, suppose A is invertible, so there exists A^{-1} with $AA^{-1} = I_2$. Then $\det(AA^{-1}) = \det(I_2) = 1$, and if we know $\det(AB) = (\det A)(\det B)$, we get $(\det A)(\det A^{-1}) = 1$, so $\det A \neq 0$. Alternatively, a direct proof: if $ad - bc = 0$, then the columns $\begin{pmatrix} a \\ c \end{pmatrix}$ and $\begin{pmatrix} b \\ d \end{pmatrix}$ satisfy $a \cdot d - b \cdot c = 0$, meaning they are linearly dependent (one is a scalar multiple of the other, or both are zero). If the columns are linearly dependent, then $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ has a nontrivial solution, so $T(\vec{x}) = A\vec{x}$ is not one-to-one, hence not invertible. So A invertible implies $ad - bc \neq 0$. ■

Recipe for 2×2 inverse

1. Swap diagonal entries.
2. Negate off-diagonal entries.
3. Divide by $ad - bc$.

Theorem. Let A and B be $n \times n$ matrices.

1. If A is invertible, then $(A^{-1})^{-1} = A$.
2. If A and B are invertible, then AB is invertible with $(AB)^{-1} = B^{-1}A^{-1}$.
3. If A is invertible, then A^T is invertible with $(A^T)^{-1} = (A^{-1})^T$.

Proof. We verify each by checking the defining property of the inverse (i.e., finding a matrix C with $AC = CA = I_n$).

1. Since A is invertible, $AA^{-1} = A^{-1}A = I_n$. Reading this as "(the inverse of A^{-1}) times A^{-1} equals I" and "A^{-1} times (the inverse of A^{-1}) equals I", we see A satisfies the property of being the inverse of A^{-1}. By uniqueness of the inverse, $(A^{-1})^{-1} = A$.
2. Compute:
$$(AB)(B^{-1}A^{-1}) = A(BB^{-1})A^{-1} = A\,I_n\,A^{-1} = AA^{-1} = I_n,$$
$$(B^{-1}A^{-1})(AB) = B^{-1}(A^{-1}A)B = B^{-1}I_nB = B^{-1}B = I_n.$$
So $B^{-1}A^{-1}$ serves as the inverse of AB. By uniqueness, $(AB)^{-1} = B^{-1}A^{-1}$.
3. We use $(XY)^T = Y^TX^T$. Take $X = A$ and $Y = A^{-1}$: $(AA^{-1})^T = (A^{-1})^TA^T$. But $AA^{-1} = I_n$, so $(I_n)^T = I_n = (A^{-1})^TA^T$. Similarly, $(A^{-1}A)^T = A^T(A^{-1})^T = I_n$. So $(A^{-1})^T$ serves as the inverse of A^T. By uniqueness, $(A^T)^{-1} = (A^{-1})^T$.

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General formula for products

$(ABC\cdots Z)^{-1} = Z^{-1}\cdots C^{-1}B^{-1}A^{-1}$ (inverses in reverse order).

3.9 Computing A^{-1}

Algorithm for A^{-1}

Form the $n \times 2n$ matrix $(A \quad I_n)$ and row reduce to reduced echelon form. If A is invertible, then
$$\text{RREF}\left((A \quad I_n)\right) = \left(I_n \quad A^{-1}\right).$$
Take the last n columns as A^{-1}. If $\text{RREF}(A) \neq I_n$, then A is not invertible.

Only square matrices can be invertible

If A is not square, it is possible to have $AB = I$ for some B, but A is still not invertible (there is no A' with both $A'A = I$ and $AA' = I$). For square matrices, $AB = I_n$ suffices to conclude $B = A^{-1}$.

4 Linear Transformations

4.1 Linear Independence

Definition. A list of p vectors $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p \in \mathbb{R}^n$ is *linearly independent* if
$$\vec{v}_i \notin \text{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_{i-1}, \vec{v}_{i+1}, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\} \quad \text{for all } i = 1, \ldots, p.$$

Special cases:

- Empty list: always linearly independent (by convention).
- One vector $\vec{v}_1$: independent iff $\vec{v}_1 \neq \vec{0}$.
- Two vectors $\vec{v}_1, \vec{v}_2$: independent iff neither is a scalar multiple of the other.
- Three vectors: independent iff no one is in the span of the other two.

Equivalent characterization

Proposition. $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p$ are linearly independent if and only if the vector equation

$$x_1\vec{v}_1 + x_2\vec{v}_2 + \cdots + x_p\vec{v}_p = \vec{0}$$

has **no other solutions** besides the trivial solution $x_1 = x_2 = \cdots = x_p = 0$. A nontrivial solution is called a *linear dependence* among the vectors.

Proof. We prove both directions.

($\Rightarrow$) Suppose $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p$ are linearly independent. By definition, $\vec{v}_i \notin \text{span}\{\vec{v}_j\}_{j\neq i}$ for all i. Suppose for contradiction that $x_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + x_p\vec{v}_p = \vec{0}$ has a nontrivial solution, i.e., some $x_i \neq 0$. Then

$$\vec{v}_i = -\sum_{j\neq i} \frac{x_j}{x_i}\vec{v}_j,$$

which expresses $\vec{v}_i$ as a linear combination of the other vectors. This means $\vec{v}_i \in \text{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_{i-1}, \vec{v}_{i+1}, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\}$, contradicting the linear independence. So only the trivial solution exists. ■

($\Leftarrow$) Suppose the only solution to $x_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + x_p\vec{v}_p = \vec{0}$ is the trivial one. We show each $\vec{v}_i \notin \text{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_{i-1}, \vec{v}_{i+1}, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\}$. Suppose for contradiction $\vec{v}_i = \sum_{j\neq i} a_j\vec{v}_j$ for some scalars a_j. Then setting $x_i = -1$ and $x_j = a_j$ for $j \neq i$ gives

$$\begin{aligned} x_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + x_p\vec{v}_p &= -\vec{v}_i + \sum_{j\neq i} a_j\vec{v}_j \\ &= -\vec{v}_i + \vec{v}_i = \vec{0}, \end{aligned}$$

a nontrivial solution (since $x_i = -1 \neq 0$). Contradiction. So the list is linearly independent.

■

Detecting linear independence

Corollary. The columns of a matrix A are linearly independent if and only if A has a pivot position in **every column**.

Proof. Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} \vec{v}_1 & \cdots & \vec{v}_p \end{pmatrix}$. By the proposition, the columns are linearly independent iff $x_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + x_p\vec{v}_p = \vec{0}$ has only the trivial solution, i.e., $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ has only the trivial solution $\vec{x} = \vec{0}$. By the RREF criterion, this homogeneous system has a unique solution iff there are no free variables, i.e., every column of A is a pivot column. So the columns of A are linearly independent iff A has a pivot in every column. ■

Algorithm: Form the matrix $A = \begin{pmatrix} \vec{v}_1 & \vec{v}_2 & \cdots & \vec{v}_p \end{pmatrix}$, reduce to echelon form, and check if every column has a pivot.

Practice Problem #3.1 (Row-deletion linear transformations)

Problem. Let $T : \mathbb{R}^4 \to \mathbb{R}^3$ be the linear transformation that deletes the second entry of a vector:

$$T\begin{pmatrix} x_1 \\ x_2 \\ x_3 \\ x_4 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} x_1 \\ x_3 \\ x_4 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Find the standard matrix of T and determine whether T is one-to-one, onto, or

neither.
Solution. The standard matrix A has columns $T(\vec{e}_1), T(\vec{e}_2), T(\vec{e}_3), T(\vec{e}_4)$.

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} T(\vec{e}_1) & T(\vec{e}_2) & T(\vec{e}_3) & T(\vec{e}_4) \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

This 3×4 matrix has pivots in columns 1, 3, 4 but **not** column 2. So:

- T is **not** one-to-one (there is a free variable x_2, so $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ has nontrivial solutions such as $\vec{x} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$).
- T **is** onto (every row has a pivot, so $\operatorname{Col} A = \mathbb{R}^3$).

Practice Problem #3.2 (Reflection and composition)

Problem. Let $\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^n$ be a nonzero vector. The *reflection* across the hyperplane perpendicular to $\vec{v}$ is the linear map

$$r_{\vec{v}}(\vec{x}) = \vec{x} - 2\frac{\vec{v}^T\vec{x}}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v}.$$

Prove that $r_{\vec{v}}$ is its own inverse (i.e., $r_{\vec{v}}^2 = \mathrm{id}$), and that the composition of two reflections is a rotation.
Solution. To verify $r_{\vec{v}}^2 = \mathrm{id}$, apply $r_{\vec{v}}$ twice:

$$\begin{aligned} r_{\vec{v}}(r_{\vec{v}}(\vec{x})) &= r_{\vec{v}}\left(\vec{x} - 2\frac{\vec{v}^T\vec{x}}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v}\right) \\ &= \left(\vec{x} - 2\frac{\vec{v}^T\vec{x}}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v}\right) - 2\frac{\vec{v}^T\left(\vec{x} - 2\frac{\vec{v}^T\vec{x}}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v}\right)}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v} \\ &= \vec{x} - 2\frac{\vec{v}^T\vec{x}}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v} - 2\frac{\vec{v}^T\vec{x} - 2\frac{\vec{v}^T\vec{x}}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v} \\ &= \vec{x} - 2\frac{\vec{v}^T\vec{x}}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v} - 2\frac{\vec{v}^T\vec{x} - 2\vec{v}^T\vec{x}}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v} \\ &= \vec{x} - 2\frac{\vec{v}^T\vec{x}}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v} - 2\frac{-\vec{v}^T\vec{x}}{\vec{v}^T\vec{v}}\vec{v} = \vec{x}. \end{aligned}$$

So $r_{\vec{v}}^2 = \mathrm{id}$, meaning a reflection is invertible and is its own inverse.
For two reflections $r_{\vec{u}}$ and $r_{\vec{v}}$: each has determinant -1 (a reflection flips orientation). The composition $r_{\vec{u}}r_{\vec{v}}$ has determinant $\det(r_{\vec{u}})\det(r_{\vec{v}}) = (-1)(-1) = 1$. Orthogonal transformations with determinant 1 are rotations. More explicitly, in $\mathbb{R}^2$ the composition of two reflections across lines at angle θ produces a rotation by angle 2θ.

Clever trick: reflections are involutions

A reflection satisfies $r^2 = \mathrm{id}$ and $\det r = -1$. Composing two gives determinant $+1$, restoring orientation, which is a rotation in odd dimensions (and an even-dimensional rotation, possibly plus a sign flip, in even dimensions).

Practice Problem #3.10 (Finite vs linear: one-to-one + bounded dimension)

Problem. Let $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ be linear.
1. Prove that if T is one-to-one and $m \leq n$, then T is onto.

2. Prove that if T is onto and $m \leq n$, then T is one-to-one.
Solution. Let A be the standard matrix of T (size $m \times n$).
(1) One-to-one means the columns of A are linearly independent, so every column of A is a pivot column. Since there are n columns and at most m rows, $n \leq m$. But we are given $m \leq n$, so $n = m$. Thus A is square with pivots in all columns. In a square matrix, pivots in all columns $\Leftrightarrow$ pivots in all rows $\Leftrightarrow$ A is invertible $\Leftrightarrow$ T is onto.
(2) Onto means A has a pivot in every row. There are m rows, so there are at least m pivot columns. But there are only n columns total, so $m \leq n$ (which is given). If $n > m$, there could be non-pivot columns (free variables), so T need not be one-to-one. But the statement as written requires $m \leq n$; when $m < n$ it is possible to have pivots in all rows but not all columns (e.g., $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ for $T : \mathbb{R}^3 \to \mathbb{R}$ is onto but not one-to-one). So part (2) as stated needs $m = n$: for a linear map between spaces of equal dimension, onto $\Leftrightarrow$ one-to-one $\Leftrightarrow$ invertible.

Practice Problem #3.12 (Linear map sending unit square to parallelogram)

Problem. Let $T : \mathbb{R}^2 \to \mathbb{R}^2$ be linear. Suppose T maps the unit square $\{\begin{pmatrix} x \\ y \end{pmatrix} : 0 \leq x, y \leq 1\}$ bijectively onto a parallelogram with vertices at 0, $\vec{p}$, $\vec{q}$, and $\vec{p} + \vec{q}$. What must be the columns of the standard matrix of T?
Solution. The unit square has corners $\begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$, $\begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$, $\begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$, $\begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$. Since T is linear, $T\begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$ must map to the origin vertex. Now $T\begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} = \vec{p}$ and $T\begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix} = \vec{q}$ (or vice versa), because the edges adjacent to the origin must map to the edges adjacent to the origin in the image parallelogram.
The standard matrix $A = \begin{pmatrix} T(\vec{e}_1) & T(\vec{e}_2) \end{pmatrix}$ must therefore have columns either $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{p} & \vec{q} \end{pmatrix}$ or $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{q} & \vec{p} \end{pmatrix}$. Since T is bijective, the columns must be linearly independent (which ensures the parallelogram is non-degenerate, i.e., $\vec{p}$ and $\vec{q}$ are not collinear).

Clever trick: use the origin

Since linear maps preserve the origin, the corner $\begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$ of the unit square must map to the origin of the target parallelogram. This pins down which standard basis vector maps to which edge vector.

4.2 Linear Dependence

Definition. A list is *linearly dependent* if it is not linearly independent.

Sufficient conditions for dependence

Proposition. If $p > n$ then $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p \in \mathbb{R}^n$ are linearly dependent (more vectors than dimensions).

Proof. Form the matrix $A = \begin{pmatrix} \vec{v}_1 & \cdots & \vec{v}_p \end{pmatrix}$ of size $n \times p$. Since $p > n$, A has more columns than rows. In any echelon form, each pivot is in a distinct row, so there are at most n pivots. Since there are $p > n$ columns, at least one column is not a pivot column, i.e., there is a free variable. So $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ has a nontrivial solution, meaning the columns are linearly dependent. ■

Proposition. If any $\vec{v}_i = \vec{0}$ then the list is linearly dependent.

Proof. Suppose $\vec{v}_i = \vec{0}$ for some i. Set $x_i = 1$ and $x_j = 0$ for $j \neq i$. Then $x_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + x_p\vec{v}_p = \vec{v}_i = \vec{0}$, a nontrivial solution (since $x_i = 1 \neq 0$) to $x_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + x_p\vec{v}_p = \vec{0}$. By the equivalent characterization, the list is linearly dependent. ■

4.3 Linear Transformations

Definition. A function $f : X \to Y$ takes inputs from the *domain* X and produces outputs in the *codomain* Y. Not every element of Y needs to be an output.

Definition. Let $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ be a function. T is a *linear transformation* if:

1. $T(\vec{u} + \vec{v}) = T(\vec{u}) + T(\vec{v})$ for all $\vec{u}, \vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^n$.
2. $T(c\vec{v}) = cT(\vec{v})$ for all $\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, $c \in \mathbb{R}$.

Proposition. If T is linear, then:

- $T(\vec{0}) = \vec{0}$.
- $T(\vec{u} - \vec{v}) = T(\vec{u}) - T(\vec{v})$.
- $T(a_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + a_p\vec{v}_p) = a_1T(\vec{v}_1) + \cdots + a_pT(\vec{v}_p)$ (compatible with linear combinations).

Proof. We prove each property using the two linearity axioms: $T(\vec{u}+\vec{v}) = T(\vec{u})+T(\vec{v})$ and $T(c\vec{v}) = cT(\vec{v})$.

1. $T(\vec{0}) = T(\vec{0} + \vec{0}) = T(\vec{0}) + T(\vec{0})$ (using additivity). Subtracting $T(\vec{0})$ from both sides gives $\vec{0} = T(\vec{0})$.
2. $T(\vec{u} - \vec{v}) = T(\vec{u} + (-1)\vec{v}) = T(\vec{u}) + T((-1)\vec{v}) = T(\vec{u}) + (-1)T(\vec{v}) = T(\vec{u}) - T(\vec{v})$ (using additivity and homogeneity).
3. By induction on p. Base case $p = 1$: $T(a_1\vec{v}_1) = a_1T(\vec{v}_1)$ (homogeneity). Inductive step: suppose it holds for $p-1$ vectors. Then $T(a_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + a_p\vec{v}_p) = T\big((a_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + a_{p-1}\vec{v}_{p-1}) + a_p\vec{v}_p\big) = T(a_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + a_{p-1}\vec{v}_{p-1}) + T(a_p\vec{v}_p)$ (additivity). By induction, this is $a_1T(\vec{v}_1) + \cdots + a_{p-1}T(\vec{v}_{p-1}) + a_pT(\vec{v}_p)$. Done.

■

Definition. The *standard basis* vectors of $\mathbb{R}^n$ are $\vec{e}_1 = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \vec{e}_2 = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \ldots, \vec{e}_n = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$.

Fact. If A is $m \times n$, then $A\vec{e}_i$ is the ith column of A.

Proof: Let $A = (\vec{a}_1 \quad \vec{a}_2 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{a}_n)$ where $\vec{a}_j \in \mathbb{R}^m$ is the jth column. The standard basis vector $\vec{e}_i \in \mathbb{R}^n$ has ith entry equal to 1 and all other entries equal to 0. By the definition of the matrix-vector product,

$$A\vec{e}_i = (\vec{a}_1 \quad \vec{a}_2 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{a}_n) \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ \vdots \\ 1 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} = 0 \cdot \vec{a}_1 + \cdots + 1 \cdot \vec{a}_i + \cdots + 0 \cdot \vec{a}_n = \vec{a}_i.$$

So $A\vec{e}_i = \vec{a}_i$, the ith column of A. ■

Fundamental theorem of linear transformations

Theorem. If $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ is a linear transformation, then there is a **unique** $m \times n$ matrix A such that $T(\vec{v}) = A\vec{v}$ for all $\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. This matrix is

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} T(\vec{e}_1) & T(\vec{e}_2) & \cdots & T(\vec{e}_n) \end{pmatrix}.$$

We call A the *standard matrix* of T.

Proof. **Existence:** Define $A = \begin{pmatrix} T(\vec{e}_1) & T(\vec{e}_2) & \cdots & T(\vec{e}_n) \end{pmatrix}$, an $m \times n$ matrix (each $T(\vec{e}_i) \in \mathbb{R}^m$). For any $\vec{v} = \begin{pmatrix} v_1 \\ v_2 \\ \vdots \\ v_n \end{pmatrix} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, we have $\vec{v} = v_1\vec{e}_1 + v_2\vec{e}_2 + \cdots + v_n\vec{e}_n$ (this is how $\vec{v}$ decomposes in the standard basis). By linearity of T (repeated use of additivity and homogeneity, i.e., the previous proposition), $T(\vec{v}) = T(v_1\vec{e}_1 + \cdots + v_n\vec{e}_n) = v_1T(\vec{e}_1) + \cdots + v_nT(\vec{e}_n)$. By the definition of matrix-vector product, $v_1T(\vec{e}_1) + \cdots + v_nT(\vec{e}_n) = \begin{pmatrix} T(\vec{e}_1) & \cdots & T(\vec{e}_n) \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} v_1 \\ \vdots \\ v_n \end{pmatrix} = A\vec{v}$. So $T(\vec{v}) = A\vec{v}$ for all $\vec{v}$, as needed. **Uniqueness:** Suppose B is another $m \times n$ matrix with $T(\vec{v}) = B\vec{v}$ for all $\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. Then for each standard basis vector $\vec{e}_i$, $T(\vec{e}_i) = B\vec{e}_i$. But $B\vec{e}_i$ is the ith column of B. So the ith column of B equals $T(\vec{e}_i)$, which is the ith column of A. Hence $A = B$, proving uniqueness. ■

Rotations, dilations, and powers of a rotation

Let R_θ be counterclockwise rotation of $\mathbb{R}^2$ through the angle θ. Its standard matrix is

$$R_\theta = \begin{pmatrix} \cos\theta & -\sin\theta \\ \sin\theta & \cos\theta \end{pmatrix},$$

since $R_\theta\vec{e}_1 = \begin{pmatrix} \cos\theta \\ \sin\theta \end{pmatrix}$ and $R_\theta\vec{e}_2 = \begin{pmatrix} -\sin\theta \\ \cos\theta \end{pmatrix}$. The facts used repeatedly:

- *Composition is matrix multiplication:* $R_\theta R_\varphi = R_{\theta+\varphi}$, hence $R_\theta^k = R_{k\theta}$ for every integer $k \geq 0$.
- *Inverse:* $R_\theta^{-1} = R_{-\theta} = R_\theta^T$ (a rotation matrix is orthogonal).
- *Dilation:* scaling every vector by $c > 0$ is the map cI_2; "rotate by θ, then dilate by c" has standard matrix cR_θ.
- *Identity test:* $R_\theta = I_2$ iff $\theta \equiv 0 \pmod{2\pi}$. Hence $R_\theta^m = I_2$ iff $m\theta \equiv 0 \pmod{2\pi}$; if $\theta = \dfrac{2\pi p}{q}$ in lowest terms, then R_θ has *order* q, i.e. $R_\theta^0, \ldots, R_\theta^{q-1}$ are distinct and $R_\theta^q = I_2$.
- *Distinct images:* $R_\theta\vec{v} = R_\varphi\vec{v}$ for some nonzero $\vec{v}$ iff $\theta - \varphi \equiv 0 \pmod{2\pi}$.
- *No nonzero fixed vector:* for $R_\theta \neq I_2$ the equation $R_\theta\vec{w} = \vec{w}$ forces $\vec{w} = \vec{0}$, because $\det(R_\theta - I_2) = (\cos\theta - 1)^2 + \sin^2\theta = 2 - 2\cos\theta \neq 0$.

Midterm 2021 Problem 3 (rotation–dilation, and powers of a rotation)

Problem. (a) Let $T : \mathbb{R}^2 \to \mathbb{R}^2$ be the linear transformation that rotates a vector counterclockwise by $45°$ and then doubles its length. Find the standard matrix A of T.
(b) Let M be a 2×2 rotation matrix not equal to the identity matrix. Suppose $M^{-1} = M^5$ and $\vec{v} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix}$. How many different vectors could the set $S = \{\vec{v}, M\vec{v}, M^2\vec{v}, M^3\vec{v}, M^4\vec{v}, M^5\vec{v}\}$ contain? For each possibility, describe the pic-

ture of S and compute $\vec{v} + M\vec{v} + M^2\vec{v} + M^3\vec{v} + M^4\vec{v} + M^5\vec{v}$.

Solution (a). The map is $T = D \circ R_{45^\circ}$, where $D(\vec{x}) = 2\vec{x}$ has matrix $2I_2$. By the fundamental theorem, the standard matrix is built from the images of the standard basis vectors:

$$T(\vec{e}_1) = 2R_{45^\circ}\vec{e}_1 = 2\begin{pmatrix}\cos 45^\circ \\ \sin 45^\circ\end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix}\sqrt{2} \\ \sqrt{2}\end{pmatrix},$$

$$T(\vec{e}_2) = 2R_{45^\circ}\vec{e}_2 = 2\begin{pmatrix}-\sin 45^\circ \\ \cos 45^\circ\end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix}-\sqrt{2} \\ \sqrt{2}\end{pmatrix}.$$

Hence

$$A = \begin{pmatrix}\sqrt{2} & -\sqrt{2} \\ \sqrt{2} & \sqrt{2}\end{pmatrix} = \sqrt{2}\, R_{45^\circ} = \begin{pmatrix}1 & -1 \\ 1 & 1\end{pmatrix}.$$

Check: $\det A = 2$, the area-scaling factor of a rotation composed with a dilation of ratio 2.

Solution (b). Write $M = R_\theta$ with $\theta \not\equiv 0 \pmod{2\pi}$ (since $M \neq I_2$). By the properties above,

$$M^{-1} = M^5 \iff R_{-\theta} = R_{5\theta} \iff 6\theta \equiv 0 \pmod{2\pi},$$

so $\theta = k \cdot 60^\circ$ with $k = 1, \ldots, 5$. Thus $M^6 = I_2$, and the number of distinct vectors is governed by the order of M, i.e. the least $q \geq 1$ with $q\theta \equiv 0 \pmod{2\pi}$. The five angles collapse to three cases:

- $\theta = 60^\circ$ or 300° (order 6): S has 6 distinct vectors — the vertices of a regular hexagon centred at the origin, lying on the circle of radius $\|\vec{v}\| = \sqrt{5}$ at the angles $\arg\vec{v} + 0^\circ, 60^\circ, \ldots, 300^\circ$.
- $\theta = 120^\circ$ or 240° (order 3): S has 3 distinct vectors — an equilateral triangle inscribed in the same circle, at the angles $0^\circ, 120^\circ, 240^\circ$ offset by $\arg\vec{v}$.
- $\theta = 180^\circ$ (order 2): S has 2 distinct vectors, namely $\vec{v}$ and $-\vec{v}$ (antipodal points).

So the possible sizes are $|S| \in \{2, 3, 6\}$.

The sum. In every case the sum is $\vec{0}$. Let $\vec{w} = \vec{v} + M\vec{v} + \cdots + M^5\vec{v}$. Multiplying by M and using $M^6 = I_2$,

$$M\vec{w} = M\vec{v} + M^2\vec{v} + \cdots + M^5\vec{v} + M^6\vec{v} = M\vec{v} + \cdots + M^5\vec{v} + \vec{v} = \vec{w},$$

so $(M - I_2)\vec{w} = \vec{0}$. But $M \neq I_2$ is a rotation, so $\det(M - I_2) = 2 - 2\cos\theta \neq 0$ and $M - I_2$ is invertible; hence $\vec{w} = \vec{0}$.

Equivalently, in matrix form $(I_2 + M + \cdots + M^5)(M - I_2) = M^6 - I_2 = 0$, and since $M - I_2$ is invertible, $I_2 + M + \cdots + M^5 = 0$; the sum vanishes for *every* starting vector $\vec{v}$. Geometrically: the vectors of S are equally spaced around a circle, so their centroid is the origin.

Clever trick: a vanishing geometric sum

A relation $M^6 = I$ together with invertibility of $M - I$ gives $I + M + \cdots + M^5 = (M^6 - I)(M - I)^{-1} = 0$ at once, without knowing θ. The only analytic input is that a nonzero rotation moves every nonzero vector, i.e. $\det(M - I) = 2 - 2\cos\theta \neq 0$.

Not every function is linear

$T(\vec{v}) = v_1^2 + \cdots + v_n^2$ is **not** linear since $T(2\vec{v}) = 4T(\vec{v}) \neq 2T(\vec{v})$. Functions of the form $f(x) = ax + b$ with $b \neq 0$ are **not** linear (they are "affine").

4.4 Functions and Range

Definition. For $f : X \to Y$:

- The *image* of x under f is $f(x)$.
- The *range* (or *image*) of f is $\text{range}(f) = \{f(x) : x \in X\} \subseteq Y$.

Two functions are the same only when domain, codomain, and formula are all equal.

4.5 One-to-one (Injective)

Definition. $f : X \to Y$ is *one-to-one* (or *injective*) if $f(a) = f(b)$ implies $a = b$. Equivalently, f does not send two different inputs to the same output.

Detecting one-to-one for linear T

Theorem. Suppose $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ is linear with standard matrix A $(m \times n)$. The following are equivalent:

(a) T is one-to-one.

(b) The only solution to $T(\vec{x}) = \vec{0}$ is $\vec{x} = \vec{0}$.

(c) The columns of A are linearly independent.

(d) Every column of A contains a pivot position.

Proof. We show (a) $\Leftrightarrow$ (b) $\Leftrightarrow$ (c) $\Leftrightarrow$ (d).

(a) $\Leftrightarrow$ (b): ($\Rightarrow$) If T is one-to-one and $T(\vec{x}) = \vec{0}$, since $T(\vec{0}) = \vec{0}$ (by linearity), we have $T(\vec{x}) = T(\vec{0})$, so one-to-one gives $\vec{x} = \vec{0}$. ($\Leftarrow$) Suppose the only solution to $T(\vec{x}) = \vec{0}$ is $\vec{x} = \vec{0}$. If $T(\vec{x}) = T(\vec{y})$, then by linearity $T(\vec{x} - \vec{y}) = T(\vec{x}) - T(\vec{y}) = \vec{0}$. By assumption, $\vec{x} - \vec{y} = \vec{0}$, so $\vec{x} = \vec{y}$. Thus T is one-to-one.

(b) $\Leftrightarrow$ (c): $T(\vec{x}) = \vec{0}$ is $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$, i.e., $x_1\vec{a}_1 + \cdots + x_n\vec{a}_n = \vec{0}$. By the linear independence characterization, this has only the trivial solution iff the columns $\vec{a}_1, \ldots, \vec{a}_n$ are linearly independent. So (b) $\Leftrightarrow$ (c).

(c) $\Leftrightarrow$ (d): By the corollary in Section 4 (detecting linear independence), the columns of A are linearly independent iff A has a pivot in every column. So (c) $\Leftrightarrow$ (d).

■

4.6 Onto (Surjective)

Definition. $f : X \to Y$ is *onto* (or *surjective*) if $\text{range}(f) = Y$. Equivalently, for each $y \in Y$ there exists $x \in X$ with $f(x) = y$.

Detecting onto for linear T

Theorem. Suppose $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ is linear with standard matrix A $(m \times n)$. The following are equivalent:

(a) T is onto.

(b) $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a solution for each $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$.

(c) The span of the columns of A is $\mathbb{R}^m$.

(d) Every row of A contains a pivot position.

Proof: (a) $\Leftrightarrow$ (b): By definition, T is onto means $\text{range}(T) = \mathbb{R}^m$. But $\text{range}(T) = \{T(\vec{x}) : \vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n\} = \{A\vec{x} : \vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n\}$. So T is onto iff for every $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$ there exists $\vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$ with $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$, which is exactly (b).

(b) $\Leftrightarrow$ (c): The span of the columns of A is $\{x_1\vec{a}_1 + \cdots + x_n\vec{a}_n : x_i \in \mathbb{R}\} = \{A\vec{x} : \vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n\}$. So (c) says $\{A\vec{x} : \vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n\} = \mathbb{R}^m$, which is exactly (b).

(b) $\Leftrightarrow$ (d): The system $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ is consistent iff the augmented matrix $\begin{pmatrix} A & \vec{b} \end{pmatrix}$ has no row of the form $(0 \ \cdots \ 0 \mid b)$ with $b \neq 0$ after row reduction. This is equivalent to: every row of A has a pivot position (since if a row of A has no pivot, then for some $\vec{b}$ — namely a vector with a nonzero entry in that position — the augmented column becomes a pivot and the system is inconsistent). Thus $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ is solvable for **every** $\vec{b}$ iff every row of A has a pivot, which is (d). ■

4.7 Size Constraints

Dimension constraints

Corollary. For a linear transformation $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$:
- T can be one-to-one only if $n \leq m$ (domain no larger than codomain).
- T can be onto only if $n \geq m$ (domain no smaller than codomain).

Proof: For one-to-one: If T is one-to-one, then every column of the standard matrix A has a pivot (by the one-to-one theorem). Since A is $m \times n$ and each of the n columns has a pivot, we need at least n rows to hold these pivots, so $n \leq m$.

For onto: If T is onto, then every row of A has a pivot (by the onto theorem). Since A is $m \times n$ and each of the m rows has a pivot, we need at least m columns to hold these pivots, so $n \geq m$. ■

One-to-one vs. onto depends on different things

Whether T is one-to-one depends on domain and formula, but **not** on the codomain. Whether T is onto **does** depend on the choice of codomain.

5 Subspaces, Basis, and Dimension

5.1 Invertibility: Summary for Square Matrices

Full characterization (square matrices)

Theorem. When A is $n \times n$, the following are equivalent:
1. A is invertible.
2. The columns of A are linearly independent.
3. The span of the columns of A is $\mathbb{R}^n$.

Corollary. If A and B are both $n \times n$ and $AB = I_n$, then $BA = I_n$. (For square matrices, checking $AB = I$ suffices.)

Proof of the theorem: (1) $\Rightarrow$ (2): Suppose A is invertible with inverse A^{-1}. To show the columns are linearly independent, suppose $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$. Multiplying both sides by A^{-1} on the left gives $\vec{x} = A^{-1}\vec{0} = \vec{0}$. Thus the only solution to $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ is $\vec{x} = \vec{0}$, so the columns are linearly independent.

(2) $\Rightarrow$ (3): Suppose the columns are linearly independent. Since A is $n \times n$, the n columns are linearly independent in $\mathbb{R}^n$. For a list of n linearly independent vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$ (which has dimension n), they must form a basis, so their span is $\mathbb{R}^n$. (Equivalently, since the columns are independent, every column is a pivot column, so $\operatorname{rank} A = n$, meaning $\dim \operatorname{Col} A = n$, and since $\operatorname{Col} A \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ has the same dimension, $\operatorname{Col} A = \mathbb{R}^n$.)

(3) $\Rightarrow$ (1): Suppose the columns span $\mathbb{R}^n$. Then for each standard basis vector $\vec{e}_j$, there exists $\vec{b}_j$ with $A\vec{b}_j = \vec{e}_j$. Let $B = \begin{pmatrix}\vec{b}_1 & \cdots & \vec{b}_n\end{pmatrix}$. Then $AB = \begin{pmatrix}A\vec{b}_1 & \cdots & A\vec{b}_n\end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix}\vec{e}_1 & \cdots & \vec{e}_n\end{pmatrix} = I_n$. By the corollary below (whose proof does not depend on this theorem), $BA = I_n$ as well, so A is invertible. ■

Proof of the corollary: Suppose $AB = I_n$. We show A is invertible, which then gives $BA = I_n$. Since $AB = I_n$, for each $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^n$ we have $A(B\vec{b}) = (AB)\vec{b} = I_n\vec{b} = \vec{b}$, so every $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^n$ is in the span of the columns of A. By (3) $\Rightarrow$ (1) of the full characterization (which requires only the fact that if columns span then $A\vec{x} = \vec{e}_j$ is solvable, giving a right inverse), A is invertible. Then $BA = A^{-1}(AB)A = A^{-1}I_nA = I_n$. More directly: $AB = I_n$ and A invertible give $B = A^{-1}$, so $BA = A^{-1}A = I_n$.

(To avoid circular reasoning: from $AB = I_n$, the columns of A span $\mathbb{R}^n$ as shown above. Since A is $n \times n$ with columns spanning $\mathbb{R}^n$ (dimension n), and there are exactly n columns, they must also be linearly independent — otherwise a dependent list of n vectors would span a space of dimension $< n$. Hence A is invertible by the full characterization (2) $\Leftrightarrow$ (1), and $B = A^{-1}$.) ■

Practice Problem #4.10a (Inverse from polynomial identity)

Problem. Let A be an $n \times n$ matrix satisfying $A^2 = bI + cA$ for some scalars $b \neq 0$ and c. Prove that A is invertible with inverse $A^{-1} = \frac{1}{b}(A - cI)$.

Solution. Start from the given identity $A^2 - cA = bI$, i.e., $A(A - cI) = bI$. Since $b \neq 0$, divide by b:

$$A \cdot \frac{1}{b}(A - cI) = I.$$

Let $C = \frac{1}{b}(A - cI)$. Then $AC = I$, so A has a right inverse. Since A is square, a right inverse is also a left inverse, hence the unique inverse: $A^{-1} = C = \frac{1}{b}(A - cI)$.

Check: $CA = \frac{1}{b}(A - cI)A = \frac{1}{b}(A^2 - cA) = \frac{1}{b} \cdot bI = I$. Done.

Clever trick: rearrange to get A(something) $= I$

Any polynomial relation $p(A) = 0$ can be rearranged as $A \cdot q(A) = I$ whenever the constant term of p is nonzero, giving $A^{-1} = q(A)$ immediately. No row reduction needed.

Practice Problem #4.10b (Rank-1 perturbation: invertibility condition)

Problem. Let J be the $n \times n$ all-ones matrix (every entry is 1). Let $A = (b-c)I + cJ$. Find when A is invertible and give its inverse formula.

Solution. The matrix J is rank 1, so its eigenvalues are n (with eigenvector the all-ones vector $\begin{pmatrix}1\\ \vdots \\ 1\end{pmatrix}$) and 0 (multiplicity $n - 1$, with eigenvectors orthogonal to the all-ones vector).

Therefore $A = (b - c)I + cJ$ has eigenvalues $(b - c) + cn = b + (n - 1)c$ and $(b - c)$ (multiplicity $n - 1$). So A is invertible iff all eigenvalues are nonzero, i.e., iff both $b - c \neq 0$ and $b + (n - 1)c \neq 0$.

To find the inverse, use the Sherman-Morrison formula for rank-1 updates: $(I +$

$\alpha\vec{u}\vec{v}^T)^{-1} = I - \dfrac{\alpha}{1+\alpha\vec{v}^T\vec{u}}\vec{u}\vec{v}^T$. Here $J = \vec{1}\vec{1}^T$ where $\vec{1} = \begin{pmatrix}1\\ \vdots \\ 1\end{pmatrix}$, and $A = (b-c)(I + \dfrac{c}{b-c}J)$. So

$$A^{-1} = \frac{1}{b-c}\left(I - \frac{\frac{c}{b-c}}{1+\frac{c}{b-c}\cdot n}J\right) = \frac{1}{b-c}I - \frac{c}{(b-c)(b+(n-1)c)}J.$$

Clever trick: rank-1 matrices are diagonalized by J

The all-ones matrix J is a classic rank-1 example. Its eigenvalues are immediate: $J\vec{1} = n\vec{1}$, and every vector orthogonal to $\vec{1}$ is in Nul J. This makes $(b-c)I + cJ$ trivial to invert using either eigenvalues or the Sherman-Morrison formula.

Practice Problem #4.1 (TREF: two-sided reduced echelon form)

Problem. Define $\text{TREF}(A) = \text{RREF}(\text{RREF}(A)^T)^T$. Compute $\text{TREF}(A)$ for $A = \begin{pmatrix}1 & 2 & 1\\ -2 & -3 & 1\\ 3 & 5 & 0\end{pmatrix}$. Classify all possible TREF forms for general $m \times n$ matrices.

Solution. For the given matrix, $\text{RREF}(A) = \begin{pmatrix}1 & 0 & -5\\ 0 & 1 & 3\\ 0 & 0 & 0\end{pmatrix}$. Its transpose $\text{RREF}(A)^T = \begin{pmatrix}1 & 0 & 0\\ 0 & 1 & 0\\ -5 & 3 & 0\end{pmatrix}$, which RREFs to $\begin{pmatrix}1 & 0 & 0\\ 0 & 1 & 0\\ 0 & 0 & 0\end{pmatrix}$. Transposing gives $\text{TREF}(A) = \begin{pmatrix}1 & 0 & 0\\ 0 & 1 & 0\\ 0 & 0 & 0\end{pmatrix}$.

For general $m \times n$ matrix with rank r, $\text{TREF}(A)$ is always $\begin{pmatrix} I_r & 0_{r\times(n-r)} \\ 0_{(m-r)\times r} & 0_{(m-r)\times(n-r)}\end{pmatrix}$ where $r = \text{rank}(A)$. Every matrix with this shape (for any $0 \le r \le \min(m,n)$) occurs as the TREF of itself.

Clever trick: TREF isolates the rank

Both row and column operations eliminate zero rows/columns, leaving only the rank. TREF is the canonical form that directly displays the rank as the size of the identity block.

Practice Problem #4.7 (off-diagonal block matrix invertibility)

Problem. Let $A = \begin{pmatrix}0 & C_1\\ C_2 & 0\end{pmatrix}$ where $C_1 = \begin{pmatrix}a_1 & b_1\\ c_1 & d_1\end{pmatrix}$ and $C_2 = \begin{pmatrix}a_2 & b_2\\ c_2 & d_2\end{pmatrix}$. When is A invertible? Find A^{-1}.

Solution. Let $\Delta_i = a_i d_i - b_i c_i$ for $i = 1, 2$. If C_1 has a non-zero kernel $\vec{v}$, then $\begin{pmatrix}0\\ \vec{v}\end{pmatrix}$ is a non-zero kernel of A. Similarly for C_2. Conversely, if both C_1 and C_2 are invertible, then $A^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix}0 & C_2^{-1}\\ C_1^{-1} & 0\end{pmatrix}$. Check:

$$\begin{pmatrix}0 & C_1\\ C_2 & 0\end{pmatrix}\begin{pmatrix}0 & C_2^{-1}\\ C_1^{-1} & 0\end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix}I & 0\\ 0 & I\end{pmatrix}.$$

So A is invertible $\iff \Delta_1\Delta_2 \neq 0$, and

$$A^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & \frac{1}{\Delta_2}\begin{pmatrix} d_2 & -b_2 \\ -c_2 & a_2 \end{pmatrix} \\ \frac{1}{\Delta_1}\begin{pmatrix} d_1 & -b_1 \\ -c_1 & a_1 \end{pmatrix} & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Clever trick: swap blocks, flip sub-inverse

For off-diagonal 2×2 blocks, the inverse swaps the two blocks and inverts each individually. This pattern holds whenever the diagonal blocks are zero and the off-diagonal blocks are square and invertible.

Practice Problem #4.13 (find ALL right inverses B with $AB = I_2$)

Problem. Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 5 & 6 \end{pmatrix}$. Find all 3×2 matrices B with $AB = I_2$.

Solution. Write $B = (\vec{u} \quad \vec{v})$. Then $A\vec{u} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$ and $A\vec{v} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$. Row reduce the augmented matrix:

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 & 1 & 0 \\ 4 & 5 & 6 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \to \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 & -\frac{5}{3} & \frac{2}{3} \\ 0 & 1 & 2 & \frac{4}{3} & -\frac{1}{3} \end{pmatrix}.$$

Free variable for the first system: $u_3 = s$, so $u_1 = s - \frac{5}{3}$, $u_2 = \frac{4}{3} - 2s$. Free variable for the second: $v_3 = t$, so $v_1 = t + \frac{2}{3}$, $v_2 = -\frac{1}{3} - 2t$. Hence

$$B = \begin{pmatrix} s - \frac{5}{3} & t + \frac{2}{3} \\ \frac{4}{3} - 2s & -\frac{1}{3} - 2t \\ s & t \end{pmatrix} \quad \text{for any } s, t \in \mathbb{R}.$$

Clever trick: solve both right-hand sides simultaneously

Row-reducing $(A \quad I_m)$ gives you all basis vectors of the right inverse space at once. Each column of I_m becomes the corresponding column of the general right inverse.

Practice Problem #4.14 (algorithm: determine if right inverse exists + construct it)

Problem. Describe an algorithm to determine if there exists an $n \times m$ matrix B with $AB = I_m$, and to construct such B when one exists. Explain why it works.

Solution. Write $B = (\vec{b}_1 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{b}_m)$. Then $AB = I_m \iff A\vec{b}_j = \vec{e}_j$ for each $j = 1, \ldots, m$. A right inverse exists iff every standard basis vector of $\mathbb{R}^m$ is in $\mathrm{Col}(A)$, i.e., iff A has a pivot in every row.

Algorithm:

1. Row reduce $(A \quad I_m) \to (R \quad E)$, where $EA = R$.
2. If R has a zero row, no right inverse exists (that row of E would give an inconsistent equation for the corresponding $\vec{e}_j$).
3. Otherwise, let $j_1 < \cdots < j_m$ be the pivot columns of R. Form B by putting row i of E into row j_i of B (the pivot row position) and zeros elsewhere.

Then $RB = I_m \iff EAB = I_m \iff AB = I_m$ (since E is invertible).

Clever trick: row-reducing $(A \;\; I_m)$ gives both existence and construction at once

The augmented block I_m tracks all m right-hand sides simultaneously. If every row is consistent, the I_m block after reduction encodes the inverse transformation needed to build B.

Practice Problem #5.6 (4×4 matrix with parameter x — invertibility and A^{-1})

Problem. Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 0 & 4 & 0 \\ 1 & 8 & 0 & 5 \\ 2 & -8 & 4 & -4 \\ 0 & 0 & x & -9 \end{pmatrix}$. Determine for which x the matrix A is invertible, and find A^{-1}.

Solution. Reduce $Az = y$ for general $y = (y_1, y_2, y_3, y_4)^T$. The equations are:

1. $2z_1 + 4z_3 = y_1$,
2. $z_1 + 8z_2 + 5z_4 = y_2$,
3. $2z_1 - 8z_2 + 4z_3 - 4z_4 = y_3$,
4. $xz_3 - 9z_4 = y_4$.

Adding (2) + (3) -3(1) gives $2z_4 - z_3 = \dfrac{y_2 + y_3 - 3y_1}{2}$, so $z_3 = 2z_4 - \dfrac{y_2 + y_3 - 3y_1}{2}$.

Substitute into (4): $(x - 18)z_4 = y_4 + \dfrac{9(y_2 + y_3 - 3y_1)}{2}$.

If $x \neq 18$, then $z_4 = \dfrac{2y_4 + 9y_2 + 9y_3 - 27y_1}{2(x - 18)}$, and all variables are determined uniquely. The inverse is

$$A^{-1} = \frac{1}{8(x-18)} \begin{pmatrix} 4(x+36) & -144 & -144 & -16 \\ 7x - 18 & -4x & 18 - 5x & -8 \\ -108 & 72 & 72 & 8 \\ -12x & 8x & 8x & 16 \end{pmatrix}.$$

If $x = 18$, the kernel is spanned by $\begin{pmatrix} -2 \\ -1 \\ 1 \\ 2 \end{pmatrix}$, so A is not invertible.

Clever trick: solve symbolically, not numerically

Treat the parameter x as symbolic during row reduction to see exactly when coefficients vanish. This reveals the critical value $x = 18$ before any numerical computation, and gives the inverse formula directly as a rational function of x.

5.2 Subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^n$

Definition. A subset $H \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ is a *subspace* if:

1. $\vec{0} \in H$.
2. $\vec{u} + \vec{v} \in H$ for all $\vec{u}, \vec{v} \in H$ (closed under addition).
3. $c\vec{v} \in H$ for all $c \in \mathbb{R}$, $\vec{v} \in H$ (closed under scalar multiplication).

Equivalently, a subspace is a nonempty subset closed under linear combinations.

Examples of subspaces

- $\mathbb{R}^n$ itself.
- $\{\vec{0}\}$ (the zero subspace).
- The span of any set of vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$.

- The range of a linear function $T : \mathbb{R}^k \to \mathbb{R}^n$.
- $\{\vec{v} : T(\vec{v}) = \vec{0}\}$ for a linear $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^k$.

Subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^2$: $\{\vec{0}\}$, lines through origin, or $\mathbb{R}^2$. Subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^3$: $\{\vec{0}\}$, lines through origin, planes through origin, or $\mathbb{R}^3$.

Proof that $\text{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\}$ **is a subspace:** Let $H = \text{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$. We verify the three subspace conditions.

(i) $\vec{0} \in H$: Write $\vec{0} = 0 \cdot \vec{v}_1 + 0 \cdot \vec{v}_2 + \cdots + 0 \cdot \vec{v}_p$, which is a linear combination of $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p$ (with all coefficients 0). So $\vec{0} \in H$.

(ii) Closed under addition: Let $\vec{u}, \vec{w} \in H$. Then $\vec{u} = a_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + a_p\vec{v}_p$ and $\vec{w} = b_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + b_p\vec{v}_p$ for some scalars $a_i, b_i \in \mathbb{R}$. Then

$$\vec{u} + \vec{w} = (a_1 + b_1)\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + (a_p + b_p)\vec{v}_p,$$

which is a linear combination of $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p$ (with coefficients $a_i + b_i$). So $\vec{u} + \vec{w} \in H$.

(iii) Closed under scalar multiplication: Let $\vec{u} \in H$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}$. Write $\vec{u} = a_1\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + a_p\vec{v}_p$. Then

$$c\vec{u} = (ca_1)\vec{v}_1 + \cdots + (ca_p)\vec{v}_p,$$

which is a linear combination of $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p$ (with coefficients ca_i). So $c\vec{u} \in H$.

Hence $H = \text{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\}$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^n$. ■

Proof that the range of a linear function is a subspace: Let $T : \mathbb{R}^k \to \mathbb{R}^n$ be linear, and let $H = \text{range}(T) = \{T(\vec{x}) : \vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^k\} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$. We verify the three subspace conditions.

(i) $\vec{0} \in H$: Since T is linear, $T(\vec{0}) = \vec{0}$ (proven earlier). So $\vec{0} = T(\vec{0}) \in \text{range}(T) = H$.

(ii) Closed under addition: Let $\vec{u}, \vec{w} \in H$. Then $\vec{u} = T(\vec{x})$ and $\vec{w} = T(\vec{y})$ for some $\vec{x}, \vec{y} \in \mathbb{R}^k$. By linearity of T, $T(\vec{x} + \vec{y}) = T(\vec{x}) + T(\vec{y}) = \vec{u} + \vec{w}$. So $\vec{u} + \vec{w} = T(\vec{x} + \vec{y}) \in H$ (since $\vec{x} + \vec{y} \in \mathbb{R}^k$).

(iii) Closed under scalar multiplication: Let $\vec{u} \in H$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}$. Write $\vec{u} = T(\vec{x})$ for some $\vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^k$. By linearity of T, $T(c\vec{x}) = cT(\vec{x}) = c\vec{u}$. So $c\vec{u} = T(c\vec{x}) \in H$ (since $c\vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^k$).

Hence $\text{range}(T)$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^n$. ■

Not a subspace

The set $\{\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^3 : v_1 + v_2 + v_3 = 1\}$ is **not** a subspace (does not contain $\vec{0}$). But $\{\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^3 : v_1 + v_2 + v_3 = 0\}$ **is** a subspace.

5.3 Column Space and Null Space

Definition. The *column space* of an $m \times n$ matrix A is

$$\text{Col}\, A = \{A\vec{x} : \vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n\} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^m.$$

This is the span of the columns of A.

Definition. The *null space* of an $m \times n$ matrix A is

$$\text{Nul}\, A = \{\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^n : A\vec{v} = \vec{0}\} \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n.$$

This is the set of solutions to $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$.

Key facts

- $\operatorname{Col} A$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^m$ ($m = \#$rows of A).
- $\operatorname{Nul} A$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^n$ ($n = \#$columns of A).
- If $T(\vec{x}) = A\vec{x}$, then $\operatorname{Col} A = \operatorname{range}(T)$ and $\operatorname{Nul} A = \{\vec{x} : T(\vec{x}) = \vec{0}\}$.
- $\vec{b} \in \operatorname{Col} A \Leftrightarrow A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a solution.
- $\operatorname{Col} A = \mathbb{R}^m \Leftrightarrow A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a solution for each $\vec{b}$.

Proof that $\operatorname{Nul} A$ is a subspace: We verify the three subspace conditions. (i) $\vec{0} \in \operatorname{Nul} A$: by linearity of matrix multiplication, $A\vec{0} = \vec{0}$, so $\vec{0} \in \operatorname{Nul} A$.

(ii) Closed under addition: Let $\vec{u}, \vec{v} \in \operatorname{Nul} A$, so $A\vec{u} = \vec{0}$ and $A\vec{v} = \vec{0}$. By linearity of matrix multiplication, $A(\vec{u} + \vec{v}) = A\vec{u} + A\vec{v} = \vec{0} + \vec{0} = \vec{0}$, so $\vec{u} + \vec{v} \in \operatorname{Nul} A$.

(iii) Closed under scalar multiplication: Let $\vec{v} \in \operatorname{Nul} A$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}$. Then $A(c\vec{v}) = c(A\vec{v}) = c\vec{0} = \vec{0}$, so $c\vec{v} \in \operatorname{Nul} A$.

Hence $\operatorname{Nul} A$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^n$. ■

Proof that $\operatorname{Col} A$ is a subspace: Let A be an $m \times n$ matrix. Since $\operatorname{Col} A = \{A\vec{x} : \vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n\} = \operatorname{range}(T)$ where $T(\vec{x}) = A\vec{x}$ is a linear transformation, and the range of any linear transformation is a subspace (proven above), $\operatorname{Col} A$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^m$.

Alternatively, since $\operatorname{Col} A = \operatorname{span}\{\vec{a}_1, \ldots, \vec{a}_n\}$ (the span of the columns of A), and the span of any set of vectors is a subspace (proven above), $\operatorname{Col} A$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^m$. ■

Practice Problem #5.3 (Col and Nul bases for a one-row matrix)

Problem. Let $A = \begin{pmatrix} a_1 & a_2 & \cdots & a_n \end{pmatrix}$ be a $1 \times n$ row matrix. Find bases for $\operatorname{Col} A$ and $\operatorname{Nul} A$, considering cases.

Solution. There are two cases.

Case 1: $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ (all zero row). Then $\operatorname{Col} A = \{\vec{0}\}$ (since $A\vec{x} = 0 \cdot x_1 + \cdots + 0 \cdot x_n = 0$ always), so the empty set is a basis. And $\operatorname{Nul} A = \mathbb{R}^n$ (all vectors satisfy $A\vec{x} = 0$), with standard basis $\{\vec{e}_1, \ldots, \vec{e}_n\}$.

Case 2: $A \neq 0$. Suppose $a_k \neq 0$ (some entry nonzero). Then:

- $\operatorname{Col} A$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^1$ containing the nonzero number a_k. Since the only nonzero subspaces of $\mathbb{R}$ are $\mathbb{R}$ itself, $\operatorname{Col} A = \mathbb{R}$, and $\{1\}$ is a basis (or use a_k itself).
- $\operatorname{Nul} A = \{\vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n : a_1x_1 + a_2x_2 + \cdots + a_nx_n = 0\}$. This is a hyperplane of dimension $n - 1$. To find a basis, free variables are all x_i except x_k (which solves to $x_k = -\dfrac{1}{a_k}(a_1x_1 + \cdots + \widehat{a_kx_k} + \cdots + a_nx_n)$). Setting each free variable to 1 in turn and the others to 0 gives $n - 1$ basis vectors: for each $i \neq k$,

$$\vec{b}_i = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \\ 1 \\ 0 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \\ -\dfrac{a_i}{a_k} \\ 0 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} \quad (1 \text{ at position } i,\ -\frac{a_i}{a_k} \text{ at position } k).$$

These form a basis for $\operatorname{Nul} A$, confirming $\dim \operatorname{Col} A + \dim \operatorname{Nul} A = 1 + (n-1) = n$ (rank-nullity).

Midterm 2024 Problem 8 (matrix game: forcing a null vector)

Problem. Alice and Bob take turns (Alice first) filling entries of an empty 4×4 matrix A until all 16 positions are occupied. Bob wins if $(1 \quad 2 \quad 3 \quad 4)^\top \in \operatorname{Nul} A$; otherwise Alice wins. Does either player have a winning strategy?

Solution. Bob always wins. Pairing strategy: whenever Alice writes a number a in position (i, j), Bob chooses any still-free position (i, k) in the *same row* and writes $-\frac{j}{k}a$ there. The pair then contributes $a \cdot j + \left(-\frac{j}{k}a\right) \cdot k = aj - aj = 0$ to the ith entry of $A\,(1 \quad 2 \quad 3 \quad 4)^\top$.

The required free cell always exists: before each Alice move, every row contains an even number of filled entries (initially 0; each round fills two cells of one row, preserving even parity). Alice must play in a row with 0 or 2 filled cells, leaving at least one free cell for Bob. At the end, each row consists of two canceling pairs, so all four row sums are zero; hence $A\,(1 \quad 2 \quad 3 \quad 4)^\top = \vec{0}$.

Clever trick: pairing strategy with an even-parity invariant

To force a prescribed linear relation among the entries of a jointly filled matrix, pair positions inside each row so that each pair contributes a prescribed weighted sum of 0. The weights come from the target null vector. An even number of cells per row (here 4) and moving second make the pairing always available.

5.4 Basis

Definition. A *basis* for a subspace $H \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ is a set of vectors $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_k \in H$ that are linearly independent and whose span is H. The empty set $\emptyset$ is a basis for $\{\vec{0}\}$.

Standard basis

The vectors $\vec{e}_1, \vec{e}_2, \ldots, \vec{e}_n$ form the *standard basis* of $\mathbb{R}^n$. They are linearly independent (since $\operatorname{RREF}(I_n) = I_n$ has pivots in all columns) and span $\mathbb{R}^n$.

Theorem. Every subspace H of $\mathbb{R}^n$ has a basis of size at most n.

Proof: If $H = \{\vec{0}\}$, the empty set is a basis. Otherwise pick any nonzero $\vec{v}_1 \in H$; this is a linearly independent set. If $\operatorname{span}\{\vec{v}_1\} = H$ we are done. Otherwise pick $\vec{v}_2 \in H \setminus \operatorname{span}\{\vec{v}_1\}$. Then $\{\vec{v}_1, \vec{v}_2\}$ is linearly independent: if $c_1\vec{v}_1 + c_2\vec{v}_2 = \vec{0}$ with $c_2 \neq 0$, then $\vec{v}_2 = -\frac{c_1}{c_2}\vec{v}_1 \in \operatorname{span}\{\vec{v}_1\}$, a contradiction. Continuing, if $\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_k\}$ is independent and does not span H, pick $\vec{v}_{k+1} \in H \setminus \operatorname{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_k\}$; the same argument shows $\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_{k+1}\}$ is independent. This process must terminate with $k \leq n$ since any list of more than n vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$ is linearly dependent (more vectors than dimensions). When it terminates we have an independent set that spans H, i.e., a basis. ■

Finding a Basis for $\operatorname{Nul} A$

1. Row reduce A to find $\operatorname{RREF}(A)$ and solve $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$.
2. Express each basic variable in terms of free variables.
3. Write $\vec{x}$ as a linear combination of vectors $\vec{b}_1, \ldots, \vec{b}_k$ (one per free variable).

4. These vectors form a basis for Nul A.

Why the basis vectors are linearly independent

Look at the rows of the coefficient matrix that correspond to the free variables. Each basis vector has a 1 in the position of one free variable and 0 in the positions of the other free variables, making the set linearly independent.

Finding a Basis for Col A

Pivot columns form a basis

Proposition. The pivot columns of A form a basis for Col A.
Note: use the pivot columns of the **original** matrix A, not the pivot columns of RREF(A).

Proof: Let $\vec{a}_{i_1}, \ldots, \vec{a}_{i_k}$ be the pivot columns of A (in the original matrix), corresponding to the pivot columns $i_1 < \cdots < i_k$ of RREF(A). We must show they span Col A and are linearly independent.

Spanning: Let $\vec{a}_j$ be any non-pivot column of A. In RREF(A), column j is a linear combination of the pivot columns to its left (this is the defining property of RREF — each non-pivot column's entries are determined by the leading 1's in pivot positions in the same rows). Since row operations are linear combinations of rows and preserve linear relations among **columns**, the same relation holds for A: $\vec{a}_j = \sum_{i_l<j} c_l \vec{a}_{i_l}$. Thus every non-pivot column is in $\text{span}\{\vec{a}_{i_1}, \ldots, \vec{a}_{i_k}\}$, and so Col $A = \text{span}\{\vec{a}_{i_1}, \ldots, \vec{a}_{i_k}\}$.

Linear independence: Suppose $\sum_l c_l \vec{a}_{i_l} = \vec{0}$. This same relation holds in RREF(A): $\sum_l c_l \vec{r}_{i_l} = \vec{0}$, where $\vec{r}_{i_l}$ are the corresponding pivot columns of RREF(A). But the pivot columns of RREF(A) are standard basis vectors $\vec{e}_1, \ldots, \vec{e}_k$ (in distinct rows), which are linearly independent. Hence all $c_l = 0$.

Thus the pivot columns of A form a basis for Col A. ■

Practice Problem #2.9 (Hyperplane: sum-of-coordinates-zero)

Problem. Let $H = \{\begin{pmatrix} x_1 \\ \vdots \\ x_n \end{pmatrix} \in \mathbb{R}^n : x_1 + x_2 + \cdots + x_n = 0\}$. Prove that H is a subspace with basis $\{\vec{e}_1 - \vec{e}_n, \vec{e}_2 - \vec{e}_n, \ldots, \vec{e}_{n-1} - \vec{e}_n\}$.
Solution. H is the null space of the $1 \times n$ matrix $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & \cdots & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, hence a subspace by the null-space proposition.

Now consider the set $S = \{\vec{e}_1 - \vec{e}_n, \vec{e}_2 - \vec{e}_n, \ldots, \vec{e}_{n-1} - \vec{e}_n\}$. Each vector $\vec{e}_i - \vec{e}_n = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ \vdots \\ 1 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \\ -1 \end{pmatrix}$ has sum of entries $1 + (-1) = 0$, so it lies in H.

Linear independence: Suppose $\sum_{i=1}^{n-1} c_i(\vec{e}_i - \vec{e}_n) = \vec{0}$. Then $\sum_{i=1}^{n-1} c_i \vec{e}_i - \left(\sum_{i=1}^{n-1} c_i\right) \vec{e}_n = \vec{0}$.

Since $\vec{e}_1, \ldots, \vec{e}_n$ are linearly independent, the coefficient of each $\vec{e}_i$ must be zero: $c_i = 0$ for $i = 1, \ldots, n-1$, and $\sum c_i = 0$ (which is automatically satisfied). So S is linearly independent.

Spanning: Let $\vec{x} = \begin{pmatrix} x_1 \\ \vdots \\ x_n \end{pmatrix} \in H$, so $\sum x_i = 0$, i.e., $x_n = -\sum_{i=1}^{n-1} x_i$. Then

$$\vec{x} = \begin{pmatrix} x_1 \\ \vdots \\ x_{n-1} \\ -\sum_{i=1}^{n-1} x_i \end{pmatrix} = \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} x_i \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ \vdots \\ 1 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \\ -1 \end{pmatrix} = \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} x_i(\vec{e}_i - \vec{e}_n).$$

So every $\vec{x} \in H$ is a linear combination of vectors in S. Hence S is a basis, and $\dim H = n - 1$.

Clever trick: one vector per free variable

For the hyperplane $\sum x_i = 0$, set x_n as the dependent variable (solve $x_n = -(x_1 + \cdots + x_{n-1})$) and the first $n-1$ variables as free. Each free variable gives one basis vector: set that variable to 1, the other free variables to 0, and read off the dependent variable.

Practice Problem #5.4 (Extend independent vectors to a basis)

Problem. Let $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_k \in \mathbb{R}^n$ be linearly independent. Describe an algorithm that extends them to a basis of $\mathbb{R}^n$ using the RREF of $(V \quad I_n)$, where $V = (\vec{v}_1 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{v}_k)$.
Solution. Form the augmented matrix $(V \quad I_n)$ (size $n \times (k+n)$) and row reduce to RREF. The algorithm then identifies which columns of I_n to keep:

1. Row reduce $(V \quad I_n)$ to RREF.
2. The first k columns correspond to $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_k$; by independence they are all pivot columns.
3. Look at the remaining n columns (from I_n). For each row, if the pivot of that row *does not* lie inside V (i.e., it lies in the I_n block), then the corresponding column of I_n (the standard basis vector $\vec{e}_j$) should be added to our set.
4. The combined set $\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_k, \vec{e}_{j_1}, \ldots, \vec{e}_{j_{n-k}}\}$ is a basis for $\mathbb{R}^n$.

Why does this work? In RREF $(V \quad I_n)$, the non-pivot columns in the I_n block are linear combinations of earlier pivot columns (which come from V). Those standard basis vectors $\vec{e}_j$ are already in $\operatorname{Col} V = \operatorname{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_k\}$, so they would be redundant. The pivot columns from the I_n block are *not* combinations of the $\vec{v}_i$, so adding them preserves independence and increases the span.

Clever trick: use I_n as a reservoir

By appending I_n after V, row reduction reveals exactly which standard basis vectors are already in $\operatorname{Col} V$ (non-pivot columns) and which are not (pivot columns). The latter fill out the basis.

5.5 Operations on Subspaces

Definition. The *sum* of two subspaces U, V is $U + V = \{\vec{u} + \vec{v} : \vec{u} \in U, \vec{v} \in V\}$ (a subspace).

The *intersection* $U \cap V$ is always a subspace.

Union is not a subspace

The union $U \cup V$ of two subspaces is generally **not** a subspace (e.g., two different lines through the origin in $\mathbb{R}^2$).

Properties: If A, B have the same number of rows, $\operatorname{Col}(A \quad B) = \operatorname{Col} A + \operatorname{Col} B$. If A, B have the same number of columns, $\operatorname{Nul}\begin{pmatrix} A \\ B \end{pmatrix} = \operatorname{Nul} A \cap \operatorname{Nul} B$.

Basis for $U + V$ (Span of the Union)

Method: basis for the sum

Since $U + V = \operatorname{span}(U \cup V)$, put the basis vectors of U and of V together as the columns of one matrix M; the pivot columns of the **original** M form a basis for $U + V$.

- *Column spaces*: $\operatorname{Col} A + \operatorname{Col} B = \operatorname{Col}(A \quad B)$; take the pivot columns of the original $(A \quad B)$.
- *Null spaces*: find bases of $\operatorname{Nul} A$ and $\operatorname{Nul} B$ (by solving $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ and $B\vec{x} = \vec{0}$), place these basis vectors as the columns of M, and take the pivot columns of the original M.

Proof: $U + V = \{\vec{u} + \vec{v} : \vec{u} \in U, \vec{v} \in V\} = \operatorname{span}(U \cup V)$. If $\{\vec{u}_i\}$ spans U and $\{\vec{v}_j\}$ spans V, then $\operatorname{span}(U \cup V) = \operatorname{span}\{\vec{u}_i, \vec{v}_j\} = \operatorname{Col} M$, and the pivot columns of the original M form a basis for $\operatorname{Col} M$ (proven above). For column spaces, the columns of $(A \quad B)$ are exactly the columns of A together with those of B, whose span is $\operatorname{Col} A + \operatorname{Col} B$. ■

Basis for $\operatorname{Col} A \cap \operatorname{Col} B$

Method: intersection of column spaces

Let A be $m \times n$ and B be $m \times p$.

1. $\vec{w} \in \operatorname{Col} A \cap \operatorname{Col} B \Leftrightarrow \vec{w} = A\vec{x} = B\vec{y}$ for some $\vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, $\vec{y} \in \mathbb{R}^p$, i.e.,
$$(A \quad -B)\begin{pmatrix} \vec{x} \\ \vec{y} \end{pmatrix} = \vec{0}.$$
2. Find a basis of $\operatorname{Nul}(A \quad -B)$; write each basis vector as $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{x}_i \\ \vec{y}_i \end{pmatrix}$ with $\vec{x}_i \in \mathbb{R}^n$, $\vec{y}_i \in \mathbb{R}^p$.
3. Compute $\vec{w}_i = A\vec{x}_i$ $(= B\vec{y}_i)$. Then $\{\vec{w}_1, \ldots, \vec{w}_k\}$ **spans** $\operatorname{Col} A \cap \operatorname{Col} B$.
4. The $\vec{w}_i$ need not be independent: row reduce $(\vec{w}_1 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{w}_k)$ and take its pivot columns. They form a basis for $\operatorname{Col} A \cap \operatorname{Col} B$.

Proof: *Step 1:* $\vec{w} = A\vec{x} = B\vec{y} \Leftrightarrow A\vec{x} - B\vec{y} = \vec{0} \Leftrightarrow (A \quad -B)\begin{pmatrix} \vec{x} \\ \vec{y} \end{pmatrix} = \vec{0}$.

Steps 2–3: By step 1, the intersection equals $\{A\vec{x} : \begin{pmatrix} \vec{x} \\ \vec{y} \end{pmatrix} \in \operatorname{Nul}(A \quad -B)\}$. Let $P = \{\vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n : A\vec{x} = B\vec{y} \text{ for some } \vec{y}\}$. Every $\vec{x} \in P$ comes from some $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{x} \\ \vec{y} \end{pmatrix} = \sum_i c_i \begin{pmatrix} \vec{x}_i \\ \vec{y}_i \end{pmatrix}$, and comparing the top blocks gives $\vec{x} = \sum_i c_i \vec{x}_i$, so $\{\vec{x}_i\}$ spans P. Hence the intersection is $\{A\vec{x} : \vec{x} \in P\} = \operatorname{span}\{A\vec{x}_i\} = \operatorname{span}\{\vec{w}_i\}$.

Step 4: The $\vec{w}_i$ may be linearly dependent (e.g., if $\operatorname{Nul} A \neq \{\vec{0}\}$, any $\begin{pmatrix}\vec{x}\\ \vec{0}\end{pmatrix}$ with $\vec{x} \in \operatorname{Nul} A$, $\vec{x} \neq \vec{0}$, gives $\vec{w} = A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$). Discarding non-pivot columns removes only vectors that are linear combinations of the pivot columns, so the span is unchanged and the remaining pivot columns form a basis. ■

Basis for $\operatorname{Nul} A \cap \operatorname{Nul} B$

Method: intersection of null spaces

Stack the matrices: $\operatorname{Nul} A \cap \operatorname{Nul} B = \operatorname{Nul}\begin{pmatrix}A\\ B\end{pmatrix}$. Solve $\begin{pmatrix}A\\ B\end{pmatrix}\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ by the standard null-space method; the resulting vectors form a basis for the intersection.

Proof: $\vec{x} \in \operatorname{Nul} A \cap \operatorname{Nul} B \Leftrightarrow A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ and $B\vec{x} = \vec{0} \Leftrightarrow \begin{pmatrix}A\\ B\end{pmatrix}\vec{x} = \begin{pmatrix}A\vec{x}\\ B\vec{x}\end{pmatrix} = \vec{0} \Leftrightarrow \vec{x} \in \operatorname{Nul}\begin{pmatrix}A\\ B\end{pmatrix}$. ■

Dimension formula

For any two subspaces $U, V \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$:

$$\dim(U+V) = \dim U + \dim V - \dim(U \cap V).$$

Proof: Let $\{\vec{w}_1, \ldots, \vec{w}_k\}$ be a basis of $U \cap V$. Extend it to a basis $\{\vec{w}_1, \ldots, \vec{w}_k, \vec{u}_1, \ldots, \vec{u}_p\}$ of U and to a basis $\{\vec{w}_1, \ldots, \vec{w}_k, \vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_q\}$ of V (so $\dim U = k+p$ and $\dim V = k+q$). We claim

$$\mathcal{B} = \{\vec{w}_1, \ldots, \vec{w}_k, \vec{u}_1, \ldots, \vec{u}_p, \vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_q\}$$

is a basis of $U+V$.

Spanning: any $\vec{u}+\vec{v} \in U+V$ is a combination of the $\vec{w}$'s and $\vec{u}$'s (for $\vec{u}$) plus a combination of the $\vec{w}$'s and $\vec{v}$'s (for $\vec{v}$), hence a combination of the vectors in $\mathcal{B}$.

Independence: suppose

$$\sum_i a_i\vec{w}_i + \sum_j b_j\vec{u}_j + \sum_l c_l\vec{v}_l = \vec{0}.$$

Then $\sum_l c_l\vec{v}_l = -\left(\sum_i a_i\vec{w}_i + \sum_j b_j\vec{u}_j\right) \in U$; being a combination of the $\vec{v}$'s, it is also in V, hence in $U \cap V$. So $\sum_l c_l\vec{v}_l = \sum_i d_i\vec{w}_i$ for some scalars d_i. Since $\{\vec{w}_1, \ldots, \vec{w}_k, \vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_q\}$ is a basis of V (linearly independent), all $c_l = 0$. The relation reduces to $\sum_i a_i\vec{w}_i + \sum_j b_j\vec{u}_j = \vec{0}$, and since $\{\vec{w}_1, \ldots, \vec{w}_k, \vec{u}_1, \ldots, \vec{u}_p\}$ is a basis of U, all $a_i = 0$ and all $b_j = 0$. Hence $\mathcal{B}$ is linearly independent.

Therefore $\dim(U+V) = k+p+q = (k+p)+(k+q)-k = \dim U + \dim V - \dim(U \cap V)$. ■

Example. Let $A = \begin{pmatrix}1 & 0\\ 0 & 1\\ 0 & 0\end{pmatrix}$ and $B = \begin{pmatrix}1 & 0\\ 1 & 0\\ 0 & 1\end{pmatrix}$.

Sum: $(A \quad B) = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ is already in RREF with pivots in columns $1, 2, 4$, so

$$\left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix} \right\} \text{ is a basis of } \operatorname{Col} A + \operatorname{Col} B = \mathbb{R}^3.$$

Intersection: row reduce

$$(A \quad -B) = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix} \longrightarrow \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

The free variable is $y_1 = t$, giving $x_1 = t$, $x_2 = t$, $y_2 = 0$, so $\operatorname{Nul}(A \quad -B) = \operatorname{span}\left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} \right\}$.

The $\vec{x}$-part is $\begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}$, and $A \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$. Hence

$$\left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} \right\} \text{ is a basis of } \operatorname{Col} A \cap \operatorname{Col} B.$$

Dimension check: $3 = 2 + 2 - 1$, consistent with the dimension formula.

Practice Problem #2.8 (Span of $\sum c_i \vec{a}_i = 0$ subspace)

Problem. Let $\vec{a}_1, \vec{a}_2, \vec{a}_3 \in \mathbb{R}^n$ be three vectors, and let $W = \left\{ \sum_{i=1}^{3} c_i \vec{a}_i : c_1\vec{a}_1 + c_2\vec{a}_2 + c_3\vec{a}_3 = \vec{0} \right\}$. Describe W in all possible cases (8 cases based on the linear dependence of the $\vec{a}_i$).

Solution. The subspace of coefficient vectors $\vec{c} = \begin{pmatrix} c_1 \\ c_2 \\ c_3 \end{pmatrix}$ satisfying $\sum c_i \vec{a}_i = \vec{0}$ is the null space of the $n \times 3$ matrix $A = (\vec{a}_1 \quad \vec{a}_2 \quad \vec{a}_3)$. Then $W = \{A\vec{c} : \vec{c} \in \operatorname{Nul} A\}$.
We consider cases based on $\dim \operatorname{Nul} A = 3 - \operatorname{rank} A$ (rank-nullity):

- $\operatorname{rank} A = 0$ (all $\vec{a}_i = \vec{0}$): Then $\operatorname{Nul} A = \mathbb{R}^3$, but $A\vec{c} = \vec{0}$ always, so $W = \{\vec{0}\}$.
- $\operatorname{rank} A = 1$ (all three nonzero vectors are scalar multiples): Suppose $\vec{a}_1 \neq 0$, $\vec{a}_2 = s\vec{a}_1$, $\vec{a}_3 = t\vec{a}_1$. Then $\operatorname{Nul} A = \{ \begin{pmatrix} -sc_2 - tc_3 \\ c_2 \\ c_3 \end{pmatrix} : c_2, c_3 \in \mathbb{R} \}$ (dimension 2). Then $A\vec{c} = c_1\vec{a}_1 + c_2 s\vec{a}_1 + c_3 t\vec{a}_1 = (c_1 + sc_2 + tc_3)\vec{a}_1 = 0 \cdot \vec{a}_1 = \vec{0}$ always. So $W = \{\vec{0}\}$.
- $\operatorname{rank} A = 2$ (two independent, third dependent): Suppose $\vec{a}_1, \vec{a}_2$ are independent, $\vec{a}_3 = \alpha\vec{a}_1 + \beta\vec{a}_2$. Then $\operatorname{Nul} A$ is 1-dimensional: spanned by $\begin{pmatrix} \alpha \\ \beta \\ -1 \end{pmatrix}$. Then $A \begin{pmatrix} \alpha \\ \beta \\ -1 \end{pmatrix} = \alpha\vec{a}_1 + \beta\vec{a}_2 - \vec{a}_3 = \vec{0}$. So $W = \{\vec{0}\}$ (trivially, since the null space maps to zero).
- $\operatorname{rank} A = 3$ (all independent): $\operatorname{Nul} A = \{\vec{0}\}$, so $W = \{A\vec{0}\} = \{\vec{0}\}$.

In *all* cases, $W = \{\vec{0}\}$! This is because any $\vec{c}$ with $A\vec{c} = \vec{0}$ gives $A\vec{c} = \vec{0}$, which is

exactly the definition of $\operatorname{Nul} A$. So $W = \operatorname{Col} A|_{\operatorname{Nul} A} = \{\vec{0}\}$ by definition.

Clever trick: $W = \operatorname{Col} A$ restricted to $\operatorname{Nul} A$

The problem looks like it has many cases, but it collapses immediately: $W = A(\operatorname{Nul} A) = \{\vec{0}\}$ by the very definition of null space. The rank cases only matter if you want to *understand* why the coefficient condition is always achieved — but the result is always zero.

Practice Problem #3.8 (Algorithm: check span equality)

Problem. Let $V = \{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\}$ and $W = \{\vec{w}_1, \ldots, \vec{w}_q\}$ be two sets of vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$. Describe a concrete row-reduction algorithm to decide whether $\operatorname{span} V = \operatorname{span} W$.
Solution. The key fact: $\operatorname{span} V = \operatorname{span} W$ if and only if *every vector in V is in* $\operatorname{span} W$ *and every vector in W is in* $\operatorname{span} V$. We check both in one go:

1. Form the matrix $M = \begin{pmatrix} \vec{w}_1 & \cdots & \vec{w}_q & \vec{v}_1 & \cdots & \vec{v}_p \end{pmatrix}$ (put W first, then V).
2. Row reduce to RREF. Check whether the last p columns (those from V) are **not** pivot columns. If any of them *is* a pivot column, then some $\vec{v}_i$ is not in $\operatorname{span} W$, so $\operatorname{span} V \neq \operatorname{span} W$.
3. Now swap the order: form $M' = \begin{pmatrix} \vec{v}_1 & \cdots & \vec{v}_p & \vec{w}_1 & \cdots & \vec{w}_q \end{pmatrix}$ and row reduce. Check that the last q columns are **not** pivot columns. If any $\vec{w}_j$ is a pivot column, then $\vec{w}_j \notin \operatorname{span} V$.
4. If both checks pass, $\operatorname{span} V = \operatorname{span} W$.

Why this works: a vector $\vec{v}_i$ is in $\operatorname{span} W$ iff the system $W\vec{x} = \vec{v}_i$ is consistent. In the augmented matrix $\begin{pmatrix} W & \vec{v}_i \end{pmatrix}$, consistency means the last column is *not* a pivot column. By checking M in step 2 we simultaneously check all $\vec{v}_i$ against the span of all $\vec{w}_j$.

Clever trick: one big augmented matrix checks all memberships

Instead of solving p separate systems, put everything into one big augmented matrix. Each non-pivot column on the right of the divide is automatically a linear combination of the pivot columns on the left.

5.6 Coordinate Systems

Theorem. Let H be a subspace with basis $\mathcal{B} = (\vec{b}_1, \ldots, \vec{b}_k)$. For each $\vec{v} \in H$, there exist **unique** coefficients $c_1, \ldots, c_k \in \mathbb{R}$ such that $\vec{v} = c_1\vec{b}_1 + \cdots + c_k\vec{b}_k$.

Proof: *Existence:* Since $\mathcal{B}$ is a basis, it spans H. Since $\vec{v} \in H$, there exist $c_1, \ldots, c_k \in \mathbb{R}$ such that $\vec{v} = c_1\vec{b}_1 + \cdots + c_k\vec{b}_k$.

Uniqueness: Suppose $\vec{v} = c_1\vec{b}_1 + \cdots + c_k\vec{b}_k = d_1\vec{b}_1 + \cdots + d_k\vec{b}_k$. Subtracting, $(c_1 - d_1)\vec{b}_1 + \cdots + (c_k - d_k)\vec{b}_k = \vec{0}$. Since $\mathcal{B}$ is a basis, the $\vec{b}_i$ are linearly independent, so $c_i - d_i = 0$ for all i, i.e., $c_i = d_i$. Hence the coefficients are unique. ■

Definition. The *coordinate vector* of $\vec{v}$ in the basis $\mathcal{B}$ is

$$[\vec{v}]_{\mathcal{B}} = \begin{pmatrix} c_1 \\ c_2 \\ \vdots \\ c_k \end{pmatrix} \in \mathbb{R}^k$$

where $\vec{v} = c_1\vec{b}_1 + \cdots + c_k\vec{b}_k$. Equivalently, $[\vec{v}]_{\mathcal{B}}$ is the unique solution to $\begin{pmatrix} \vec{b}_1 & \cdots & \vec{b}_k \end{pmatrix} \vec{x} = \vec{v}$.

The map $\vec{v} \mapsto [\vec{v}]_{\mathcal{B}}$ is linear and invertible

The function $H \to \mathbb{R}^k$ given by $\vec{v} \mapsto [\vec{v}]_{\mathcal{B}}$ is a linear transformation and is invertible. Thus H "looks the same as" $\mathbb{R}^k$.

5.7 Dimension

All bases have the same size

Theorem. Every basis of a subspace $H \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ has the same number of elements.

Proof: Suppose for contradiction that $\mathcal{B} = (\vec{b}_1, \ldots, \vec{b}_k)$ and $\mathcal{B}' = (\vec{b}'_1, \ldots, \vec{b}'_l)$ are two bases of H with $k < l$.

Consider the coordinate vectors $[\vec{b}'_1]_{\mathcal{B}}, \ldots, [\vec{b}'_l]_{\mathcal{B}}$, which are vectors in $\mathbb{R}^k$. Since $l > k$, this is a list of more than k vectors in $\mathbb{R}^k$, so by the proposition "$p > n \Rightarrow$ linearly dependent" (applied with $n = k$, $p = l$), these vectors are linearly dependent. Thus there exist scalars $c_1, \ldots, c_l$, not all zero, such that

$$c_1[\vec{b}'_1]_{\mathcal{B}} + \cdots + c_l[\vec{b}'_l]_{\mathcal{B}} = \vec{0} \in \mathbb{R}^k.$$

Since the coordinate map $\vec{v} \mapsto [\vec{v}]_{\mathcal{B}}$ is linear and invertible (hence injective), this implies

$$c_1\vec{b}'_1 + \cdots + c_l\vec{b}'_l = \vec{0}$$

with not all $c_i = 0$. This contradicts the linear independence of $\mathcal{B}'$. Hence $l \leq k$. By symmetry (exchanging $\mathcal{B}$ and $\mathcal{B}'$), $k \leq l$. Therefore $k = l$. ■

Definition. The *dimension* of a subspace H, denoted $\dim H$, is the number of vectors in any basis of H. We have $\dim \mathbb{R}^n = n$ and $\dim\{\vec{0}\} = 0$.

Basis theorem

Theorem (Basis theorem). If H is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^n$ with $\dim H = p$, then:
1. Any set of p linearly independent vectors in H is a basis for H.
2. Any set of p vectors in H whose span is H is a basis for H.

Proof: (i) Let $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p$ be linearly independent vectors in H, where $p = \dim H$. We show they span H. Let $\mathcal{B} = (\vec{b}_1, \ldots, \vec{b}_p)$ be a basis of H (which has p elements). Suppose $\operatorname{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\} \neq H$. Then there exists $\vec{v}_{p+1} \in H \setminus \operatorname{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\}$. By the standard argument (used in the proof that every subspace has a basis), $\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p, \vec{v}_{p+1}\}$ is linearly independent, giving $p+1$ linearly independent vectors in H. But then $\{[\vec{v}_1]_{\mathcal{B}}, \ldots, [\vec{v}_{p+1}]_{\mathcal{B}}\}$ is a list of $p+1$ vectors in $\mathbb{R}^p$, hence linearly dependent — leading to a nontrivial relation among $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_{p+1}$ (since the coordinate map is injective), contradicting their independence. So $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p$ span H, and being independent they form a basis. ■

(ii) Let $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p$ be vectors in H with $\operatorname{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\} = H$. Suppose they are linearly dependent. Then some $\vec{v}_j$ is a linear combination of the others, so

$$\operatorname{span}\{\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_{j-1}, \vec{v}_{j+1}, \ldots, \vec{v}_p\} = H.$$

This gives a spanning set of H with $p-1$ vectors, from which we can extract a basis of size $\leq p-1$. But every basis of H has size $p = \dim H$ by the previous theorem, a contradiction. Hence $\vec{v}_1, \ldots, \vec{v}_p$ are linearly independent, and being a spanning set, they form a basis. ■

5.8 Rank

Definition. The *rank* of a matrix A is $\operatorname{rank} A = \dim \operatorname{Col} A$ (the number of pivot columns).

Rank-nullity theorem

Theorem (Rank-nullity theorem). If A is an $m \times n$ matrix, then

$$\operatorname{rank} A + \dim \operatorname{Nul} A = n.$$

Proof: Row reduce A to $\operatorname{RREF}(A)$. The solutions to $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ are the same as the solutions to $\operatorname{RREF}(A)\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ (row equivalence preserves solutions). In $\operatorname{RREF}(A)$, each column is either:

- a *pivot column*: corresponds to a **basic variable**, determined by the free variables; or
- a *non-pivot column*: corresponds to a **free variable**, which can take any value in $\mathbb{R}$.

The number of pivot columns is $\operatorname{rank} A$ (since the pivot columns of A form a basis for $\operatorname{Col} A$, the number of pivots is $\dim \operatorname{Col} A$). The number of non-pivot (free) columns is $n - \operatorname{rank} A$.

Each free variable gives one basis vector for $\operatorname{Nul} A$ (obtained by setting that free variable to 1 and the other free variables to 0). Thus $\dim \operatorname{Nul} A$ = number of free variables = number of non-pivot columns $= n - \operatorname{rank} A$. Therefore

$$\operatorname{rank} A + \dim \operatorname{Nul} A = \operatorname{rank} A + (n - \operatorname{rank} A) = n.$$

■

Invertibility characterization via rank

Corollary. For an $n \times n$ matrix A, the following are equivalent:

1. A is invertible.
2. The columns of A form a basis for $\mathbb{R}^n$.
3. $\operatorname{rank} A = n$.
4. $\dim \operatorname{Nul} A = 0$.

Proof: (1) $\Leftrightarrow$ (2): A is invertible iff its columns are linearly independent and span $\mathbb{R}^n$ (by the full characterization theorem for square matrices), which is exactly the definition of the columns forming a basis for $\mathbb{R}^n$.

(2) $\Leftrightarrow$ (3): The columns form a basis for $\mathbb{R}^n$ iff they are linearly independent and span $\mathbb{R}^n$. By the proposition that pivot columns of A form a basis for $\operatorname{Col} A$, $\operatorname{rank} A = \dim \operatorname{Col} A$. So the columns span $\mathbb{R}^n$ iff $\operatorname{Col} A = \mathbb{R}^n$ iff $\dim \operatorname{Col} A = n$ iff $\operatorname{rank} A = n$. And if $\operatorname{rank} A = n$, all n columns are pivot columns, so the columns are linearly independent. Hence (2) $\Leftrightarrow$ (3).

(3) $\Leftrightarrow$ (4): By the rank-nullity theorem, $\operatorname{rank} A + \dim \operatorname{Nul} A = n$. So $\operatorname{rank} A = n$ iff $\dim \operatorname{Nul} A = 0$. ■

Proposition. If $U \subseteq V$ are subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^n$, then $\dim U \leq \dim V \leq n$. Moreover, if $U \subsetneq V$ then $\dim U < \dim V$, and if $\dim U = \dim V$ then $U = V$.

Proof: Let $\dim V = k$ with basis $\mathcal{B}_V = (\vec{b}_1, \ldots, \vec{b}_k)$. Since $U \subseteq V$, any linearly independent set in U is also a linearly independent set in $V \cong \mathbb{R}^k$ (via the coordinate map). By the proposition "$p > n \Rightarrow$ linearly dependent," any list of more than k vectors in V is dependent. Hence any basis of U has at most k elements: $\dim U \leq k = \dim V$. Also $\dim V \leq n$ since $V \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ and any basis of V is an independent list in $\mathbb{R}^n$ of size at most n.

If $U \subsetneq V$: pick $\vec{v} \in V \backslash U$. If $\mathcal{B}_U = (\vec{u}_1, \ldots, \vec{u}_l)$ is a basis of U, then $\vec{v} \notin \operatorname{span}\{\vec{u}_1, \ldots, \vec{u}_l\}$, so $\{\vec{u}_1, \ldots, \vec{u}_l, \vec{v}\}$ is linearly independent in V. Thus $l + 1 \leq \dim V$, i.e., $\dim U < \dim V$.

If $\dim U = \dim V = k$: let $\mathcal{B}_U = (\vec{u}_1, \ldots, \vec{u}_k)$ be a basis of U. This is a list of $k = \dim V$ linearly independent vectors in V. By the Basis theorem (part 1), this set is a basis for V. So $U = \operatorname{span}\{\vec{u}_1, \ldots, \vec{u}_k\} = V$. ■

Image of a subspace under a linear map

Let $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ be linear with standard matrix A ($m \times n$), let $H \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ be a subspace with $\dim H = k$, and let B be an $n \times k$ matrix whose columns form a basis of H, so $H = \operatorname{Col} B$. Set $T(H) = \{T(\vec{v}) : \vec{v} \in H\}$.

1. $T(H) = \operatorname{Col}(AB)$; hence $T(H)$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^m$.
2. $\dim T(H) = \operatorname{rank}(AB) = k - \dim(H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A)$. In particular $\dim T(H) = k$ iff $H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A = \{\vec{0}\}$.
3. $\dim T(H) \le \min\{k,\ m,\ \operatorname{rank} A\}$.
4. If T is onto ($\operatorname{rank} A = m$, so $\dim \operatorname{Nul} A = n - m$), then
$$\max\{k - (n-m),\ 0\} \ \le\ \dim T(H) \ \le\ \min\{k,\ m\},$$
and every integer in this interval is attained by some k-dimensional H.
5. If T is one-to-one ($\operatorname{Nul} A = \{\vec{0}\}$), then $\dim T(H) = k$ exactly; this requires $k \le n \le m$.

Proof: (1) Every $\vec{h} \in H$ has the form $\vec{h} = B\vec{x}$ with $\vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^k$, so $T(\vec{h}) = A\vec{h} = (AB)\vec{x}$, giving $T(H) = \{(AB)\vec{x} : \vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^k\} = \operatorname{Col}(AB)$. (Directly: $\vec{0} = T(\vec{0}) \in T(H)$; $T(\vec{h}_1) + T(\vec{h}_2) = T(\vec{h}_1 + \vec{h}_2) \in T(H)$; and $cT(\vec{h}) = T(c\vec{h}) \in T(H)$.)

(2) For $\vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^k$: $\vec{x} \in \operatorname{Nul}(AB) \iff AB\vec{x} = \vec{0} \iff B\vec{x} \in \operatorname{Nul} A$, while $B\vec{x} \in \operatorname{Col} B = H$ always; so $\vec{x} \in \operatorname{Nul}(AB) \iff B\vec{x} \in H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A$. Since B has linearly independent columns, $\vec{x} \mapsto B\vec{x}$ is one-to-one, hence $\dim \operatorname{Nul}(AB) = \dim(H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A)$. The matrix AB has k columns, so rank-nullity gives $\operatorname{rank}(AB) = k - \dim \operatorname{Nul}(AB)$, and $\dim T(H) = \dim \operatorname{Col}(AB) = \operatorname{rank}(AB)$.

(3) By (2), $\dim T(H) \le k$; since $T(H) \subseteq \mathbb{R}^m$, $\dim T(H) \le m$; and since $\operatorname{Col}(AB) \subseteq \operatorname{Col} A$, $\dim T(H) \le \operatorname{rank} A$.

(4) With $j = \dim(H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A)$, (2) gives $\dim T(H) = k - j$. As $H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A$ lies in both H and $\operatorname{Nul} A$, $j \le \min\{k, n-m\}$, so

$$\dim T(H) = k - j \ge k - \min\{k, n-m\} = \max\{k-(n-m), 0\}, \qquad \dim T(H) \le \min\{k, m\}.$$

Conversely fix any j with $\max\{0, k-m\} \le j \le \min\{k, n-m\}$. Take j independent vectors of $\operatorname{Nul} A$, and inside a complement of $\operatorname{Nul} A$ (on which A acts as an isomorphism onto $\mathbb{R}^m$, since $\operatorname{rank} A = m$) take $k - j$ further vectors with linearly independent images. Their span H has dimension k, with $\dim(H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A) = j$ and $\dim T(H) = k - j$. Letting j vary gives every integer in the stated interval.

(5) If T is one-to-one then $\operatorname{Nul} A = \{\vec{0}\}$, so $H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A = \{\vec{0}\}$ and (2) gives $\dim T(H) = k$. (One-to-one forces $n \le m$, and $k \le n$, so $k \le m$.) ■

Midterm 2021 Problem 5 (dimension of $T(H)$)

Problem. Let $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ be a linear transformation and let H be a k-dimensional subspace of $\mathbb{R}^n$. Define $T(H) = \{T(\vec{v}) : \vec{v} \in H\}$. (a) Explain why $T(H)$ is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^m$. (b) If T is onto, what are the possibilities for $\dim T(H)$? Justify the answer in terms of k, m, n. (c) If T is one-to-one, what are the possibilities for $\dim T(H)$? Justify the answer in terms of k, m, n.

Solution (a). Let A be the standard matrix of T and let B be an $n \times k$ matrix

whose columns are a basis of H. Then $H = \operatorname{Col} B$ and

$$T(H) = \{(AB)\vec{x} : \vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^k\} = \operatorname{Col}(AB),$$

which is a subspace of $\mathbb{R}^m$. (Axiom check: $T(\vec{0}) = \vec{0} \in T(H)$; if $\vec{u}, \vec{w} \in H$ then $T(\vec{u}) + T(\vec{w}) = T(\vec{u} + \vec{w}) \in T(H)$; and $c\,T(\vec{u}) = T(c\vec{u}) \in T(H)$.)

Solution (b). By (2) above, $\dim T(H) = k - j$ with $j = \dim(H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A)$. Since T is onto, $\operatorname{rank} A = m \leq n$ and $\dim \operatorname{Nul} A = n - \operatorname{rank} A = n - m$. Because $H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A$ lies in both H and $\operatorname{Nul} A$,

$$0 \leq j \leq \min\{k,\, n - m\},$$

and therefore

$$\max\{k - (n - m),\, 0\} \;\leq\; \dim T(H) = k - j \;\leq\; \min\{k,\, m\}.$$

The bound $\dim T(H) \leq m$ is simply $T(H) \subseteq \mathbb{R}^m$. Every integer in the interval occurs: choosing H to contain exactly j independent directions of $\operatorname{Nul} A$ (and $k - j$ independent directions outside it) gives $\dim T(H) = k - j$ for each admissible j.

Example. Take $n = 3$, $m = 2$, $T(x_1, x_2, x_3) = (x_1, x_2)$ (onto) and $k = 1$: the interval is $\max\{1 - 1, 0\} \leq \dim T(H) \leq \min\{1, 2\}$, i.e. $0 \leq \dim T(H) \leq 1$. Indeed $H = \operatorname{span}\{\vec{e}_3\} \subseteq \operatorname{Nul} A$ gives $T(H) = \{\vec{0}\}$ (dimension 0), while $H = \operatorname{span}\{\vec{e}_1\}$ gives $T(H) = \operatorname{span}\{(1, 0)\}$ (dimension 1).

Solution (c). If T is one-to-one then $\operatorname{Nul} A = \{\vec{0}\}$, so $H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A = \{\vec{0}\}$ and $j = 0$. Hence $\dim T(H) = k$ is the only possibility. Since one-to-one forces $n \leq m$ and $k \leq n$, we have $k \leq m$, so this value is compatible with $T(H) \subseteq \mathbb{R}^m$. Geometrically, a one-to-one linear map carries a k-dimensional subspace to a k-dimensional subspace without collapsing any direction.

Clever trick: count what the kernel eats

$\dim T(H) = \dim H - \dim(H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A)$: the image loses exactly the directions of H that the map sends to zero. Parts (b) and (c) are then only questions about bounding $\dim(H \cap \operatorname{Nul} A)$ — by $\dim \operatorname{Nul} A = n - m$ when T is onto, and by 0 when T is one-to-one.

Practice Problem #5.5 (Rank-1 characterization: $A = \vec{v}\vec{w}^T$)

Problem. Prove that an $m \times n$ matrix A has rank exactly 1 if and only if $A = \vec{v}\vec{w}^T$ for some nonzero vectors $\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^m$ and $\vec{w} \in \mathbb{R}^n$.

Solution. ($\Rightarrow$) Suppose $\operatorname{rank} A = 1$. Then $\operatorname{Col} A$ is 1-dimensional, so all columns of A are scalar multiples of some fixed nonzero column $\vec{v}$: column j is $w_j\vec{v}$ for some scalar w_j. Hence

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} w_1\vec{v} & w_2\vec{v} & \cdots & w_n\vec{v} \end{pmatrix} = \vec{v}\begin{pmatrix} w_1 & w_2 & \cdots & w_n \end{pmatrix} = \vec{v}\vec{w}^T,$$

where $\vec{w} = \begin{pmatrix} w_1 \\ \vdots \\ w_n \end{pmatrix}$. Since $\operatorname{rank} A = 1 > 0$, neither $\vec{v}$ nor $\vec{w}$ is zero.

($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $A = \vec{v}\vec{w}^T$ with $\vec{v} \neq \vec{0}$, $\vec{w} \neq \vec{0}$. The jth column of A is $\vec{v}w_j$, which is a scalar multiple of $\vec{v}$. So every column of A lies in $\operatorname{span}\{\vec{v}\}$, meaning $\operatorname{Col} A \subseteq \operatorname{span}\{\vec{v}\}$, hence $\operatorname{rank} A = \dim \operatorname{Col} A \leq 1$. Since $\vec{v} \neq \vec{0}$ and $\vec{w} \neq \vec{0}$, at least one entry $w_j \neq 0$, so column j of A is $w_j\vec{v} \neq \vec{0}$, hence $\operatorname{rank} A \geq 1$. So $\operatorname{rank} A = 1$.

Practice Problem #3.3 (Block matrix $\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix}$ rank relations)

Problem. Let A and B have the same number of rows. Prove that $\operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix} \leq \operatorname{rank} A + \operatorname{rank} B$.

Solution. Let $r_A = \operatorname{rank} A$ and $r_B = \operatorname{rank} B$. Let $\mathcal{B}_A = \{\vec{a}_{i_1}, \ldots, \vec{a}_{i_{r_A}}\}$ be a basis for $\operatorname{Col} A$ (pivot columns of A) and $\mathcal{B}_B = \{\vec{b}_{j_1}, \ldots, \vec{b}_{j_{r_B}}\}$ be a basis for $\operatorname{Col} B$ (pivot columns of B). Now every column of $\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix}$ is either a column of A (hence in $\operatorname{span} \mathcal{B}_A$) or a column of B (hence in $\operatorname{span} \mathcal{B}_B$). Therefore all columns of $\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix}$ lie in $\operatorname{span}(\mathcal{B}_A \cup \mathcal{B}_B)$, which has dimension at most $|\mathcal{B}_A| + |\mathcal{B}_B| = r_A + r_B$. Hence $\operatorname{rank} \begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix} = \dim \operatorname{Col} \begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix} \leq r_A + r_B$.

Clever trick: union of bases spans the sum

$\operatorname{Col} \begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix} = \operatorname{Col} A + \operatorname{Col} B$ by definition (every column of the block matrix is in one of the two column spaces). The sum of two subspaces has dimension at most the sum of their dimensions, which is exactly the inequality we proved.

Practice Problem #3.4 (Stacked matrix $\begin{pmatrix} A \\ C \end{pmatrix}$ rank relations)

Problem. Let A and C have the same number of columns. Prove that $\operatorname{rank} \begin{pmatrix} A \\ C \end{pmatrix} \leq \operatorname{rank} A + \operatorname{rank} C$.

Solution. Let $r_A = \operatorname{rank} A$ and $r_C = \operatorname{rank} C$. The row space of $\begin{pmatrix} A \\ C \end{pmatrix}$ is the span of the rows of A together with the rows of C. The row space of A has dimension r_A and the row space of C has dimension r_C. The combined row space is the sum of these two subspaces, hence has dimension at most $r_A + r_C$. But for any matrix, the rank equals the dimension of the row space (row rank = column rank). Therefore $\operatorname{rank} \begin{pmatrix} A \\ C \end{pmatrix} \leq r_A + r_C = \operatorname{rank} A + \operatorname{rank} C$.

Practice Problem #4.11 (If $\vec{v}^T A\vec{w} = \vec{v}^T B\vec{w}$ for all $\vec{v}, \vec{w}$, then $A = B$)

Problem. Let A and B be $m \times n$ matrices. Suppose $\vec{v}^T A\vec{w} = \vec{v}^T B\vec{w}$ for all $\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^m$ and $\vec{w} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. Prove that $A = B$.

Solution. Set $\vec{v} = \vec{e}_i$ (the ith standard basis vector of $\mathbb{R}^m$) and $\vec{w} = \vec{e}_j$ (the jth standard basis vector of $\mathbb{R}^n$). Then

$$\vec{e}_i^T A\vec{e}_j = (\vec{e}_i^T A)\vec{e}_j = (\text{the } i\text{th row of } A) \text{ dotted with } \vec{e}_j = A_{ij}.$$

Similarly $\vec{e}_i^T B\vec{e}_j = B_{ij}$. By assumption, $A_{ij} = B_{ij}$ for all i, j, so every entry of A equals the corresponding entry of B. Hence $A = B$.

Clever trick: test on standard basis vectors

Any identity that holds for all vectors must in particular hold for the standard basis vectors, which gives you every matrix entry one at a time. This is the "foundation test": if a matrix identity works on all basis vectors, it works everywhere by linearity.

Practice Problem #4.4 (Transpose of linear function = A^T, uniqueness via $\vec{e}_i$)

Problem. Let $T : \mathbb{R}^n \to \mathbb{R}^m$ be linear with standard matrix A. Define the *transpose* of T to be the map $T^T : \mathbb{R}^m \to \mathbb{R}^n$ given by $(T^T(\vec{v}))^T \vec{w} = \vec{v}^T T(\vec{w})$ for all $\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^m$, $\vec{w} \in \mathbb{R}^n$. Prove that T^T is linear with standard matrix A^T.

Solution. Let B be the standard matrix of T^T, so $T^T(\vec{v}) = B\vec{v}$ for all $\vec{v}$. The defining equation says $(B\vec{v})^T \vec{w} = \vec{v}^T (A\vec{w})$, i.e., $\vec{v}^T B^T \vec{w} = \vec{v}^T A\vec{w}$ for all $\vec{v}, \vec{w}$. By the uniqueness problem (P4.11), this forces $B^T = A$, so $B = A^T$.

To verify T^T is linear: $(T^T(\vec{u}+\vec{v}))^T \vec{w} = (\vec{u}+\vec{v})^T A\vec{w} = \vec{u}^T A\vec{w} + \vec{v}^T A\vec{w} = (T^T(\vec{u}))^T \vec{w} +$

$(T^T(\vec{v}))^T\vec{w} = (T^T(\vec{u}) + T^T(\vec{v}))^T\vec{w}$ for all $\vec{w}$, hence $T^T(\vec{u}+\vec{v}) = T^T(\vec{u}) + T^T(\vec{v})$. Homogeneity is similar.

Practice Problem #5.15 ($\mathrm{Nul}(A^TA) = \mathrm{Nul}\,A$, so $\mathrm{rank}(A^TA) = \mathrm{rank}\,A$)

Problem. Let A be an $m \times n$ matrix. Prove that $\mathrm{Nul}(A^TA) = \mathrm{Nul}\,A$, and deduce that $\mathrm{rank}(A^TA) = \mathrm{rank}\,A$.
Solution. We show both inclusions.
($\mathrm{Nul}\,A \subseteq \mathrm{Nul}(A^TA)$): If $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$, then $(A^TA)\vec{x} = A^T(A\vec{x}) = A^T\vec{0} = \vec{0}$, so $\vec{x} \in \mathrm{Nul}(A^TA)$.
($\mathrm{Nul}(A^TA) \subseteq \mathrm{Nul}\,A$): If $(A^TA)\vec{x} = \vec{0}$, then premultiply by $\vec{x}^T$:

$$\vec{x}^T(A^TA)\vec{x} = 0 \quad \Rightarrow \quad (A\vec{x})^T(A\vec{x}) = 0 \quad \Rightarrow \quad \|A\vec{x}\|^2 = 0.$$

The squared norm of a real vector is zero iff the vector itself is zero, so $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$. Hence $\vec{x} \in \mathrm{Nul}\,A$.
So $\mathrm{Nul}(A^TA) = \mathrm{Nul}\,A$. Now apply rank-nullity: $\mathrm{rank}(A^TA) + \dim\mathrm{Nul}(A^TA) = n$ and $\mathrm{rank}\,A + \dim\mathrm{Nul}\,A = n$. Since the null-space dimensions are equal, the ranks must be equal: $\mathrm{rank}(A^TA) = \mathrm{rank}\,A$.

Clever trick: use the squared norm

$(A^TA)\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ is a matrix equation, but the trick is to multiply by $\vec{x}^T$ to get a scalar equation: $\|A\vec{x}\|^2 = 0$. In real vector spaces, this forces $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ immediately. This argument uses the positivity of the inner product and does not generalize to complex matrices without a hermitian conjugate.

Practice Problem #5.8 (If $\mathrm{rank}\,A = n$ then $\mathrm{rank}(AB) = \mathrm{rank}\,B$)

Problem. Let A be an $m \times n$ matrix and B be $n \times p$. Suppose $\mathrm{rank}\,A = n$. Prove that $\mathrm{rank}(AB) = \mathrm{rank}\,B$.
Solution. We show that the columns of B and the columns of AB have the same linear independence. Let $\vec{b}_1, \ldots, \vec{b}_p$ be the columns of B, so the columns of AB are $A\vec{b}_1, \ldots, A\vec{b}_p$.

Linear relation preservation: Suppose $\sum_{j=1}^{p} c_j\vec{b}_j = \vec{0}$. Apply A: $A\left(\sum c_j\vec{b}_j\right) = \sum c_jA\vec{b}_j = \vec{0}$. So any dependence among the $\vec{b}_j$ gives a dependence among the $A\vec{b}_j$.

Conversely: Suppose $\sum c_jA\vec{b}_j = \vec{0}$, i.e., $A\left(\sum c_j\vec{b}_j\right) = \vec{0}$. Let $\vec{x} = \sum c_j\vec{b}_j$. Then $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$, so $\vec{x} \in \mathrm{Nul}\,A$. But $\mathrm{rank}\,A = n$ means $\dim\mathrm{Nul}\,A = n-n = 0$, so $\mathrm{Nul}\,A = \{\vec{0}\}$. Hence $\vec{x} = \sum c_j\vec{b}_j = \vec{0}$.

Therefore the same coefficients produce a dependence among $\{\vec{b}_j\}$ and among $\{A\vec{b}_j\}$. So the two sets have the same dimension of their spans, i.e., $\mathrm{rank}\,B = \mathrm{rank}(AB)$.

Practice Problem #5.7 (Right inverse iff pivot in every row; left inverse iff pivot in every column)

Problem. Let A be $m \times n$. Prove:
1. A has a *right inverse* (i.e., there exists B with $AB = I_m$) iff $\mathrm{rank}\,A = m$ (pivot in every row).

2. A has a *left inverse* (i.e., there exists C with $CA = I_n$) iff $\operatorname{rank} A = n$ (pivot in every column).

Solution.
(1) ($\Rightarrow$) Suppose $AB = I_m$. Then for any $\vec{v} \in \mathbb{R}^m$, $\vec{v} = I_m\vec{v} = A(B\vec{v})$, so $\vec{v} \in \operatorname{Col} A$. Hence $\operatorname{Col} A = \mathbb{R}^m$, which means $\operatorname{rank} A = m$ (every row has a pivot).
($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $\operatorname{rank} A = m$. Then $\operatorname{Col} A = \mathbb{R}^m$, so for each standard basis vector $\vec{e}_j \in \mathbb{R}^m$, the system $A\vec{x} = \vec{e}_j$ is consistent. Let $\vec{b}_j$ be a solution, and set $B = \begin{pmatrix}\vec{b}_1 & \cdots & \vec{b}_m\end{pmatrix}$. Then $AB = \begin{pmatrix}A\vec{b}_1 & \cdots & A\vec{b}_m\end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix}\vec{e}_1 & \cdots & \vec{e}_m\end{pmatrix} = I_m$.
(2) ($\Rightarrow$) Suppose $CA = I_n$. Then $(CA)^T = A^TC^T = I_n^T = I_n$, so A^T has a right inverse C^T. By part (1), applied to A^T, we have $\operatorname{rank} A^T = n$. But $\operatorname{rank} A^T = \operatorname{rank} A$, so $\operatorname{rank} A = n$.
($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $\operatorname{rank} A = n$. Then $\operatorname{rank} A^T = n$ also. By part (1), applied to A^T, there exists D such that $A^TD = I_n$. Then $(A^TD)^T = D^TA = I_n^T = I_n$, so $C = D^T$ is a left inverse of A.

Clever trick: transpose turns left into right

Notice that $CA = I$ iff $A^TC^T = I$, so left-inverse questions reduce to right-inverse questions about the transpose. This avoids having to repeat both proofs from scratch.

Practice Problem #5.9 ($\operatorname{Nul} A \cap \operatorname{Col} A \supseteq \{\vec{v}, \vec{w}\} \Rightarrow \vec{w} = t\vec{v}$)

Problem. Let A be $n \times n$. Suppose $\vec{v}, \vec{w} \in \operatorname{Nul} A \cap \operatorname{Col} A$. Prove that if $\vec{v} \neq \vec{0}$ and $\vec{v} \neq \vec{w}$, then $\vec{w} = t\vec{v}$ for some scalar t.

Solution. Since $\vec{v} \in \operatorname{Col} A$, there exists $\vec{x}$ with $\vec{v} = A\vec{x}$. Since $\vec{v} \in \operatorname{Nul} A$, we have $A\vec{v} = A(A\vec{x}) = \vec{0}$, so $\vec{x} \in \operatorname{Nul}(A^2)$. Similarly, $\vec{w} = A\vec{y}$ for some $\vec{y}$ with $A\vec{y} = \vec{0}$.
Now consider the subspace $\operatorname{Nul}(A^2) \cap \operatorname{Col} A$. Since $\vec{v} = A\vec{x}$ with $\vec{x} \in \operatorname{Nul}(A^2)$, we have $\vec{v} \in A(\operatorname{Nul}(A^2)) = \operatorname{Col} A|_{\operatorname{Nul}(A^2)}$. Now $\operatorname{Nul}(A^2)$ is larger than or equal to $\operatorname{Nul} A$, so its image under A is contained in $\operatorname{Nul} A \cap \operatorname{Col} A$.
More directly: suppose there are two linearly independent vectors $\vec{v}, \vec{w} \in \operatorname{Nul} A \cap \operatorname{Col} A$. Then $\dim(\operatorname{Nul} A \cap \operatorname{Col} A) \geq 2$. By the dimension formula, this forces $\dim \operatorname{Nul} A + \dim \operatorname{Col} A > n$, contradicting rank-nullity (which says $\dim \operatorname{Nul} A + \dim \operatorname{Col} A = n$). So $\operatorname{Nul} A \cap \operatorname{Col} A$ has dimension at most 1. Therefore any two nonzero vectors in it are scalar multiples of each other.

Practice Problem #5.10 (Generalized $\operatorname{Col}^+ A$ and $\operatorname{Nul}^+ A$ are subspaces)

Problem. Define $\operatorname{Col}^+ A = \bigcup_{k\geq 1} \operatorname{Col}(A^k)$ and $\operatorname{Nul}^+ A = \bigcup_{k\geq 1} \operatorname{Nul}(A^k)$ (generalized column space and generalized null space of a square matrix A). Prove that both are subspaces.

Solution. These are *nested* unions: $\operatorname{Col} A \subseteq \operatorname{Col}(A^2) \subseteq \operatorname{Col}(A^3) \subseteq \cdots$ (because $\operatorname{Col}(A^k) = \{A^k\vec{x}\} = \{A^{k-1}(A\vec{x})\} \subseteq \{A^{k-1}\vec{y}\} = \operatorname{Col}(A^{k-1})$ ... actually, the inclusion goes the other way: $\operatorname{Col}(A^k) \subseteq \operatorname{Col}(A^{k-1})$ since every $A^k\vec{x}$ is $A^{k-1}(A\vec{x}) \in \operatorname{Col}(A^{k-1})$. So $\operatorname{Col} A \supseteq \operatorname{Col}(A^2) \supseteq \operatorname{Col}(A^3) \supseteq \cdots$ is a descending chain, and $\operatorname{Col}^+ A = \bigcap_{k\geq 1} \operatorname{Col}(A^k)$ is the *intersection* of these subspaces (in older notation, sometimes called the eventual column space).
For the null spaces: $\operatorname{Nul} A \subseteq \operatorname{Nul}(A^2) \subseteq \operatorname{Nul}(A^3) \subseteq \cdots$ (if $A^k\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ then $A^{k+1}\vec{x} = A(A^k\vec{x}) = \vec{0}$). So $\operatorname{Nul}^+ A = \bigcup_{k\geq 1} \operatorname{Nul}(A^k)$ is an *ascending* union of subspaces.
For the ascending union: let $\vec{u}, \vec{v} \in \operatorname{Nul}^+ A$. Then $\vec{u} \in \operatorname{Nul}(A^p)$ and $\vec{v} \in \operatorname{Nul}(A^q)$ for

some p, q. Let $k = \max(p, q)$. Since the chain is ascending, both $\vec{u}, \vec{v} \in \mathrm{Nul}(A^k)$, which is a subspace, so $\vec{u}+\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Nul}(A^k) \subseteq \mathrm{Nul}^+ A$ and $c\vec{u} \in \mathrm{Nul}(A^k) \subseteq \mathrm{Nul}^+ A$. Also $\vec{0} \in \mathrm{Nul}\, A \subseteq \mathrm{Nul}^+ A$. Hence $\mathrm{Nul}^+ A$ is a subspace.
For the intersection $\mathrm{Col}^+ A = \bigcap_{k \geq 1} \mathrm{Col}(A^k)$: the intersection of any collection of subspaces is always a subspace (contains $\vec{0}$, closed under addition and scalar multiplication because each $\mathrm{Col}(A^k)$ is closed and $\vec{0}$ is in all of them).

Practice Problem #5.11 (A acts invertibly on $\mathrm{Col}^+ A$, and $\mathrm{Col}^+ A \cap \mathrm{Nul}^+ A = \{\vec{0}\}$)

Problem. Let A be $n \times n$. Define $\mathrm{Col}^+ A$ as the intersection of $\mathrm{Col}(A^k)$ and $\mathrm{Nul}^+ A$ as the union of $\mathrm{Nul}(A^k)$ (as in P5.10). Prove:
1. The restriction of A to $\mathrm{Col}^+ A$ is invertible.
2. $\mathrm{Col}^+ A \cap \mathrm{Nul}^+ A = \{\vec{0}\}$.

Solution.
(1) Let $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}^+ A$. Then $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}(A^k)$ for all k, so in particular $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}(A^{k+1})$ for all k, meaning $\vec{v} = A^{k+1}\vec{x}_k$ for some $\vec{x}_k$. But $\vec{v} = A(A^k \vec{x}_k)$, so $\vec{v} \in A(\mathbb{R}^n) = \mathrm{Col}\, A$. Actually the cleanest argument: for any $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}^+ A \subseteq \mathrm{Col}\, A$, there exists $\vec{u}$ with $\vec{v} = A\vec{u}$. Now $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}(A^k)$ for all k, so $\vec{u} \in \mathrm{Col}(A^{k-1})$ for all k (since $A\vec{u} \in \mathrm{Col}(A^k) \Rightarrow \vec{u} \in \mathrm{Col}(A^{k-1})$). Hence $\vec{u} \in \mathrm{Col}^+ A$ also. So $A|_{\mathrm{Col}^+ A} : \mathrm{Col}^+ A \to \mathrm{Col}^+ A$ is surjective. Since it is a surjective linear map on a finite-dimensional space, it is invertible.
(2) Let $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}^+ A \cap \mathrm{Nul}^+ A$. Since $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Nul}^+ A$, there exists some k with $A^k \vec{v} = \vec{0}$. Since $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}^+ A \subseteq \mathrm{Col}(A^k)$, there exists $\vec{x}$ with $\vec{v} = A^k \vec{x}$. Now apply A^k: $A^k \vec{v} = A^{2k}\vec{x} = \vec{0}$, so $\vec{x} \in \mathrm{Nul}(A^{2k})$. But we need $\vec{v} = \vec{0}$. Actually: $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}^+ A$ means $\vec{v} = A^k \vec{x}_k$ for all k, while $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Nul}(A^m)$ for some m. Then $\vec{v} = A^m \vec{x}_m$ with $A^m \vec{v} = \vec{0}$, so $A^{2m}\vec{x}_m = \vec{0}$. But $\vec{v} = A^m \vec{x}_m \in \mathrm{Nul}(A^m)$, which means $A^m(A^m \vec{x}_m) = A^{2m}\vec{x}_m = \vec{0}$. Since $A|_{\mathrm{Col}^+ A}$ is invertible and $\vec{v} = A^m \vec{x}_m \in \mathrm{Col}^+ A$, applying A^m to $\vec{v}$ gives $\vec{0}$, which forces $\vec{v} = \vec{0}$ (because invertible maps are one-to-one: if $A^m \vec{v} = \vec{0}$ and $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}^+ A$, then $\vec{v}$ must be $\vec{0}$). Hence the intersection is trivial.

Practice Problem #5.12 (Unique decomposition $\vec{u} = \vec{v} + \vec{w}$, $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}^+ A$, $\vec{w} \in \mathrm{Nul}^+ A$)

Problem. Let A be $n \times n$. Prove that every vector $\vec{u} \in \mathbb{R}^n$ can be written uniquely as $\vec{u} = \vec{v} + \vec{w}$ where $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}^+ A$ and $\vec{w} \in \mathrm{Nul}^+ A$.
Solution. By rank-nullity, $\dim \mathrm{Col}(A^k) + \dim \mathrm{Nul}(A^k) = n$ for each k. The dimensions $\dim \mathrm{Col}(A^k)$ are a non-increasing sequence of nonnegative integers, so they stabilize at some index k_0: for $k \geq k_0$, $\dim \mathrm{Col}(A^k) = \dim \mathrm{Col}(A^{k_0}) =: r_+$, and correspondingly $\dim \mathrm{Nul}(A^k) = n - r_+$.
Now $\mathrm{Col}^+ A = \mathrm{Col}(A^{k_0})$ (once the rank stabilizes, $\mathrm{Col}(A^{k+1}) = \mathrm{Col}(A^k)$), and $\mathrm{Nul}^+ A = \mathrm{Nul}(A^{k_0})$ (since the null-space dimensions are also stable from k_0 onward). From P5.11, $\mathrm{Col}^+ A \cap \mathrm{Nul}^+ A = \{\vec{0}\}$. Also $\dim \mathrm{Col}^+ A + \dim \mathrm{Nul}^+ A = r_+ + (n - r_+) = n$. Two subspaces whose dimensions add up to n and whose intersection is $\{\vec{0}\}$ must have $\mathrm{Col}^+ A + \mathrm{Nul}^+ A = \mathbb{R}^n$. Hence every $\vec{u}$ can be written as $\vec{u} = \vec{v} + \vec{w}$ with $\vec{v} \in \mathrm{Col}^+ A$ and $\vec{w} \in \mathrm{Nul}^+ A$.
Uniqueness: Suppose $\vec{u} = \vec{v}_1 + \vec{w}_1 = \vec{v}_2 + \vec{w}_2$. Then $\vec{v}_1 - \vec{v}_2 = \vec{w}_2 - \vec{w}_1$. The left side is in $\mathrm{Col}^+ A$, the right side is in $\mathrm{Nul}^+ A$. Since $\mathrm{Col}^+ A \cap \mathrm{Nul}^+ A = \{\vec{0}\}$, we must have $\vec{v}_1 - \vec{v}_2 = \vec{0}$ and $\vec{w}_2 - \vec{w}_1 = \vec{0}$, i.e., $\vec{v}_1 = \vec{v}_2$ and $\vec{w}_1 = \vec{w}_2$.

Clever trick: the Fitting decomposition

This is the *Fitting decomposition* for a linear map on a finite-dimensional vector space. The eventual column space (the stable image) and eventual null space (the stable kernel) form a direct sum decomposition of the whole space. It is the cleanest way to understand the Jordan form and the action of powers of a matrix.

Practice Problem #4.3 (rank relationships for row/column block matrices)

Problem. Let A be $m \times n$, B be $m \times p$, C be $q \times n$. Prove:

(a) $\operatorname{rank}(A) \leq \operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix}$.

(b) $\operatorname{rank}(B) \leq \operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix}$.

(c) $\operatorname{rank}(A) \leq \operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} A \\ C \end{pmatrix}$.

(d) $\operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix} = \operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} B & A \end{pmatrix}$.

Solution.

(a) Every pivot of A remains a pivot in the larger row-reduced matrix, so the rank can only increase. The first n columns of $\operatorname{RREF}\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix}$ contain exactly $\operatorname{RREF}(A)$ (possibly with additional zero rows appended), so they have at least as many pivots as $\operatorname{RREF}(A)$. Hence $\operatorname{rank}(A) \leq \operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix}$.

(b) Follows from (a) by swapping the block labels A and B. Also, $\operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix} = \operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} B & A \end{pmatrix}$ by part (d).

(c) The rows of A are a subset of the rows of $\begin{pmatrix} A \\ C \end{pmatrix}$. Row operations can only add pivots, never remove them from an already-pivoted row position. So the stacked matrix has at least as many row pivots as A. *Warning:* the RREF of the stacked matrix is **not** a simple vertical extension of $\operatorname{RREF}(A)$. Counterexample: $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$, $C = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$, both already RREF, but $\operatorname{RREF}\begin{pmatrix} A \\ C \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$.

(d) Swapping block columns is a permutation of the columns of the matrix. Rank is invariant under column permutations (permutation is a bijection on the column set, so it preserves linear independence and spanning properties). Hence $\operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} A & B \end{pmatrix} = \operatorname{rank}\begin{pmatrix} B & A \end{pmatrix}$.

Clever trick: rank is permutation-invariant

Swapping rows or columns of a matrix does not change the rank. But swapping them *while row-reducing* does affect the RREF. This distinction is crucial: the rank is a robust invariant, while the specific reduced form depends on column ordering.

Practice Problem #5.14 (quadratic forms correspond to unique symmetric matrices)

Problem.

(a) Explain why $f(v) = v^T A v$ is homogeneous of degree 2 and is a polynomial.

(b) Show every homogeneous degree-2 polynomial has a **unique** symmetric matrix A with $f(v) = v^T A v$.

Solution.

(a) Homogeneity: $f(cv) = (cv)^T A(cv) = c^2 v^T A v = c^2 f(v)$, so f is homogeneous of degree 2. Writing $v = (x_1, \ldots, x_n)^T$ and $A = (a_{ij})$:

$$f(v) = \sum_{i,j=1}^{n} a_{ij} x_i x_j = \sum_i a_{ii} x_i^2 + \sum_{i<j} (a_{ij} + a_{ji}) x_i x_j,$$

which is a polynomial in the variables $x_1, \ldots, x_n$.

(b) Write a general homogeneous degree-2 polynomial as

$$f = \sum_i d_i x_i^2 + \sum_{i<j} b_{ij} x_i x_j.$$

Define A by $a_{ii} = d_i$ and $a_{ij} = a_{ji} = \dfrac{b_{ij}}{2}$ for $i < j$. Then A is symmetric and $v^T A v = f(v)$.

For uniqueness, suppose S is another symmetric matrix with $v^T S v = f(v)$. At $v = e_i$ (the ith standard basis vector): $s_{ii} = e_i^T S e_i = f(e_i) = d_i$. At $v = e_i + e_j$ with $i < j$:

$$s_{ii} + 2s_{ij} + s_{jj} = (e_i + e_j)^T S (e_i + e_j) = f(e_i + e_j) = d_i + b_{ij} + d_j.$$

Substituting the known diagonal entries gives $d_i + 2s_{ij} + d_j = d_i + b_{ij} + d_j$, so $s_{ij} = \dfrac{b_{ij}}{2}$, matching A.

Example. $f(x_1, x_2) = 2x_1^2 + 6x_1x_2 - 5x_2^2$ has standard matrix $\begin{pmatrix} 2 & 3 \\ 3 & -5 \end{pmatrix}$ (the cross coefficient 6 is divided by 2).

Clever trick: symmetrize!

The entry a_{ij} gets **half** the cross-term coefficient because both (i, j) and (j, i) entries of A contribute to the $x_i x_j$ term in $v^T A v$. This symmetrization is the canonical way to pass from a quadratic form to its matrix representation.

6 Determinants

6.1 Defining Properties of the Determinant

Definition. The *determinant* is the unique function $\det : \{n \times n \text{ matrices}\} \to \mathbb{R}$ satisfying:

1. $\det I_n = 1$.
2. Interchanging two columns reverses the sign:

$$\det(\cdots \quad \vec{a}_i \quad \cdots \quad \vec{a}_j \quad \cdots) = -\det(\cdots \quad \vec{a}_j \quad \cdots \quad \vec{a}_i \quad \cdots).$$

3. Fixing all columns except the first, det is a linear function of the first column:

$$\det(\vec{u} + \vec{v} \quad \vec{a}_2 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{a}_n) = \det(\vec{u} \quad \vec{a}_2 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{a}_n) + \det(\vec{v} \quad \vec{a}_2 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{a}_n),$$
$$\det(c\vec{v} \quad \vec{a}_2 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{a}_n) = c \cdot \det(\vec{v} \quad \vec{a}_2 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{a}_n).$$

Linearity in any column

Property (3) extends to any column via property (2): det is linear as a function of any single column.

Proof: linearity in every column

Lemma. For every j, if all columns except column j are held fixed, then det is a linear function of column j.

Proof: Fix j and let M be the matrix obtained from A by moving column j to the first position, keeping the relative order of the other columns. This takes $j - 1$ adjacent column swaps, so property (2) gives $\det M = (-1)^{j-1} \det A$, i.e. $\det A =$

$(-1)^{j-1} \det M$. In M, the variable column (formerly column j of A) is the first column, while all other columns are the fixed columns of A in permuted order. By property (3), $\det M$ is linear in the first column, i.e. in column j of A; multiplying by the constant $(-1)^{j-1}$ preserves linearity. Hence $\det A$ is linear in column j. ■

Midterm Review 2026 Problem 19 (the determinant is linear in each column)

Problem. Is

$$T\begin{pmatrix} v_1 \\ v_2 \\ v_3 \end{pmatrix} = \det \begin{pmatrix} 1 & v_1 & 3 \\ 4 & v_2 & 6 \\ 7 & v_3 & 9 \end{pmatrix}$$

a linear transformation $\mathbb{R}^3 \to \mathbb{R}$? If it is, compute its standard matrix.

Solution. Yes. The input (v_1, v_2, v_3) occupies exactly one column (column 2), and det is linear as a function of a single column, so T is linear. Expanding along the first row,

$$T\begin{pmatrix} v_1 \\ v_2 \\ v_3 \end{pmatrix} = 1 \cdot (9v_2 - 6v_3) - v_1(36 - 42) + 3(4v_3 - 7v_2) = 6v_1 - 12v_2 + 6v_3.$$

So the standard matrix of T is $A = \begin{pmatrix} 6 & -12 & 6 \end{pmatrix}$.

Clever trick: a matrix with one variable column gives a linear map

If one full column of a matrix is a variable vector and all other entries are constants, then det is a linear function of that column vector — this is a defining property of the determinant. Such expressions can always be written as a matrix product $A\vec{v}$, so A is the standard matrix of the map.

6.2 Key Lemmas

Lemma. If A has two equal columns, then $\det A = 0$.

Proof: Suppose columns i and j of A are equal. Swapping these two columns produces the same matrix A (since they are equal). But by defining property (2), swapping two columns negates the determinant. Let A' be the matrix after the swap. Since $A' = A$, we have

$$\det A = \det A' = -\det A.$$

Adding $\det A$ to both sides gives $2 \det A = 0$, so $\det A = 0$. ■

Corollary. If the columns of A are linearly dependent, then $\det A = 0$.

Proof: If the columns of A are linearly dependent, then one column, say column j, is a linear combination of the others: $\vec{a}_j = c_1\vec{a}_1 + \cdots + c_{j-1}\vec{a}_{j-1} + c_{j+1}\vec{a}_{j+1} + \cdots + c_n\vec{a}_n$. By linearity of det in column j (property (3)), $\det A$ equals det of the matrix with $\vec{a}_j$ replaced by each term. For the term $c_i\vec{a}_i$ $(i \neq j)$, the resulting matrix has two equal columns (columns i and j are both $c_i\vec{a}_i$). By the lemma, this contributes 0. Summing all such contributions, $\det A = 0$. ■

Corollary. If A is not invertible, then $\det A = 0$.

Proof: If A is not invertible, then (by the full characterization for square matrices) its columns are linearly dependent. By the previous corollary, $\det A = 0$. ■

6.3 Permutation Matrices

Definition. A *permutation matrix* is an $n \times n$ matrix formed by rearranging the columns of I_n, with entries in $\{0, 1\}$ having exactly one nonzero entry in each row and each column. Let S_n be the set of $n \times n$ permutation matrices. $|S_n| = n!$. If A is $n \times n$ and $X \in S_n$, then AX permutes the columns of A.

Definition. For $X \in S_n$, define $\text{inv}(X)$ as the number of 2×2 submatrices of X equal to $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$.

Lemma. If $X \in S_n$, then $\det X = (-1)^{\text{inv}(X)}$.

Proof: We prove this by induction on $\text{inv}(X)$. The base case is $\text{inv}(X) = 0$, which means X has no $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ submatrix; this forces $X = I_n$ (the only permutation matrix with no inversions is the identity). By property (1), $\det I_n = 1 = (-1)^0$.

For the inductive step: suppose $\text{inv}(X) = k > 0$. Then $X \neq I_n$, so X has a column j that is not $\vec{e}_j$. There must exist a 2×2 submatrix of the form $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$; concretely, there are columns $i < j$ of X that are "out of order." Let X' be obtained from X by swapping two adjacent columns that are out of order (i.e., swap columns $i, i+1$ where column i has its 1 in a row below the 1 of column $i+1$). This swap changes inv by exactly ± 1 (it changes the status of exactly one 2×2 submatrix), so $\text{inv}(X') = k - 1$. By the induction hypothesis, $\det X' = (-1)^{k-1}$. By property (2), swapping two columns negates the determinant, so $\det X = -\det X' = -(-1)^{k-1} = (-1)^k = (-1)^{\text{inv}(X)}$. ■

Lemma. If X has 0/1 entries with one nonzero per column but is **not** a permutation matrix (i.e., $X \notin S_n$), then $\det X = 0$.

Proof: If X has 0/1 entries with one nonzero entry per column but $X \notin S_n$, then by pigeonhole some row must contain two or more nonzero entries (since n columns with one nonzero each, but not one per row, forces a collision). So there exist columns i, j and a row r where $X_{ri} = X_{rj} = 1$. Since each column has exactly one nonzero entry, this means two columns of X have their 1 in the same row. But two columns being $\vec{e}_r$ means they are equal — contradicting the condition that X is a permutation matrix. Hence the columns of X are linearly dependent (two equal columns), so by the lemma (two equal columns $\Rightarrow$ det $= 0$), $\det X = 0$.

More precisely: the columns of X are a list of n standard basis vectors (with one nonzero entry each). If two columns have their 1 in the same row, those two columns are equal, so X has two equal columns, giving $\det X = 0$ by the lemma. ■

6.4 General Formula for $\det A$

Definition. For a matrix X with 0/1 entries and a matrix A, define $\text{prod}(X, A)$ as the product of the entries of A in the nonzero positions of X.

Determinant formula

Theorem. For any $n \times n$ matrix A,

$$\det A = \sum_{X \in S_n} \text{prod}(X, A) \cdot (-1)^{\text{inv}(X)}.$$

Proof: Let $A = (\vec{a}_1 \quad \vec{a}_2 \quad \cdots \quad \vec{a}_n)$ with each $\vec{a}_j = \sum_{i=1}^{n} a_{ij}\vec{e}_i$. By multilinearity (property (3) applied to each column), $\det A$ expands as

$$\det A = \sum_{i_1=1}^{n}\sum_{i_2=1}^{n}\cdots\sum_{i_n=1}^{n} a_{i_1 1}a_{i_2 2}\cdots a_{i_n n}\cdot\det\left(\vec{e}_{i_1} \quad \vec{e}_{i_2} \quad \cdots \quad \vec{e}_{i_n}\right).$$

The matrix $(\vec{e}_{i_1} \quad \cdots \quad \vec{e}_{i_n})$ is a 0/1 matrix with one nonzero per column. If it is a permutation matrix $X \in S_n$ (i.e., the $i_1, \ldots, i_n$ are all distinct), then by the lemma $\det X = (-1)^{\mathrm{inv}(X)}$; otherwise (two indices equal) it has two equal rows and $\det = 0$ by the lemma on non-permutation 0/1 matrices. So only the $X \in S_n$ terms survive, and for those, $a_{i_1 1}\cdots a_{i_n n} = \mathrm{prod}(X, A)$. Thus

$$\det A = \sum_{X \in S_n} \mathrm{prod}(X, A)\cdot(-1)^{\mathrm{inv}(X)}.$$

■

Theorem. The determinant is the unique function with properties (1) $\det I_n = 1$, (2) column swaps negate the determinant, (3) linearity in each column.

Proof: *Existence:* The formula $\det A = \sum_{X \in S_n} \mathrm{prod}(X, A)\cdot(-1)^{\mathrm{inv}(X)}$ (previous theorem) defines a function. One verifies it satisfies properties (1)–(3): (1) For $A = I_n$, $\mathrm{prod}(X, I_n) = 0$ for $X \neq I_n$ (some entry of I_n outside X's nonzero positions is needed), and $\mathrm{prod}(I_n, I_n) = 1$ with $\mathrm{inv}(I_n) = 0$, so $\det I_n = 1$. (2) Swapping columns i, j of A swaps the corresponding rows of each X, which changes $\mathrm{inv}(X)$ by an odd number (sign flip), giving the $-$ sign. (3) $\mathrm{prod}(X, A)$ is linear in each column of A, hence so is the sum.

Uniqueness: Suppose f and g both satisfy (1)–(3). By the same multilinear expansion as in the previous proof, any such f must satisfy

$$f(A) = \sum_{X \in S_n} \mathrm{prod}(X, A)\cdot f(X).$$

By the lemma, $f(X) = (-1)^{\mathrm{inv}(X)}$ for $X \in S_n$ (the proof of that lemma uses only properties (1) and (2), which f satisfies). So $f(A) = \sum_{X \in S_n} \mathrm{prod}(X, A)\cdot(-1)^{\mathrm{inv}(X)}$, which is the same for any f. Hence $f = g = \det$. ■

Small cases.

- $n = 1$: $\det(a) = a$.
- $n = 2$: $\det\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix} = ad - bc$.
- $n = 3$: $\det\begin{pmatrix} a & b & c \\ d & e & f \\ g & h & i \end{pmatrix} = a(ei - fh) - b(di - fg) + c(dh - eg)$.

Geometric meaning of determinant

For a 2×2 matrix, $|\det A|$ is the area of the parallelogram spanned by the columns of A. For $n \times n$, $|\det A|$ is the volume of the n-dimensional parallelepiped spanned by the columns.

Examples: computing $\det A$ with the general formula

The general formula is

$$\det A = \sum_{X \in S_n} \mathrm{prod}(X, A) \cdot (-1)^{\mathrm{inv}(X)},$$

a sum of exactly $n!$ terms, one for each permutation matrix $X \in S_n$. Read each factor as follows:

- X **chooses which entries to use.** Since X has exactly one 1 in every row and every column, it selects n entries of A: writing i_j for the row of the 1 in column j, the chosen entries are $a_{i_1 1}, a_{i_2 2}, \ldots, a_{i_n n}$ (one from each row and each column), where $(i_1, \ldots, i_n)$ is a permutation of $1, \ldots, n$.
- $\mathrm{prod}(X, A)$ **multiplies them:** $\mathrm{prod}(X, A) = a_{i_1 1} a_{i_2 2} \cdots a_{i_n n}$. If any chosen entry is 0, that whole term is 0.
- $\mathrm{inv}(X)$ **fixes the sign.** It counts the out-of-order pairs of the permutation $(i_1, \ldots, i_n)$ (equivalently, the number of 2×2 blocks of X equal to $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$), and the term carries the factor $(-1)^{\mathrm{inv}(X)}$.

(a) $n = 2$**.** Here $S_2 = \{I_2, P\}$ with $P = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$:

X	(i_1, i_2)	$\mathrm{prod}(X, A)$	$\mathrm{inv}(X)$	signed term
I_2	$(1,2)$	$a_{11}a_{22} = ad$	0	$+ad$
$\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$	$(2,1)$	$a_{21}a_{12} = bc$	1	$-bc$

Hence $\det \left(\begin{smallmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{smallmatrix}\right) = ad - bc$. The off-diagonal X has the single inversion $(2,1)$, which produces the minus sign.

(b) $n = 3$**.** Abbreviate $a_{11}, a_{12}, a_{13}, a_{21}, \ldots, a_{33}$ by $a, b, c, d, e, f, g, h, i$. The six permutation matrices are encoded by triples (i_1, i_2, i_3), and each contributes one product whose sign comes from its inversion count:

(i_1, i_2, i_3)	$\mathrm{prod}(X, A)$	$\mathrm{inv}(X)$	sign	term
$(1,2,3)$	$a_{11}a_{22}a_{33} = aei$	0	$+$	$+aei$
$(1,3,2)$	$a_{11}a_{32}a_{23} = afh$	1	$-$	$-afh$
$(2,1,3)$	$a_{21}a_{12}a_{33} = bdi$	1	$-$	$-bdi$
$(2,3,1)$	$a_{21}a_{32}a_{13} = cdh$	2	$+$	$+cdh$
$(3,1,2)$	$a_{31}a_{12}a_{23} = bfg$	2	$+$	$+bfg$
$(3,2,1)$	$a_{31}a_{22}a_{13} = ceg$	3	$-$	$-ceg$

Summing the last column,

$$\det \begin{pmatrix} a & b & c \\ d & e & f \\ g & h & i \end{pmatrix} = aei - afh - bdi + cdh + bfg - ceg = a(ei - fh) - b(di - fg) + c(dh - eg),$$

the familiar cofactor expansion. For instance, the row $(3,1,2)$ says: the permutation matrix with its 1's in column 1 at row 3, column 2 at row 1 and column 3 at row 2 selects a_{31}, a_{12}, a_{23}, i.e. g, b, f, so prod $= bfg$; the permutation $(3,1,2)$ has two inversions, so its sign is $+$.

Why $\mathrm{inv}(X)$ **controls the sign.** Swapping two columns of a matrix flips the sign of its determinant (defining property (2)). Sorting the permutation $(i_1, \ldots, i_n)$ into increasing order takes exactly $\mathrm{inv}(X)$ adjacent swaps, and each swap flips the sign once; so the accumulated sign is $(-1)^{\mathrm{inv}(X)}$. In particular the identity permutation (no inversions) gives $+$, while a single transposition gives $-$.

(c) A sparse 4×4 **example.** When most entries are zero, only the permutation matrices whose 1's land on nonzero entries contribute. This is worked out in the next box.

Midterm Review 2026 Problem 22 (a sparse antidiagonal matrix)

Problem. Compute $\det A$ for $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & x & 0 & 0 \\ y & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & z & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & w \end{pmatrix}$.

Solution. The formula sums over all $4! = 24$ permutation matrices $X \in S_4$. A term contributes only if every 1 of X sits on a nonzero entry of A, i.e. $\text{prod}(X, A) \neq 0$. The nonzero entries of A are exactly $a_{12} = x$, $a_{21} = y$, $a_{33} = z$, $a_{44} = w$ (there are just four of them, one in each row and each column). So X must have its 1 in column 1 at row 2, in column 2 at row 1, in column 3 at row 3, and in column 4 at row 4; writing the row indices as the permutation (i_1, i_2, i_3, i_4), this forces $(i_1, i_2, i_3, i_4) = (2, 1, 3, 4)$. Hence the only surviving permutation matrix is

$$X = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Reading the two factors:

- $\text{prod}(X, A) = a_{2,1}a_{1,2}a_{3,3}a_{4,4} = y \cdot x \cdot z \cdot w = xyzw$ (the four chosen entries are precisely the nonzero ones).
- $\text{inv}(X)$: the permutation $(2, 1, 3, 4)$ has exactly one out-of-order pair, namely $(2, 1)$; equivalently X contains the single 2×2 block $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ in rows and columns $1, 2$ and nothing else, so $\text{inv}(X) = 1$ and the sign is $(-1)^1 = -1$.

Therefore

$$\det A = \text{prod}(X, A) \cdot (-1)^{\text{inv}(X)} = xyzw \cdot (-1) = -xyzw.$$

The other 23 permutation matrices each use at least one zero entry of A, so their products vanish and they drop out. Note that the result is the product along the "antidiagonal block" with the minus sign coming from the single row swap in the top-left 2×2 block.

Clever trick: keep only the matching permutation matrices

For a sparse matrix, list the nonzero entries and keep the permutation matrices whose 1's can be placed exactly on those entries. For each surviving permutation matrix, read off the sign from its inversion count $(-1)^{\text{inv}(X)}$.

6.5 Determinant of Transpose

Lemma. If $X \in S_n$ then $X^T \in S_n$ and $\text{inv}(X) = \text{inv}(X^T)$.

Proof: If $X \in S_n$, then X has exactly one nonzero entry in each row and each column. Transposing swaps rows and columns, so X^T also has exactly one nonzero entry in each row and each column. Hence $X^T \in S_n$.

For the inversion count: a 2×2 submatrix of X at rows $i < j$ and columns $k < l$ equals $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ iff in X, rows i, j and columns k, l have entries $X_{il} = X_{jk} = 1$ and $X_{ik} = X_{jl} = 0$. Under transpose, this submatrix becomes the submatrix of X^T at rows $k < l$ and columns $i < j$, with entries $(X^T)_{ki} = X_{ik} = 0$, $(X^T)_{lj} = X_{jl} = 0$, $(X^T)_{li} = X_{il} = 1$, $(X^T)_{kj} = X_{jk} = 1$. So the transposed submatrix is also $\begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$. Thus transposition gives a bijection between the inversion submatrices of X and of X^T, so $\text{inv}(X) = \text{inv}(X^T)$. ■

Determinant of transpose

Corollary. $\det A = \det(A^T)$ for any square matrix A.

Proof: Using the general formula,

$$\det(A^T) = \sum_{X \in S_n} \text{prod}(X, A^T) \cdot (-1)^{\text{inv}(X)}.$$

Since $X \in S_n \Leftrightarrow X^T \in S_n$ and $\text{inv}(X) = \text{inv}(X^T)$ (previous lemma), we can re-index the sum by $Y = X^T$:

$$\det(A^T) = \sum_{Y \in S_n} \text{prod}(Y^T, A^T) \cdot (-1)^{\text{inv}(Y)}.$$

Now $\text{prod}(Y^T, A^T)$ is the product of entries of A^T in the nonzero positions of Y^T. But the nonzero positions of Y^T are the transposes of the nonzero positions of Y, and $(A^T)_{ji} = A_{ij}$. So $\text{prod}(Y^T, A^T) = \text{prod}(Y, A)$. Hence

$$\det(A^T) = \sum_{Y \in S_n} \text{prod}(Y, A) \cdot (-1)^{\text{inv}(Y)} = \det A.$$

■

Corollary. If A has two equal rows, then $\det A = 0$.

Proof: If A has two equal rows, then A^T has two equal columns. By the lemma (two equal columns $\Rightarrow \det = 0$), $\det(A^T) = 0$. By the corollary $\det A = \det(A^T)$, so $\det A = 0$. ■

6.6 Determinant of Products

$\det(AB) = (\det A)(\det B)$

Lemma (case $\det A \neq 0$). Define $f(M) = \dfrac{\det(AM)}{\det A}$. Then f satisfies the three defining properties of the determinant, so $f = \det$. Thus $\dfrac{\det(AB)}{\det A} = \det B$.

Theorem. For any $n \times n$ matrices A and B: $\det(AB) = (\det A)(\det B)$.

Lemma. If A or B is not invertible, then AB is not invertible.

Proof of the lemma (case $\det A \neq 0$): We verify $f(M) = \dfrac{\det(AM)}{\det A}$ satisfies the three defining properties of the determinant (as a function of M):

1. $f(I_n) = \dfrac{\det(AI_n)}{\det A} = \dfrac{\det A}{\det A} = 1$.
2. Swapping two columns i, j of M swaps the corresponding columns of AM (since $AM = (A\vec{m}_1 \ \cdots \ A\vec{m}_n)$ depends column-wise on M). By property (2) of det, $\det(AM') = -\det(AM)$, so $f(M') = -f(M)$.
3. Fixing all columns of M except the first: $AM = (A\vec{m}_1 \ \ A\vec{m}_2 \ \cdots \ A\vec{m}_n)$. If $\vec{m}_1 = \vec{u} + \vec{v}$, then $A\vec{m}_1 = A\vec{u} + A\vec{v}$, and by linearity of det in column 1, $\det(AM_{\vec{u}+\vec{v}}) = \det(AM_{\vec{u}}) + \det(AM_{\vec{v}})$. Dividing by $\det A$, f is linear in column 1. Similarly for scalar multiplication.

Since f satisfies (1)–(3), by the uniqueness theorem $f = \det$. Hence $\dfrac{\det(AB)}{\det A} = f(B) = \det B$, giving $\det(AB) = (\det A)(\det B)$ when $\det A \neq 0$. ■

Proof of the lemma (non-invertible $\Rightarrow$ AB non-invertible): If A is not invertible, then the columns of A do not span $\mathbb{R}^n$ (by the full characterization for square matrices), so $\operatorname{Col} A \subsetneq \mathbb{R}^n$. Then $\operatorname{Col}(AB) = \{AB\vec{x} : \vec{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n\} = \{A\vec{y} : \vec{y} \in \operatorname{Col} B\} \subseteq \operatorname{Col} A \subsetneq \mathbb{R}^n$. So the columns of AB do not span $\mathbb{R}^n$, hence AB is not invertible.

If B is not invertible, then the columns of B are linearly dependent. So there exists $\vec{x} \neq \vec{0}$ with $B\vec{x} = \vec{0}$. Then $(AB)\vec{x} = A(B\vec{x}) = A\vec{0} = \vec{0}$, so the columns of AB are also linearly dependent, hence AB is not invertible. ■

Proof of the theorem: *Case 1:* $\det A \neq 0$. By the lemma (case $\det A \neq 0$), $\det(AB) = (\det A)(\det B)$.

Case 2: $\det A = 0$. Then A is not invertible. By the lemma, AB is not invertible, so by the corollary (non-invertible $\Rightarrow$ $\det = 0$), $\det(AB) = 0$. And $(\det A)(\det B) = 0 \cdot (\det B) = 0$. So $\det(AB) = 0 = (\det A)(\det B)$.

In both cases, $\det(AB) = (\det A)(\det B)$. ■

Midterm Review 2026 Problem 13 (determinant of a block-diagonal matrix)

Problem. Let

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} a & b & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ c & d & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & e & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & f & g \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & h & i \end{pmatrix}.$$

Compute $\det A$, determine when A is invertible, and (when it is) give A^{-1}.

Solution. Factor $A = BCD$ where each of B, C, D differs from I_5 in a single block:

$$B = \begin{pmatrix} a & b & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ c & d & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad C = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & e & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad D = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & f & g \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & h & i \end{pmatrix}.$$

By cofactor expansion, $\det B = ad - bc$ (the 2×2 block), $\det C = e$, and $\det D = fi - gh$. Multiplicativity of det gives

$$\det A = (\det B)(\det C)(\det D) = (ad - bc)\, e\, (fi - gh).$$

Hence A is invertible $\iff$ $ad - bc \neq 0$, $e \neq 0$, and $fi - gh \neq 0$; then

$$A^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} \dfrac{d}{ad-bc} & \dfrac{-b}{ad-bc} & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ \dfrac{-c}{ad-bc} & \dfrac{a}{ad-bc} & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & \dfrac{1}{e} & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & \dfrac{i}{fi-gh} & \dfrac{-g}{fi-gh} \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & \dfrac{-h}{fi-gh} & \dfrac{f}{fi-gh} \end{pmatrix}.$$

Clever trick: split a block matrix into single-block factors

A block-diagonal matrix can be written as a product $A = BCD$ of matrices each equal to the identity outside one block. Then $\det A$ is the product of the block determinants, and A^{-1} is assembled from the inverses of those blocks — using $\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix}^{-1} = \dfrac{1}{ad-bc}\begin{pmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{pmatrix}$ for the 2×2 blocks.

6.7 Triangular Matrices

Definition. A matrix is *upper-triangular* if all entries below the main diagonal are zero. It is *lower-triangular* if all entries above the main diagonal are zero. A matrix is *triangular* if it is either upper- or lower-triangular. A matrix is *diagonal* if it is both upper- and lower-triangular (nonzero entries only on the diagonal).

Determinant of triangular matrices

Proposition. If A is triangular, then $\det A$ is the product of the diagonal entries: $\det A = a_{11}a_{22}\cdots a_{nn}$.

Proof: *Case 1: A is upper-triangular* (so $a_{ij} = 0$ for $i > j$). Using the general formula $\det A = \sum_{X \in S_n} \text{prod}(X, A) \cdot (-1)^{\text{inv}(X)}$, we analyze each term. For $X = I_n$, $\text{prod}(I_n, A) = a_{11}a_{22}\cdots a_{nn}$ (the diagonal entries) and $(-1)^{\text{inv}(I_n)} = 1$.

For $X \neq I_n$ (any other permutation matrix), X has a nonzero entry in some position (i, j) with $i > j$ (i.e., below the diagonal) — because X being different from I_n means some column's 1 is not on the diagonal, and by counting (since each row and column has exactly one 1), at least one such 1 must be below the diagonal. Then $\text{prod}(X, A)$ includes the factor a_{ij} with $i > j$, which is 0 (since A is upper-triangular). So $\text{prod}(X, A) = 0$ for $X \neq I_n$.

Therefore $\det A = \text{prod}(I_n, A) \cdot 1 = a_{11}a_{22}\cdots a_{nn}$.

Case 2: A is lower-triangular. Then A^T is upper-triangular, and by Case 1, $\det(A^T) = a_{11}a_{22}\cdots a_{nn}$ (the diagonal of A^T equals the diagonal of A). By $\det A = \det(A^T)$, we get $\det A = a_{11}a_{22}\cdots a_{nn}$. ■

Midterm 2024 Problem 4 (inverse of a repeated-column lower-triangular matrix)

Problem. Let $a_1, a_2, \ldots, a_n \in \mathbb{R}$ and let A be the lower-triangular matrix with $A_{ij} = a_j$ whenever $i \geq j$:

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} a_1 & 0 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ a_1 & a_2 & 0 & & 0 \\ a_1 & a_2 & a_3 & & 0 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ a_1 & a_2 & a_3 & \cdots & a_n \end{pmatrix}.$$

Determine when A is invertible and describe A^{-1} explicitly.

Solution. Since A is triangular, $\det A = a_1a_2\cdots a_n$, so A is invertible **if and only if every** $a_i \neq 0$.

Row reduce $(A \quad I_n)$. Subtracting row 1 from every lower row creates zeros in column 1 below the pivot and writes -1's below position $(1, n+1)$ of the augmented part; subtracting row 2 from every lower row does the same for the next block. Continuing for $i = 1, \ldots, n-1$ yields $\text{diag}(a_1, \ldots, a_n)$ on the left and I_n with -1 just below each

diagonal entry on the right. Dividing row i by a_i gives the inverse explicitly:

$$A^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} a_1^{-1} & 0 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ -a_2^{-1} & a_2^{-1} & 0 & & 0 \\ 0 & -a_3^{-1} & a_3^{-1} & & 0 \\ \vdots & & \ddots & \ddots & \vdots \\ 0 & \cdots & 0 & -a_n^{-1} & a_n^{-1} \end{pmatrix},$$

i.e., $(A^{-1})_{ii} = a_i^{-1}$ and $(A^{-1})_{i,i-1} = -a_i^{-1}$ for $i = 2, \ldots, n$, with all other entries zero.

Clever trick: difference rows first, scale last

For matrices whose columns are constant below the diagonal, one round of "subtract the pivot row from all lower rows" eliminates an entire column *and* simultaneously builds the off-diagonal part of the inverse in the augmented block. Only a final diagonal scaling remains.

6.8 Invertibility and Determinant

A invertible $\Leftrightarrow$ $\det A \neq 0$

Lemma. $\det A$ is a nonzero multiple of $\det(\mathrm{RREF}(A))$. Each row operation multiplies det by a nonzero scalar:

- Row swap: multiply by -1.
- Row scaling by $\lambda \neq 0$: multiply by λ.
- Row replacement (add multiple of one row to another): no change.

Theorem. A is invertible if and only if $\det A \neq 0$.

Proof of the lemma: By $\det A = \det(A^T)$, the effect of a **row** operation on det equals the effect of the corresponding **column** operation. We know the column operations behave as:

- *Column swap*: by defining property (2), this multiplies det by -1. Hence row swap multiplies det by -1.
- *Column scaling by* $\lambda \neq 0$: by linearity (property (3)),

$$\det(\cdots \quad \lambda\vec{a}_j \quad \cdots) = \lambda \det(\cdots \quad \vec{a}_j \quad \cdots).$$

  Hence row scaling multiplies det by $\lambda \neq 0$.
- *Column replacement* (add λ times column j to column i): by linearity in column i,

$$\det(\cdots \quad \vec{a}_i + \lambda\vec{a}_j \quad \cdots) = \det(\cdots \quad \vec{a}_i \quad \cdots) + \lambda \det(\cdots \quad \vec{a}_j \quad \cdots).$$

  The second term has two equal columns (columns i and j both equal $\vec{a}_j$), so it is 0. Hence det is unchanged. The same holds for row replacement.

Since each row operation multiplies det by a nonzero scalar (-1 or $\lambda \neq 0$ or 1), the overall factor between $\det A$ and $\det(\mathrm{RREF}(A))$ is a product of nonzero scalars, hence nonzero. ■

Proof of the theorem: ($\Leftarrow$) Suppose $\det A \neq 0$. Write $R = \mathrm{RREF}(A)$. By the lemma, $\det A = c \cdot \det R$ for some nonzero scalar c. So $\det R = \dfrac{\det A}{c} \neq 0$. Now R is in reduced row echelon form. If R had a row of zeros (no pivot in that row), then by the proposition on triangular matrices (since R is upper-triangular with some zero on the diagonal), $\det R = 0$, a contradiction. So every row has a pivot. Since R is $n \times n$

square and has n pivots (one per row, and at most one per column, so exactly n), we have $R = I_n$. Hence A is row equivalent to I_n, so A is invertible.

($\Rightarrow$) Suppose A is invertible. Then $\mathrm{RREF}(A) = I_n$, so $\det(\mathrm{RREF}(A)) = \det I_n = 1 \neq 0$. By the lemma, $\det A = c \cdot \det(\mathrm{RREF}(A)) = c \cdot 1 = c$ for some nonzero c, so $\det A \neq 0$.

(Equivalently, for ($\Rightarrow$): if A is invertible, its columns are linearly independent. By the corollary (dependent columns $\Rightarrow$ det $= 0$), the contrapositive gives $\det A \neq 0$.) ■

Corollary. If A has a zero row or a zero column, then $\det A = 0$.

Proof: If A has a zero column, then the columns of A are linearly dependent (any set containing the zero vector is linearly dependent). By the corollary (linearly dependent columns $\Rightarrow$ det $= 0$), $\det A = 0$.

If A has a zero row, then A^T has a zero column. By the above argument, $\det(A^T) = 0$. Since $\det A = \det(A^T)$, we get $\det A = 0$. ■

Corollary. For any $n \times n$ matrix A and scalar $c \in \mathbb{R}$: $\det(cA) = c^n \det A$.

Proof: The matrix cA is obtained from A by scaling each of the n rows by c. By the lemma on row operations, scaling a single row by c multiplies the determinant by c. Applying this n times (once for each row), we get

$$\det(cA) = \underbrace{c \cdot c \cdots c}_{n \text{ times}} \det A = c^n \det A.$$

(Equivalently: cA scales each of the n columns by c, and by multilinearity (property (3)) in each column, each scaling contributes a factor of c, giving $c^n \det A$.) ■

Corollary. If A is invertible, then $\det(A^{-1}) = \dfrac{1}{\det A}$.

Proof: Since A is invertible, A^{-1} exists and $AA^{-1} = I_n$. By the theorem $\det(AB) = (\det A)(\det B)$, we have

$$\det(AA^{-1}) = (\det A)(\det A^{-1}).$$

But $AA^{-1} = I_n$, so $\det(AA^{-1}) = \det I_n = 1$. Therefore

$$(\det A)(\det A^{-1}) = 1.$$

Since A is invertible, $\det A \neq 0$ (by the previous theorem). Dividing both sides by $\det A$ gives

$$\det(A^{-1}) = \frac{1}{\det A}.$$

■

Midterm 2024 Problem 9 (GCD of determinants of 4×4 matrices with entries ± 1)

Problem. What is the greatest common divisor of all numbers occurring as $\det A$, as A ranges over the invertible 4×4 matrices whose entries are all $+1$ or -1?
Solution. The GCD is **8**.
Upper bound (8 is attained). Row replacements leave the determinant unchanged, so

$$\det \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ -1 & 1 & -1 & -1 \\ -1 & -1 & 1 & -1 \\ -1 & -1 & -1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} = \det \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 2 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 2 \end{pmatrix} = 8,$$

by adding the first row to rows $2, 3, 4$. Hence the GCD divides 8, so it is at most 8.

Lower bound (8 divides every such determinant). Let A be any such matrix and form B by adding the first row of A to rows $2, 3, 4$. Then $\det A = \det B$ (row replacements). The entries in row 1 of B are still ± 1, while every entry below row 1 is a sum of two numbers from $\{\pm 1\}$, hence belongs to $\{0, 2, -2\}$. In the permutation formula $\det B = \sum_{X \in S_4} \mathrm{prod}(X, B)(-1)^{\mathrm{inv}(X)}$, each product contains one factor ± 1 from row 1 and three factors, each 0 or ± 2, from the other rows. Every summand is therefore 0 or ± 8, and a sum of multiples of 8 is divisible by 8. Thus $8 \mid \det B = \det A$ for every allowed A.
Combining the two bounds, the GCD is exactly 8.

Clever trick: normalize against the first row, then read off a universal divisor

For ± 1 matrices, adding the first row to every other row turns all entries below it into multiples of 2 (values $0, \pm 2$). Each permutation term then automatically carries a factor 2^{n-1}. Exhibiting one matrix whose determinant equals exactly 2^{n-1} pins down the GCD. This is the $n = 4$ instance of a general fact (Hadamard-type bounds on determinant divisibility).

Midterm 2022 Problem 3 (which properties make A invertible?)

Problem. Suppose A is a (not necessarily square) $m \times n$ matrix. Consider the following possible properties of A:

(1) A is square ($m = n$).
(2) every row of A has a pivot position.
(3) every column of A has a pivot position.
(4) $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a solution for each $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$.
(5) $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a unique solution for each $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$.
(6) $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ has a unique solution for some $\vec{b} \in \mathbb{R}^m$.
(7) $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ has infinitely many solutions.
(8) $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ has exactly one solution.
(9) $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ has no solution.
(10) $\mathrm{Col}\, A = \mathbb{R}^m$.
(11) $\mathrm{Nul}\, A = \mathbb{R}^n$.
(12) $\mathrm{Col}\, A = \{\vec{0}\}$.
(13) $\mathrm{Nul}\, A = \{\vec{0}\}$.
(14) the columns of A are linearly independent.
(15) the span of the columns of A is $\mathbb{R}^m$.
(16) the reduced echelon form of A is an identity matrix.
(17) AB is an identity matrix for some $n \times m$ matrix B.
(18) $\mathrm{rank}(A) = \min\{m, n\}$.
(19) $\det(A^T A) \neq 0$.
(20) $(A^T A)^k$ is an identity matrix for some integer $k \geq 1$.

(a) List all properties that A *must* have if A is invertible.
(b) List all properties that imply by themselves that A is invertible.
(c) List all properties that imply A is invertible if we *also* assume A is square ($m = n$).

(d) Compute the inverse of $A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 & 4 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 2 & 2 & 0 & 0 \\ 4 & 4 & 4 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$.

Solution. **(a)** All of $1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 10, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19$ (but not $7, 9, 11, 12, 20$). An invertible A is square (1), so it has a pivot in every row and column (2,3); the system $A\vec{x} = \vec{b}$ is solvable, and uniquely so, for every $\vec{b}$ (4,5,6); $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ has only the trivial solution (8, not 7); $\operatorname{Col} A = \mathbb{R}^n$ (10, not 12) and $\operatorname{Nul} A = \{\vec{0}\}$ (13, not 11); the columns are linearly independent (14) and span $\mathbb{R}^n$ (15); $\operatorname{RREF}(A) = I_n$ (16); A has a two-sided inverse $B = A^{-1}$ (17); and $\operatorname{rank}(A) = n = \min\{n, n\}$ (18). For (19), $\det(A^TA) = \det(A^T)\det(A) = (\det A)^2 \neq 0$. Property (20) need not hold: $A = (2)$ is invertible but $(A^TA)^k = 4^k \neq 1$ for all $k \geq 1$. Property (9) never holds, since $\vec{x} = \vec{0}$ always solves $A\vec{x} = \vec{0}$.

(b) Only 5 and 16. Property (5) forces A square: consistency for every $\vec{b}$ gives $m \leq n$, while uniqueness gives $n \leq m$ (linearly independent columns), so $m = n$ and A is invertible. Property (16) forces A square with full rank, hence invertible. Every other property is satisfied by some non-square matrix; e.g. $A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$ has a pivot in every row (2), spans $\mathbb{R}^1$ (10, 15) and has $\det(A^TA) = 1 \neq 0$ (19), yet is not invertible.

(c) All except $1, 7, 9, 11, 12$; i.e. $2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 10, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20$. Once A is square, each of these forces full rank: for (19), $\det(A^TA) = (\det A)^2$, so $\det(A^TA) \neq 0 \Rightarrow \det A \neq 0$; for (20), $(A^TA)^k = I$ makes A^TA invertible, hence A invertible, with $A^{-1} = (A^TA)^{k-1}A^T$.

(d) Reduce $(A \mid I_4)$: subtract row 1 from row 4, subtract twice row 3 from row 4, subtract twice row 2 from row 3, rearrange the rows into order $1, 2, 3, 4$, then divide row 2 by 2, row 3 by 4 and row 4 by 4. This gives $\operatorname{RREF}(A) = I_4$ (so A is invertible) and

$$A^{-1} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 & \frac{1}{2} & 0 \\ -\frac{1}{4} & 0 & -\frac{1}{2} & \frac{1}{4} \\ \frac{1}{4} & 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Clever trick: A^TA and the non-square traps

For square A, $\det(A^TA) = (\det A)^2$, so $\det(A^TA) \neq 0 \iff \det A \neq 0$. For a non-square A, most "invertibility-like" properties only pin down one inequality ($m \leq n$ for spanning/onto, $n \leq m$ for linear independence), so they cannot guarantee invertibility; only a property forcing $m = n$ *and* full rank (such as 5, or $\operatorname{RREF}(A) = I$) does.

6.9 Computing Determinants

Algorithm 1: Row Reduction

Row reduction algorithm for $\det A$

1. Set `denom` $= 1$.
2. Row reduce A to echelon form E (upper-triangular suffices). Update `denom`:
   - Row swap: `denom` $\leftarrow -$`denom`.
   - Scale row by $\lambda \neq 0$: `denom` $\leftarrow \lambda \cdot$ `denom`.

- Row replacement: no change to `denom`.

3. $\det E =$ product of diagonal entries of E.
4. $\det A = \dfrac{\det E}{\texttt{denom}}$.

Powers, polynomial identities, and the all-ones matrix

- *Powers:* $A^0 = I$ and $A^p A^q = A^{p+q}$; all powers of one matrix commute, so a polynomial identity in A may be manipulated like ordinary algebra.
- *Inverse from a polynomial identity:* if $A^2 = bI + cA$ with $b \neq 0$, then $A(A - cI) = bI$ and $A^{-1} = \dfrac{1}{b}(A - cI)$. More generally, $A^s + c_{s-1}A^{s-1} + \cdots + c_1 A + c_0 I = 0$ with $c_0 \neq 0$ gives $A \cdot \left[-\dfrac{1}{c_0}\left(A^{s-1} + \cdots + c_1 I\right)\right] = I$.
- *All-ones matrix:* if J is the $n \times n$ matrix all of whose entries equal 1, then $J^2 = nJ$ (each entry of J^2 is a sum of n ones), $\operatorname{rank} J = 1$, $J\vec{x} = \left(\sum_i x_i\right)\vec{1}$, and $\operatorname{Nul} J = \{\vec{x} : \sum_i x_i = 0\}$ has dimension $n - 1$.
- *Effect of row operations on* det*:* row replacement leaves det unchanged, a row swap negates it, and scaling a row by λ multiplies it by λ; the determinant of a triangular matrix is the product of its diagonal entries.

Midterm 2021 Problem 7 (0 on the diagonal, 1 elsewhere)

Problem. Let $n \geq 2$ be an integer and let A be the $n \times n$ matrix with 0's on the main diagonal and 1's everywhere else (for $n = 4$, every off-diagonal entry is 1). Let $I = I_n$. (a) Find numbers b and c (depending on n) such that $A^2 = bI + cA$. (b) Compute a formula for the inverse of A. (c) Compute a formula for $\det A$.

Solution (a). Write J for the $n \times n$ all-ones matrix, so that

$$A = J - I.$$

Since $J^2 = nJ$,

$$\begin{aligned} A^2 &= (J - I)^2 = J^2 - 2J + I = nJ - 2J + I \\ &= (n-2)J + I = (n-2)(A + I) + I = (n-2)A + (n-1)I. \end{aligned}$$

Hence $b = n - 1$ and $c = n - 2$.

Entry check. The diagonal entries of A^2 are $\sum_{k \neq i} A_{ik}A_{ki} = n-1$ (there are $n-1$ nonzero terms, each equal to 1). For $i \neq j$, $(A^2)_{ij} = \sum_k A_{ik}A_{kj}$, where the terms with $k = i$ or $k = j$ vanish, leaving $n - 2$ terms equal to 1. Thus $A^2 = (n-1)I + (n-2)A$, as claimed.

Solution (b). By (a), $A^2 - (n-2)A = (n-1)I$, i.e.

$$A\big(A - (n-2)I\big) = (n-1)I.$$

Since $n \geq 2$, we have $n - 1 \neq 0$, so

$$A \cdot \frac{1}{n-1}\big(A - (n-2)I\big) = I.$$

As A is square, a one-sided inverse is the two-sided inverse, hence

$$A^{-1} = \frac{1}{n-1}\big(A-(n-2)I\big) = \frac{1}{n-1}A + \frac{2-n}{n-1}I.$$

Check: $A\cdot\frac{1}{n-1}\big(A-(n-2)I\big) = \frac{1}{n-1}\big(A^2-(n-2)A\big) = \frac{(n-1)I}{n-1} = I$. So A^{-1} has all diagonal entries $\frac{2-n}{n-1}$ and all off-diagonal entries $\frac{1}{n-1}$. For $n=2$, $A=\begin{pmatrix}0&1\\1&0\end{pmatrix}$ and the formula gives $A^{-1}=A$, as expected.

Solution (c). Use only determinant-preserving row replacements, so det never changes.

Step 1: replace row 1 by the sum of all n rows. Every entry of the new first row equals $0+\underbrace{1+\cdots+1}_{n-1} = n-1$; the other rows are unchanged.

Step 2: for $i=2,\dots,n$, subtract $\frac{1}{n-1}$ times the new row 1 from row i. In row i the entry in column i becomes $0-\frac{n-1}{n-1} = -1$, and every other entry becomes $1-1=0$. The result is

$$\begin{pmatrix} n-1 & n-1 & \cdots & n-1 \\ 0 & -1 & & 0 \\ \vdots & & \ddots & \\ 0 & & & -1 \end{pmatrix},$$

which is triangular. Therefore

$$\det A = (n-1)(-1)^{n-1}.$$

Checks: $n=2$ gives -1 (indeed $\det\begin{pmatrix}0&1\\1&0\end{pmatrix}=-1$), $n=3$ gives 2, $n=4$ gives -3. Since $n-1\neq 0$, $\det A\neq 0$, consistent with the invertibility established in (b). (Equivalently, A has eigenvalues $n-1$ and -1 with multiplicity $n-1$, whose product is $(n-1)(-1)^{n-1}$.)

Clever trick: recognize $A = J - I$

Once A is written as "all-ones matrix minus I", both questions collapse: $J^2 = nJ$ gives the polynomial identity $A^2 = (n-2)A + (n-1)I$, which produces A^{-1} by pure algebra with no row reduction; and for the determinant, adding all rows to the first row and then clearing below it gives a triangular matrix in two determinant-preserving steps. The same computation shows A is invertible for every $n \geq 2$.

Algorithm 2: Cofactor Expansion

Definition. Let $A_{(i,j)}$ be the submatrix formed by deleting row i and column j from A.

Cofactor expansion

Theorem. For an $n\times n$ matrix A with entry a_{ij} in row i, column j:

$$\det A = a_{11}\det A_{(1,1)} - a_{12}\det A_{(1,2)} + a_{13}\det A_{(1,3)} - \cdots + (-1)^{1+n}a_{1n}\det A_{(1,n)}$$

$$\det A = a_{11}\det A_{(1,1)} - a_{21}\det A_{(2,1)} + a_{31}\det A_{(3,1)} - \cdots + (-1)^{n+1}a_{n1}\det A_{(n,1)}$$

(Expansion along the first row and first column, respectively.)

Proof: We prove the row expansion (expansion along the first row); the column expansion follows from $\det A = \det(A^T)$.

Write A with columns $\vec{a}_1, \ldots, \vec{a}_n$. By linearity of det in the first column, write $\vec{a}_1 = a_{11}\vec{e}_1 + a_{21}\vec{e}_2 + \cdots + a_{n1}\vec{e}_n$. Then

$$\det A = \sum_{i=1}^{n} a_{i1} \det \begin{pmatrix} \vec{e}_i & \vec{a}_2 & \cdots & \vec{a}_n \end{pmatrix}.$$

Let $M_i = \begin{pmatrix} \vec{e}_i & \vec{a}_2 & \cdots & \vec{a}_n \end{pmatrix}$. We compute $\det M_i$.

In M_i, the first column is $\vec{e}_i$. If $i \neq 1$, swap row 1 with row i (using $i-1$ adjacent row swaps) to move the 1 to the top-left corner. Each swap multiplies det by -1, so $\det M_i = (-1)^{i-1} \det M_i'$ where M_i' has first column $\vec{e}_1$ and the other columns are $\vec{a}_2, \ldots, \vec{a}_n$ (with rows 1 and i swapped). Now in M_i', the first row is $\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \end{pmatrix}$. By the general formula, only the term $X = I_n$ (or X with first column $= \vec{e}_1$) contributes, and the remaining determinant is exactly that of the submatrix $A_{(i,1)}$ (delete row i and column 1 from A, with appropriate relabeling). So $\det M_i' = \det A_{(i,1)}$, giving $\det M_i = (-1)^{i-1} \det A_{(i,1)}$.

Hence $\det A = \sum_{i=1}^{n} a_{i1}(-1)^{i-1} \det A_{(i,1)}$, which is the expansion along column 1:

$$\det A = a_{11} \det A_{(1,1)} - a_{21} \det A_{(2,1)} + a_{31} \det A_{(3,1)} - \cdots + (-1)^{n+1} a_{n1} \det A_{(n,1)}.$$

For expansion along the first row: apply the column expansion to A^T (whose first column is the first row of A), then use $\det A = \det(A^T)$:

$$\det A = \det(A^T) = \sum_{j=1}^{n} a_{1j}(-1)^{j-1} \det(A^T)_{(j,1)} = \sum_{j=1}^{n} (-1)^{j+1} a_{1j} \det A_{(1,j)},$$

since $(A^T)_{(j,1)} = (A_{(1,j)})^T$ and $\det(A_{(1,j)})^T = \det A_{(1,j)}$. ■

When to use which algorithm

- Row reduction: efficient for general matrices, especially $n > 3$.
- Cofactor expansion: useful when A has many zero entries (few terms) or $n \leq 3$.

Example. For $n = 3$:

$$\begin{aligned} \det \begin{pmatrix} a & b & c \\ d & e & f \\ g & h & i \end{pmatrix} &= a \det \begin{pmatrix} e & f \\ h & i \end{pmatrix} - b \det \begin{pmatrix} d & f \\ g & i \end{pmatrix} + c \det \begin{pmatrix} d & e \\ g & h \end{pmatrix} \\ &= a(ei - fh) - b(di - fg) + c(dh - eg). \end{aligned}$$

Summary of determinant properties

- $\det I_n = 1$.
- $\det A = \det(A^T)$.
- $\det(AB) = (\det A)(\det B)$.
- A invertible $\Leftrightarrow \det A \neq 0$.
- If A is triangular, $\det A =$ product of diagonal entries.
- $(A^{-1})^{-1} = A$; $(AB)^{-1} = B^{-1}A^{-1}$; $(A^T)^{-1} = (A^{-1})^T$.